

La Cuisinière Bourgeoise

or The Subtle Charm of Bourgeois Flavors

Tim Dubrovsky

04.21.2026

The bourgeois household — the kind with a cook, a maid, and a quietly humming domestic engine — is gone. Whatever fantasy we once had of living like Nero Wolfe, ordering lunch from the next room, has evaporated. At some point you understand that if anything is going to get cooked in your kitchen, it'll be your own hands doing it. The realization arrives gradually, sometime after you've earned a PhD, secured your own lab, and half a dozen people call you "boss." Or after the business you built has finally freed you from twenty years spent scrambling up the greasy pole of a biotech giant. Or perhaps the investments have matured, the houses have been built, and the kids are growing tall.

Yet sometimes — usually under a full moon — a strange dream steals toward your pillow. You are standing on a high embankment late at night, watching a ship drift past in silence. Somehow, you've missed it. The people on board sit at tables just an arm's length away, on a low, glowing deck. You hear the silverware, the waiters' footsteps, the hum of conversation — but not the meaning of a single word. You toss and turn, trying to assemble whole sentences from the fragments drifting toward you like faint, slippery fish.

I think the first time I saw that departing ship was on a little girl's birthday in Normandy. I'd stopped for the night at a tiny snail farm somewhere in the fields between Rouen and that improbable sky-castle, Mont-Saint-Michel, which rises straight out of the sea into the clouds. The entire second floor of the guesthouse was mine: a bottle of cold wine with a label scrawled in pencil, a wicker basket of warm bread. Through the open window I could see a table draped in a rustic striped cloth and a cast-iron stove by the wall. Neighbors from a nearby vineyard had brought homemade cheese and tall, frosted bottles. The stout hostess stood outside, tending to a pan of escargots. A thick, nutty perfume — butter foaming with herbs and garlic and something else I couldn't name — drifted in from the dark garden, mingling with adult chatter and the bursts of laughter from children gathered for the celebration. I perched on the windowsill, pulled the cork from a bottle of *rosé* with my teeth, and didn't stop until only a couple of swallows remained. What wine were they drinking at that table outside? And could anyone bake such bread at home? And for that matter — how on earth are vineyard snails actually prepared?

Another glimpse came on a Sunday morning at Les Halles de Lyon *Paul Bocuse*. The market sits on Lafayette Street, just above where the Saône folds into the Rhône, green water mixing with black. People moved in a slow, purposeful tide past the slick, shimmering glass counters where the day's catch waits on ice. The gleaming glass cases holding mysterious birds, still asleep inside their iridescent feathers, the fish glisten and the cuts of meat blush pink. Men followed lists from home, filling rolling bags with precision. Women debated with

clerks in crisp white aprons. Everyone there seemed to know exactly what dinner would be, and in their eyes — even the clerks' — lived a calm, effortless confidence. I bought shrimp with a faint green sheen, armored like Roland's knights caught off guard in the Roncevaux Pass, grabbed a baguette, still warm, and walked home. That was twenty years ago, and that's when I began — quietly, tentatively — looking for the pier, asking about the schedule, trying to figure out how to be there when the ship returned.

Meanwhile, in the sleepy towns of Northern California, strung along the edge of the cold Pacific under a blanket of flannel-gray sky, food is something people take lightly. In autumn the sidewalks are littered with olives no one bothers to collect. Grocery-store tomatoes taste like greenhouse plastic because, well, they are greenhouse plastic. Sure, you can buy live crabs or fresh fish, or grow your own figs, plums, and eggplants. But fewer people know what to do with that abundance.

So, let's begin with small, bright, easy pieces — dishes gathered from all corners of the world — things you can cook for yourself or for guests. They're the sort of meals that save you when you can't face another sad cardboard takeout, and when places like Keller's French Laundry or Bouchon in Napa feel too far away, too expensive, or simply too much for the day you're having. If you find that cooking sticks — that you actually like doing it — then we'll go further: toward the quiet depth of umami, toward *pot-au-feu*, toward the crisp architecture of Persian *tahdig*. Don't worry; nothing here is for sale. You won't suffer through poorly translated French recipes or pathetic photos resembling the fake fireplace in Papa Carlo's room. I'm just offering a map — a path leading from simple seared meat to complex soups to honest oven-baked pizza. One narrow trail that winds past warm pens, shiny tin feed buckets, and soda fountains — a trail leading you toward independence, maybe even freedom...

Along the way I'll show you marsala, galangal, saffron, oyster sauce — flavors that detonate instantly in a kitchen, reshaping everything from taste to smell. We'll talk about why consommé matters, and how to roast an octopus without fear. We'll talk wine. We'll learn a dozen mother sauces named for people long gone. And then maybe — not right away, but eventually — you'll buy a big dining table. The kind people naturally gather around. The kind that makes women drift toward the kitchen in the evening and sends friends wandering into your house without knocking. Children and dogs will find their way to it. Later, grandchildren. There's something especially good about sitting together over shrimp and farfalle and a bottle of rosé, talking about diving in the Yasawa Islands north of Fiji or eating bonito sashimi on Bunaken, tucked beside the northern claw of Sulawesi.

And maybe — who knows — you'll even manage to forget your phones, or whatever replaces them, for a couple of hours, and actually look one another in the eye. Which, when you think about it, is the whole point of cooking at home.

The Magnificent Seven

Think of these seven dishes as little bursts of kitchen fireworks—quick, joyful flashes of flavor that vanish almost as soon as you realize you’re smiling like a child. They ask for almost nothing from you (well, one or two may beg a tiny indulgence, but let’s not spoil the magic). A sharp knife, honest ingredients, a wide pan, a ribbon of oil, and half an hour from your day — that’s it. Suddenly dinner is transformed, and the whole evening lifts with it.

Salmon with Garlic and *Marsala*

Here’s what you need: **three fat, confident pieces of salmon, a fistful of garlic, and a small cup of *Marsala*** — no need to be fancy, but don’t drown the fish in it either. These days all our salmon comes frozen from Alaska or Norway. Thaw it right, and the flesh stays firm, almost springy, like it’s still making promises.

If yours comes with the skin on, just trim it off and cut the fish into palm-sized pieces, about an inch thick. Pat everything dry and go bone-hunting — you always forget one.

Slice half a head of garlic into unapologetically big pieces. Heat a generous glug of oil in a nonstick pan until it’s practically shimmering with ambition. Drop in the salmon and all that garlic. While the bottoms are searing over high heat, sprinkle the tops with salt and a touch more sugar than your conscience wants to admit (a half teaspoon each).

Three minutes later, when the fish develops the kind of golden crust that makes you feel like you actually know what you’re doing, flip it. Give it another three minutes.

Turn the heat down. Pour in the *Marsala* — carefully, because wine fumes are dramatic and not above spontaneous combustion. Let it bubble down by half, which happens fast, and that’s your cue: serve immediately, with pride.

Important: You want the fish browned on the outside and ruby-red inside. Yes, red. Yes, on purpose.

PS: Sashimi Lunch Hack

Got a couple of raw extra pieces? Lucky you. Tomorrow’s lunch just upgraded itself.

Mix half a tablespoon each of salt and sugar, add two tablespoons of vodka or brandy, and rub this over the raw salmon in a container. Seal and refrigerate overnight.

In the morning, dry it off, slice it beautifully — yes, you can do “beautifully” — and there you have it: DIY sashimi that tastes like you meant to plan ahead.

Important: There’s a soy-based dipping sauce with aromatic oil later in the book. It’s the kind of thing that makes coworkers notice you’re suddenly “interesting.”

Farfalle with Shrimp and *Marsala*

Thaw a **dozen big shrimp** — head-on, because you're an adult and flavor matters. You can snip off the whiskers and that sharp little forehead spike, but do *not* remove the heads. Shrimp heads are basically concentrated joy disguised as marine architecture.

Heat a good layer of oil in a big skillet until it's properly hot, then lay in the shrimp in a single, proud layer. Once they turn neon orange underneath, flip them. Sprinkle with salt and sugar (a half teaspoon each), then pour in a cup of *Marsala*, again treating open flames with the respect they deserve.

When the wine starts bubbling everywhere like it has opinions, flip the shrimp again and immediately lift them onto plates. Leave the sauce in the pan — that's liquid gold.

Meanwhile, cook **half a box of farfalle** in salted water until just shy of *al dente*. Drain, toss the pasta straight into the skillet with the shrimp sauce, crank the heat, and stir like you're convincing the pasta to absorb life's meaning.

Two minutes later, serve. Ideally before you have time to second-guess yourself.

Important: High heat. Plenty of oil. Farfalle should be *barely* cooked — they'll finish in the sauce. No farfalle? Use penne. Overcook them and you lose your pasta privileges.

Pan-Seared Meat and the Magic of Galangal

Get a heavy cast iron skillet. Heat it until your doubts evaporate. Sear thick Costco steaks, finish in the oven.

If you want to cook steak properly at home, the first thing you need isn't the steak. It's a skillet — heavy, unapologetically thick, the kind of thing that could double as a blunt weapon in a medieval tavern. Cast iron, pre-seasoned, cheap on Amazon. You can splurge on *Le Creuset* or *Staub* later, after you fall in love with making steaks indoors like a civilized barbarian. Oh, and while you're at it, get yourself a long-probe meat thermometer. It's basically a cheat code.

Now head to Costco and grab steaks at least an inch thick. What cut? Pick something substantial — something with character. A good ribeye that's marbled like winter branches. A filet mignon if you want a guaranteed victory. Thick, well-aged pieces with thin seams of fat running through them—the kind that melt and drip down into your skillet and turn into half of the flavor. The other half comes from the *Maillard reaction*, that beautiful, ancient bit of kitchen alchemy where heat, sugars and amino acids decide to collaborate. Your goal is simple: build a browned crust on the outside and trap all the juices inside. Think of it as sealing a love letter.

Pat the steak dry — really dry — oil it lightly, salt it boldly. Heat your cast-iron skillet for 6–8 minutes until it's hot enough to scare away your self-doubt. Sear the meat 2–3 minutes per side. Then put the steak on a metal tray covered with aluminum foil and slide it into a 400°F (204°C) oven for 10–15 minutes. Check the temperature with your probe thermometer because guessing is for your past life.

130–140°F (54–60°C) = medium rare. 160°F (71°C) = medium.

Exactly where you land depends on who you are as a person. Let the steak rest under foil for 5–10 minutes. This is not optional. Resting is how the meat forgives you for all the heat and chaos.

PS: Other Cuts, Same Happiness

Loin? Great. T-bone? Romantic even, if you're into anatomy. Sirloin? A bit firmer, a little less indulgent, but trustworthy. But here's a plot twist: one of my favorite "budget" cuts is the Tri-Tip. It comes as a triangular slab, slightly tough, slightly rebellious, exactly the kind of cut that rewards patience and confidence.

And Tri-Tip loves galangal. Yes, galangal — the aristocratic cousin of ginger that Thai soups whisper about. It's sharp, floral, almost citrusy, like ginger that grew up abroad and came back with opinions.

Slice off excess fat from the Tri-Tip, cut it into thick steaks, pound them gently under plastic wrap — just enough to get their attention. Heat the cast iron again, no oil this time. Dry the steaks thoroughly (overnight in paper towels is ideal), salt them, lightly oil them, and sear on high heat. Wear gloves unless you enjoy the sting of flying fat droplets. Give each side 2–3 minutes per flip, with several flips in total, until they develop a rugged golden crust. Then sear the edges by holding the steaks with tongs and rolling them along the hot surface like you're branding time itself. If the centers are still too raw — and Tri-Tip loves pretending it's invincible — move the steaks to a foil-lined tray and finish them in a 360°F (180°C) oven for 8–10 minutes.

Now the magic: a pat of soft butter mixed with coarsely grated galangal. Galangal gives the meat a silky, aromatic kick — gentle but unmistakable. Freeze the butter in little logs wrapped in plastic, and you'll always have flavor insurance at hand.

Let the steaks rest 3–5 minutes, tented under foil. Then pour yourself a glass of something bold — Rodney Strong *Cabernet Sauvignon* from Sonoma Valley, or Field Stone *Petite Sirah* from Alexander Valley — and enjoy the moment you've earned.

Important: Always check doneness with a probe thermometer. Around 140°F inside is your sweet spot.

Crabs with Garlic and Marsala

Two live Dungeness crabs. A moment of honesty with nature. A hot pan, garlic, Marsala, a five-minute simmer. This one comes from a Chinese chef at *Crustacean* in San Francisco, and I owe that man a lifetime of gratitude (though my version skips the heavy fat and the cayenne inferno).

Pick up **two big Dungeness crabs** — alive, right out of the tank at Ranch 99. You'll need thick gloves, a steady hand, and a willingness to acknowledge that eating animals is not a metaphor. Place the crab belly-down in the sink. Hold its left legs and claw down with your left hand. Grip the shell with your right and yank upward sharply. Remove the shell, toss the gills (they look like tiny tangerine palm fronds), and keep the rest — the armored belly with legs and claws.

Split the crab in half with a heavy knife. Then split each half into two pieces: two legs + a bit of body, and two legs + a claw. Four pieces per crab. Yes, it looks messy. Yes, our ancestors did this too. This is how humans left the trees and got a Michelin star.

Now the easy part.

Heat half a centimeter of oil in a deep skillet or small Dutch oven. Add all the crab pieces and **5–10 crushed garlic cloves**. Cover with a lid to stop the oil from attempting piracy, and fry on high heat for 4–6 minutes. Remove the lid, flip the crab quarters, sprinkle with a teaspoon each of salt and sugar, then pour in **a cup of Marsala**. Cover again and simmer for 5 minutes on medium. Serve immediately, ideally to someone who won't mind watching you dismantle a crustacean like a victorious deity.

Chicken in Oyster Sauce with Olives

Fried chicken — how many ways can you reinvent it? Apparently, at least one more.

Here's a scenario. You're driving down I-5, heading to LA. Long day, long road, long stretches of culinary despair. Roadside food is a gamble: you might get indigestion, or you might get a morality tale about turning into a goat. (Russian fairy tales warned us for a reason.) So, pack your own dinner: **ten skinless chicken legs** (5 thighs, 5 drumsticks) in a plastic container, drenched in a cup of Lee Kum Kee oyster sauce. Toss the container into the car along with a portable gas burner, a big nonstick pan, **a jar of olives, some oil, and Marsala**.

At your hotel, heat the oil, lay the marinated chicken into the skillet, and fry low and slow—20 minutes per side. If it spits too much, press a loose-fitting lid or a small plate over the top like an improvised shield. When the chicken is almost done, add olives (black or green, pits in), pour in a small cup of Marsala, and cook until two-thirds of the wine evaporates.

Eat with your hands, sitting on the hotel bed, sharing the skillet, a glass of rosé nearby, bad TV murmuring in the background. Domestic bliss in a disposable setting.

Important: Don't salt the chicken — oyster sauce already has more than enough. And remove the skin before marinating; it ruins the texture.

PS: Crispy Oyster-Sauce Chicken (Same Ingredients, Whole New Attitude)

Okay, so you've got this batch of chicken soaking in oyster sauce, right? Before you toss it all into the pan, pull out three thighs and stash them in the fridge. Tomorrow, they'll transform into something else entirely — something crisp, golden, and child-approved.

Here's how the magic works.

Wipe off every last trace of oyster sauce with paper towels until the chicken feels like it's wearing a new identity. Split each thigh, remove the bone with a small knife, and flatten the pieces out like tiny edible throw pillows. Dust them in corn starch — no egg, no breadcrumbs, just starch — and fry them over medium heat in a couple tablespoons of hot oil. Flip them three times or so. About 15 minutes total. The crust will turn shatteringly crisp, the kind that makes even picky kids stop mid-whine. Adults quietly reevaluate their life choices. The next recipe — Viennese schnitzel — uses the same basic idea (thin cutlets, quick fry), but adds the panache of breading. Think of this one as the gateway drug.

A Simple Viennese Schnitzel

If you've got chicken breast or turkey breast, perfect. If you have pork tenderloin — congratulations, you're about to level up.

Place the meat between two layers of plastic wrap and pound it gently with the flat side of a mallet... or the bottom of a heavy skillet. Go for a thickness of about a centimeter. If it's pork tenderloin, split the cylinder into two pieces and pound each one with the *ridged* side of the mallet — go ahead, show some authority. Salt lightly.

Beat 2–3 eggs in a bowl. In another dish, pour in fine breadcrumbs or panko (the Korean/Japanese kind that fries up like a dream). Dunk the flattened meat in the egg wash, then press it firmly into the breadcrumbs. Press like you mean it.

Heat about a centimeter of oil in a large skillet until it shimmers, then lay in the schnitzel. Fry until beautifully golden—4–5 minutes per side, give or take. The result will be something delightfully retro, like the good kind of diner food, but elevated and crisp in all the right places.

Serve with peach or apricot slices lightly glossed with a spoonful of honey mixed with white wine. Yes, fruit. Yes, it works.

Duck Breast: Confit or Steak? Why Choose?

Duck breast is one of those rare ingredients that forgives your indecision. Whether you like your meat blushing in the center or fully cooked for the faint of heart, duck plays along.

Let's start with the French approach — slow, gentle, silky — then flip the world upside down and sear it like a steak.

Duck Breast, Confit-Style (with a Quiet Nod to Oyster Sauce)

Grab **six duck breasts** — Muscovy if you can find them; they're larger and more muscular. Score the skin in a crosshatch pattern, being careful not to cut into the meat. Scoring isn't just aesthetics; it's a tiny architectural trick that lets the fat render out properly.

Put the breasts in a bowl with **half a cup of oyster sauce** and a **splash of brandy or vodka**. Let them sit for four hours at room temperature, absorbing the marinade like it's their purpose in life.

When time's up, wipe the duck dry — skin and all. Place the breasts skin-side down in a cold nonstick skillet. No oil. Turn the heat to low and let the magic unfold slowly. The fat will render, the skin will gradually caramelize, and your kitchen will begin to smell like a culinary promise kept.

Fifteen to twenty minutes later, when the skin is a glorious shade of caramel, flip the breasts and sear the other side for a minute or two.

Transfer everything to a foil-lined tray, skin-side up, and bake at 360°F (180°C) for 6–9 minutes. The internal temp should reach around 160°F (71°C). That's fully cooked duck—soft, tender, sliceable, child-safe.

Serve as-is, or drizzle with quick orange sauce: reduce the juice of two oranges with a teaspoon of brown sugar, a tablespoon of butter, and a few strips of zest. Add salt and a splash of brandy. A pinch of saffron if you're feeling poetic.

Duck Breast, Steak-Style (A Little Wild, A Lot Worth It)

Now let's go the other way. Score the skin as before. Heat a heavy cast-iron skillet until it's the temperature of a difficult conversation. Dry the duck thoroughly and salt it generously — about half a teaspoon for four breasts.

Lay the breasts skin-side down on the scorching-hot pan. The fat will render fast, sizzling and sputtering like angry applause. Give them 5–6 minutes until the skin is crisp and golden. Flip, and sear the meat side for a couple more minutes.

Mix three tablespoons of honey with a tablespoon of balsamic (or apple cider vinegar if that's what you've got). Brush the duck with the honey glaze like you're decorating a masterpiece.

Transfer to a 450°F (232°C) oven for 6–7 minutes. Rest for five minutes. Slice thinly.

Inside, the meat should be vividly red, like a steak that's flirting with you. Outside, it's lacquered with honeyed caramel.

The internal temperature should land around 140°F (60°C). Perfection.

Serve it with slices of Chinese *Hami melon* or ripe peaches drizzled with honey cut with a little Cointreau or any of your *Homemade Infusions*.

Important: Please — *please* — peel the peaches and remove the rind from the melon. It's not optional. It's respect.

How to Serve All This Without Losing Your Mind

Shrimp and farfalle pasta? That's a weeknight no-brainer — toss them together like the civilized hedonist you secretly pride yourself on being. Chicken? Eat it straight from the skillet with someone you actually like. Ideally someone you can share a quiet kitchen with, the kind where silence feels like a soft blanket, not a social failure. But meat and crab... those ask for a little theater. Not the stiff, over-ironed kind — just enough ritual to say: *I care. I'm paying attention. This is worth doing well.* A small ceremony of intention, nothing more — and absolutely nothing less.

With Properly Fried Potatoes

Potatoes are simple — until they aren't. There's an entire universe between “crispy golden bliss” and “sad, oily mush.” We want the former. Always.

Take **3–4 potatoes**. Peel them, cut them into sticks — not shoestring-thin, not steak-fries-thick. Now the critical step: **dry them**. Paper towels, clean cloth, whatever. Just get the moisture off. Wet potatoes are the enemy of crispness.

Heat a respectable layer of oil in a large nonstick skillet. Enough to coat the bottom generously. Lay the potatoes in a single layer. (Single. Layer. This is not a crowd scene.)

Fry over high heat for about five minutes. Stir once — just once — then add half a sliced white onion. Turn the heat to medium and let everything cook together, occasionally giving it a gentle nudge. Keyword: *occasionally*. This is potatoes, not oatmeal. They need space to crisp.

Salt only when they're done. Salt too early and you'll pull out moisture, which brings sadness. Serve immediately. Fried potatoes have the lifespan of a soap bubble.

Important: Dry potatoes = crispy potatoes. Moisture is betrayal.

With a Persian Yogurt-Cucumber Salad (Saffron Included)

If I didn't *know for a fact* this salad has Persian roots, I'd assume it was invented by the Spartans. Remember Leonidas, the king of Sparta — the one who held that narrow coastal pass at Thermopylae with three hundred of his personal guard and a few thousand Boeotians who decided to tag along? When Xerxes, the Persian *shahanshah*, politely suggested they lay down their weapons and step aside, Leonidas just shrugged and said, "Come and take them."

And here you are, asked to do something far less heroic: mix half a liter of thick, full-fat yogurt — or a good, pourable sour cream — with half a dozen finely chopped cucumbers, the juice of half a lemon, and a couple tablespoons of minced dill or cilantro. With dill it's straightforward; with cilantro, be civilized about it: wash the bundle thoroughly to shake off every last grain of sand, then pinch off the tiny leaves with your fingers instead of chopping.

Now — and this is important — once everything is in the bowl, scatter a small pinch of real Iranian saffron (*Mehr*, obviously) across the top. Do *not* stir. Let it sit for twenty minutes while people talk, sip wine, and pretend to be effortlessly charming. Around each stigma of *Crocus sativus*, a ragged, bright-orange halo will slowly bloom, and your guests won't forget it anytime soon.

One last thing: use good, firm, small cucumbers — not those one-dollar-per-yard monsters. And please, for the love of all that is crisp and green, rinse your herbs properly in a bowl of water until every grain of sand surrenders and sinks.

With a Tomato Salad

First things first: give that giant bundle of cilantro a proper bath — two, maybe three rinses in a bowl of water until every last grain of sand admits defeat. Then pluck the leaves off with your fingers. Just the leaves. No stems. Stems are where good intentions go to die. You only need a small handful anyway. Next, get yourself some real tomatoes — the kind grown here in California or over in Mexico, in actual soil, under actual sun. If you've got big red or yellow ones, perfect. Grab three or four, blanch them quickly, peel off the skin, carve out the pale, flavorless core, and slice the rest into medium wedges. No decent tomatoes today? Make another salad. Seriously. Or go with cherry tomatoes — about 300 grams — but wash them with soap, rinse well, and cut them in half.

Half a white onion gets peeled, sliced paper-thin, and soaked for an hour in diluted apple cider vinegar or a splash of white wine. But if you've invited a woman to dinner, forget about the onion altogether. You can't seriously imagine the heroine of *Bunin's "Light*

Breathing” sitting there after a salad loaded with raw onion... Add purple basil instead — a dozen leaves or so — plus a handful of wrinkled, oil-cured Turkish black olives with the pits removed.

For the dressing, make a French-style mix:

- 2 tbsp honey or 3 tbsp brown sugar
- 2 tbsp balsamic vinegar
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 3 tbsp olive oil

Whisk until smooth. Dress the salad right before serving. Acids are impatient and will destroy your herbs if left alone with them.

Important: Serve this in small individual bowls. You don’t want a gorgeous woman chasing dressing around her plate and splattering it onto her dress. Bowls are civilized. Bowls save evenings.

With Quick Appetizers of Caviar and Tapenade

Let’s grab a cup of good black olives — Koreana Plaza sells excellent dry black olives from Turkey. Remove the pits and blitz them in a blender with half a cup of capers (pick the bigger ones and drain the vinegar) and half a cup of anchovies in oil. This mix is one of the old Roman cousins of garum, mentioned as far back as *Cato the Elder*. Serve it with good fresh bread. I know, I know — bread is a tragedy around here. But in place of crisp French baguettes, you can take a nice ciabatta and toast it — either in the toaster or lightly in a skillet with a drop of oil.

And if you still can’t find decent bread, here’s a slightly tweaked tapenade recipe from a chef named *Charles Meynier* of Provence, who in the 1880s was serving it proudly at his restaurant in little cups made of egg whites.

Quickly gather from the pantry:

- Large capers (200 g)
- Dry-ish pitted black olives (200 g)
- A jar of anchovy fillets in oil (60–80 g)
- A can of tuna in oil or its own juices (100 g)
- Hard-boiled eggs (15 pcs. Bring to a boil, turn off the heat, cover, and let sit 6–7 minutes.)
- Olive oil (4–5 tbsp)
- A shot of cognac or vodka

The mixture's name — tapenade — comes from the old Provençal word *tapenas*, meaning capers. Preparation is fast and easy. Pulse the capers, olives, anchovies, and tuna in a blender just enough to make a rough paste. Add the shot of cognac and enough olive oil to turn it into a workable, spoonable spread.

Slice the hard-boiled eggs in half and remove the yolks. Fill 20 of the egg-white “cups” with tapenade, and the remaining 10 with good red caviar. All that's left is to arrange them beautifully on a platter of slightly faded rosy *Kuznetsov's* porcelain from our China cabinet: black, black — red!

And What Wine Do You Pour with All This?

Your everyday, easygoing choice is rosé. It's born when red grapes aren't pressed right away but left to rest for a couple of days in tall steel tanks, chilled and unbothered. For rosé, winemakers collect only the first juice that seeps out of grapes cracked under their own weight, then ferment it at about 18°C. This is the wine Provence swears by — you've probably heard of *Bandol*. A classic Provençal rosé is a three-part harmony: about 50% mourvèdre, 25% cinsault, and the remaining quarter grenache.

What you get is a light, bright wine where peaches, nectarines, citrus, and every other fruit you'd expect from a Provençal garden show up to flirt with your palate. But don't think France has a monopoly on charm: the vineyards of Sonoma Valley — practically next door — produce lovely, wonderfully affordable rosé from cabernet and merlot grapes.

Wondering how the whole magic happens? Come closer — I'll tell you...

Saffron

One of the treasured spices of ancient Persian and Indian cooking. It usually shows up alongside luxurious rice varieties like basmati. Saffron is harvested from the stamens of the blue crocus, *Crocus sativus*. Those delicate threads are loaded with a plant glycoside called picrocrocin, and it takes only a small pinch tossed into a large pot to turn the rice golden and wrap it in that unmistakable, tender saffron aroma. And please — never buy saffron in powder form. That's not saffron; that's heartbreak in a jar.

The name of the spice comes from the Persian **za'farān** (زعفران). It first appears in an official Assyrian herbal in the 7th century BCE, during the reign of King Ashurbanipal. But traces of saffron show up even earlier — in Sumerian dyes and remedies — and the beautifully preserved frescoes of crocus-gathering women in the Minoan palace at Akrotiri, on Santorini, are firmly dated to the second millennium BCE.

The best saffron in the world is Iranian — *sargol* or *negin*. You can buy it on Amazon under the label *Mehr Saffron*. Spanish saffron — *coupé* or *Mancha* from La Mancha — is excellent

too. They grow precious varieties in Kashmir as well, in northern India, but personally, I'd stay out of that adventure.

Marsala

A sweet, fortified wine born in Sicily, around the little town of Marsala, made from white grapes like *grillo*, *inzolia*, and *catarratto*. It clocks in at 15–20% alcohol and carries a serious load of sugar — even the driest varieties, *marsala secco*, have over 40 grams per liter. Which is exactly why this wine can transform the flavor of poultry or fish in the final moments of cooking, adding depth and gloss like a last-minute blessing. And yes, the alcohol will evaporate off the pan in a couple of minutes — it's not sticking around.

But serving Marsala as a table wine? Pure nonsense.

Oyster Sauce

This isn't really a sauce at all, but a thick, caramel-colored concentrate that practically begs you to marinate meat or poultry in it. It's one of the great triumphs of Cantonese cooking — a creation so successful it migrated across half of Asia and now shows up in kitchens from Thailand and Indonesia to South Korea. By some clever bit of Chinese culinary sorcery, this substance transforms the flavor and texture of even the oldest, toughest cuts of chicken, pork, or beef. More than that, it seals the cuts and slits in large pieces of meat — a small miracle when roasting or pan-frying. All the juices stay inside, the meat doesn't dry out, and the poultry stays tender. And it works *best* with cuttlefish and squid — but we'll get to that later.

This miracle mix began to be cooked from small oysters on an industrial scale in Canton and Hong Kong in the late 1860s. Around that time, the shoreline filled with British sugar factories processing imported cane, and at first the mixture seems to have been nothing more than oysters, unrefined sugar, and sea salt. Later, of course, everything sped up, and corn starch, soy extract, and the ever-present Chinese MSG joined the party. My advice: in Chinese groceries, buy only the most expensive, reputable brands of this sauce. In the recipes I always specify exactly which ones. And remember: this mixture is *never* served at the table like a regular sauce. It's for cooking, not for pouring.

Caper

A small Mediterranean shrub, *Capparis spinosa*, grows almost everywhere along the shores of the *Mare Nostrum* — as the Romans liked to call it. The salted or pickled flower buds of the plant (the ones hiding in jars labeled “capers”) are used in French and Italian cooking much like olives — tossed into salads or anything that needs a spark of briny personality. The bright green buds usually grow to about 7–10 mm; they have a sharp mustardy aroma and a bright, tangy bite that tastes downright miraculous with real mayonnaise. The plant's unripe fruits — *caper berries* — show up as cocktail snacks. They're larger, around a couple of centimeters long, with little seeds inside and a darker shade than the buds.

One of these evenings, splash a bit of Campari into wide glasses — two lazy fingers' worth — drop in a couple of ice cubes, and serve them to your weary travelers with a small plate of caper berries as an *apéritif* before dinner. To be honest, that's the full extent of my cocktail expertise.

Galangal

It's this very root that gives Thai soups their delicate fragrance and Indonesian chili pastes like *rendang* their spicy, haunting depth. In Thailand it's called **kha** — remember *Tom Kha Gai*? The plant itself, *Alpinia galanga*, is a close cousin of ginger, spreading through long underground *rhizomes* that look like dense, woody tubers. For soups, they slice it into thin coins; for curries, they pound it into paste.

The Dutch first stumbled across galangal on the Indonesian islands of Bali and Flores, caught a whiff, and immediately rushed to plant it across their Southeast Asian colonies. And today, no respectable kitchen from Thailand and Myanmar to the Philippines and the Middle East would dare operate without galangal.

Garum

One of the most common ancient sauces, used in practically every dish of Roman and Greek cooking. The name comes from the Greek **γάρος** (*gáros*), which apparently referred to small fish resembling anchovies. They were fermented, salted, and then packed under oil in clay amphorae. The smell was... let's say, assertive. But it gave otherwise bland porridges and boiled vegetables a depth we'd now recognize as *umami*.

Every civilization found its own path to that flavor. The Chinese and Japanese invented soy sauces and fermented pastes. The Greeks and Romans created *garum*. And in Vietnam, Myanmar, and Thailand, a similar process gave rise to fish sauce, which finds its way into nearly everything short of dessert. Funny enough, you can *see* umami with the naked eye inside great Italian cheeses like *Parmigiano Reggiano* and *Grana Padano*. Remember those tiny white crystals scattered across a cut surface of a massive cheese wheel in a deli case? That's it — pure umami, aka monosodium glutamate. Relax — it's just the sodium salt of an amino acid, one of the basic building blocks of the proteins that make up our bodies. And we're not going to live forever anyway, right? The trick is knowing what you actually want to do with the time you get — and doing just that, without getting distracted by the rustling nonsense around you.

And the next chapter? It's all about what else you can dream up with the power of *umami*.

Japanese Studies in Subtlety: The Quiet Flavor of Umami

Out of the full spectrum of tastes recognized across the world's culinary traditions, I'd probably single out seven: **spicy** (cayenne), **bitter** (Campari Bitter), **sweet** (honey), **salty** (bottarga), **sour** (lime), **fat** (pork belly), and **umami** (miso). You meet six of them every day — I doubt you need two pages of florid prose to explain what “sweet” or “salty” feels like. So let's focus on umami.

The Japanese insist that the most concentrated form of umami lives in miso (みそ). There are countless varieties, usually complex blends made from soybeans, wheat, barley, salt, and the Japanese fermentation starter *kōji* — essentially a thriving colony of the mold *Aspergillus oryzae*. After fermentation, a splash of rice wine is added to kill off the remaining fungi and bacteria, and the paste can then live quietly in your fridge for up to a year.

A distant ancestor of modern miso was invented in China and seems to have reached the Japanese islands with Buddhist monks around the year 600 CE. Back then, it was made from fermented fish, soybeans, and salt. From the Nara period (8th century) through the end of the Kamakura period (13th century), the monastic kitchen revolved around boiled rice, dried fish, miso, and fresh or preserved vegetables — and it was the mashed, fermented mixtures of fish and beans that delivered the essential flavor to an otherwise austere diet. That flavor is what we now call *umami*.

Like Roman garum, miso became the backbone of the Japanese military ration. Just remember: modern Japanese miso no longer contains fish, which is why its aroma is far gentler than the assertive punch of Vietnamese and Thai fish sauces like *nam pla*, or even the ancient garum itself.

Roasted or Pan-Fried Chicken in Miso

To understand how miso really works, start by making something simple: chicken legs. Four will do. In a small saucepan over low heat, whisk together about **100 g of butter**, **150 g of white shiro miso**, **2 tablespoons of honey** (or 3 tablespoons of sugar), and **1 tablespoon of 5% apple cider vinegar**. No vinegar? Fine — squeeze in a spoonful of lemon juice.

Remove the skin from the legs and chop off the lower joint with a heavy knife. The skin can go straight into the trash, but the joints should absolutely go into the freezer — they're pure gold for broth. Separate each leg into drums and thighs, coat them generously with the miso marinade, and leave them on the counter for 3–4 hours at room temperature.

From here you have options. You can simply pan-fry the miso chicken: about 15 minutes per side, with a **half-cup splash of Marsala** near the end so it can sizzle itself into sweetness. Or, if the guests have already arrived, heat the oven to 450°F (230°C), lay the pieces on a foil-lined, buttered baking sheet, and roast them until the tops turn golden — around 40–45 minutes, flipping once. If the crust looks shy and refuses to brown, give the legs a quick kiss under the broiler (5–10 minutes) until they behave.

Now take a bite. That quiet flavor with soft, mushroomy shadows — that's the miso talking. It tastes a little meaty, a little soy-like, but it's not quite meat and not quite soy. It's the Japanese umami, standing politely in the doorway.

And what else can you do with this new flavor and chicken? Plenty. Stir a teaspoon of **mild curry powder** into the miso marinade (the *Rani* brand is excellent). Or radically shift the color of the finished dish by adding a teaspoon of **ground paprika**. One tiny adjustment — and the whole thing changes its mood.

Pan-Fried Shrimp in White Miso

Let's imagine you've discovered, somewhere in the tundra of your freezer, a bag of smallish shrimp tails — the kind that have clearly spent several ice ages in cold storage. They're about the size of your index finger (say, 26–30 per pound), still in their shells, but headless. Which means that when you fry them, all the juices will rush out instantly, leaving you with a sad little curl wearing a brittle suit of armor.

There's nothing noble you can do with freezer-burned shrimp — except fill them with *another* protein and give them the gift of umami. Enter egg white for structure, and white *shiro miso* for salt and savor. Add a little sugar so the albumin distributes evenly inside the frozen flesh. And instead of fussing with slow defrosting, let's thaw them right in a mixture of beaten eggs and white miso. But of course, you must think of this in the morning so that by evening the tails are ready to hit the pan. Then again — what else is The Proper Little Piglet supposed to think about after breakfast, if not dinner?

So: for **1 kilogram of frozen shrimp**, take **3 tablespoons of white shiro miso (130 g)**, **3–4 eggs**, **1 tablespoon of vegetable oil**, and **1 tablespoon of sugar**. Whisk it all together in a wide plastic container until smooth, then dump the frozen shrimp in straight from the freezer. Mix well so every shrimp gets coated. Cover with plastic wrap and leave them to defrost at room temperature until evening.

Come evening, peel the shrimp by hand — shed their chitinous armor — and transfer the tails into a large bowl. Pour in about a cup of the miso-egg mixture they've been resting in; this keeps the peeled shrimp from drying out before breading. Next, pour **150–200 g of breadcrumbs** (Korean *panko* works beautifully) into a deep plate, move the egg-coated shrimp into the crumbs, and toss them together. Let the shrimp sit for 3–4 minutes so the coating can grab hold and form a crust around each tail.

Meanwhile, heat about **1 cup of vegetable oil** in a wide nonstick skillet to **360°F (180°C)**. That's where the breaded shrimp will go — lay them out generously in a single layer. Keep the heat fairly high, but not so high that the coating browns too fast. After about 4 minutes, flip them with a bamboo spatula and check that the underside has turned a handsome golden color. Fry the second side for another 3 minutes, move the shrimp onto paper towels to blot excess oil, and serve.

Important: Heat the oil properly from the start — but don't burn the coating! You can test the temperature with a bamboo spatula: when you dip its broad edge into the oil, a soft beard of tiny bubbles should form. And if you couldn't find breadcrumbs or you simply don't like them — dredge the shrimp in rice flour or plain starch instead. Works like a charm.

Black Cod in White Miso

The beauty of this recipe, invented by chef *Nobu Matsuhisa*, is that it's wonderfully light — but absolutely *not* quick. It takes two to three nights for the miso and sugar to seep into the fish, whose flesh is naturally a bit vague in flavor, and transform it into something denser, silkier, and entirely new. Ideally, you'll find true **black cod** — a gloomy, slippery creature from deep waters — but regular cod will do.

Fillet three large fish, if you bought them whole, or simply buy skin-on fillets at the fish market and cut them into palm-sized pieces. Freeze all leftover heads and backbones — they'll make superb fish stock later.

Two or three days before your planned dinner, take a medium saucepan and combine **50 ml lime juice** (or lemon), **150 ml apple or rice vinegar (5%)**, and **150 ml plain vodka**. Bring the mixture to a boil over medium heat. Now add about **450 g of white shiro miso** (a fist-sized lump) and stir it in with a wooden spatula. Keep an eye on the bottom so nothing sticks. Without stopping the stirring, add about **250 g sugar**. The heat stays at medium. After **5–10 minutes**, the miso marinade should thicken into a spreadable, cream-like paste. Turn off the heat and let it cool.

Meanwhile, pat **8–10 portions of skin-on fillets** completely dry with paper towels and place them in a glass or polypropylene tray with a tight-fitting plastic lid. Spread the marinade over the fish, making sure everything is well coated. Cover tightly and refrigerate for **2–3 days**. Don't worry — the fish won't spoil; the marinade is loaded with sugar and alcohol. On the big day, take the cod out of the marinade and blot off the excess with paper towels. *Now it's ready.*

You can pan-sear the fish, browning each piece in hot vegetable oil over medium heat for 7–8 minutes per side (rinse the fillets briefly before frying and pat them dry so the sugar doesn't burn). Or, if the guests are already here and you're feeding a crowd, heat the oven to 475°F (246°C), lay the lightly wiped fish skin-side down on a foil-lined, oiled baking sheet, and roast until a caramelized crust forms — about 20 minutes. If you want extra color, finish under the broiler.

When you pull the tray from the oven, you'll discover that the black cod skin has fused itself to the foil. Perfect. Slide a thin spatula under each piece and lift the fish cleanly off its own skin onto the plates.

No sauce needed. Your guests will remember this new, tender, almost confection-like fish flavor without any help.

Fried Eggplant in White Miso

Here's a graceful way to cook eggplant. Left to their own devices, they behave like sponges — soaking up every drop of oil in the pan and coming out heavy and greasy. To stop that from happening, we're going to fill them first with beer, egg whites, and salt. Once again, albumin does the structural work, and white *shiro miso* provides salt and umami.

Remember how we did this with those freezer-burned shrimp? Same idea. And we'll need a touch of sugar to help the albumin and salt distribute evenly through the eggplant.

Take **two firm, large eggplants**, peel them, trim the stems, and slice them lengthwise — first into strips about a centimeter thick, then into pieces roughly $5 \times 3 \times 1$ cm. For **1 kilogram** of these pieces, take **3 tablespoons of shiro miso (130 g)**, **3 eggs**, **one can of beer (0.5 L)**, and **1 tablespoon of sugar**. Whisk everything together in a wide plastic container until smooth, then dump in the sliced eggplant. Mix well with your hands, gently pressing the pieces against the sides to expel air and let the egg-beer mixture seep in evenly. Let them sit 2–3 hours at room temperature, giving the mixture a couple more gentle, hands-on turns.

Still working by hand, squeeze the marinated eggplant pieces to remove excess liquid and lay them out on paper towels. Then dredge each piece in a thin coat of **rice flour** (basically the same thing as starch). No rice flour? Regular flour will do.

Meanwhile, heat about **1 cup of vegetable oil** in a wide nonstick skillet to 360°F (180°C). Lay the flour-coated eggplant pieces in a single layer so they can float freely. Keep the heat just above medium. After 4 minutes, flip them carefully with a bamboo spatula and check for that golden crust underneath. Fry the other side for another 4 minutes, then move the finished pieces to paper towels to wick away excess oil — and serve immediately.

For the sauce, you can use the ready-made **pesto genovese** from Costco, or pulse a cup of walnuts with oil and herbs in a blender until you get a smooth, elegant paste. Spoon it into a small dish and bring it to the table like you mean it.

PS: Walnut Paste for the Eggplant. You'll need:

- Frozen walnuts from our orchard (1 cup; always keep walnuts frozen — the delicate walnut oil turns rancid in no time, and then it's all over...)
- Good olive oil ($\frac{1}{2}$ cup)
- A bunch of well-washed cilantro (make sure there isn't a single grain of sand hiding in the leaves!)

Optional additions:

- Fenugreek seeds (*Rani* fenugreek (*Methi*) ground seeds, ½ tsp)
- Mild curry powder (*Rani* curry powder mild 10-spice blend, ½ tsp)

Important: Heat the oil properly at the start — but *not* so much that you scorch the coating on the eggplant! You can check the oil temperature with a bamboo spatula: when you dip its broad edge into the hot oil, you should see a soft “beard” of tiny bubbles forming around it. And remember, the crust on the vegetables should turn golden, not brown.

Scallops in Miso

This recipe is complicated — no point pretending otherwise. But if you do everything right, these scallops will take their place beside a sturgeon and General Tso’s chicken — and you’ll find yourself making them every single month.

Take **exactly as many frozen scallops** as will fit in a single layer in the wide nonstick pan, you’ll eventually fry them in (figure on 4–5 scallops per person). In a large bowl, combine about **3 tablespoons (120–130 g) of white *shiro* miso, 2 tablespoons of rice flour or starch, 1 tablespoon of sugar**, crack in **2 eggs**, add enough **milk or cream** to fully cover the scallops, and whisk until perfectly smooth. Drop the frozen scallops straight into the mixture and stir. Leave them on the counter at room temperature until they thaw — this may take a couple of hours. Then stir again, cover with plastic wrap, and refrigerate overnight. (You can fry them tomorrow — or the day after. Very convenient.)

About half an hour before frying, invert the entire bowl of scallops and miso mixture into a colander set in the sink. Don’t hold back — you won’t need the marinade again. Transfer the scallops to a large plate lined with paper towels and let them dry thoroughly — better yet, pat them from the top as well to get rid of any lingering moisture.

Next, pour **150–200 g of flour** into a deep plate — rice flour is best (it’s practically starch), but all-purpose flour or even cornstarch will work. Move the scallops into the flour and make sure each one is completely dry and evenly coated.

Meanwhile, heat a couple of tablespoons of vegetable oil in your skillet and melt **80–100 g of butter** into it. Start with medium heat. Once the mixture begins to bubble, lay the floured scallops into the pan in a single layer, never piled up — and immediately crank the heat to maximum. You need the surfaces to seize up instantly so the juices stay inside. If they leak — game over. You’ll end up with steamed sadness.

Slide the pan back and forth by the handle so the scallops stay lively in the bubbling butter and cook evenly. After 4–5 minutes, flip them with a wooden spatula. Check the underside — it should have a confident golden crust. Now fry the second side, still on the highest heat. After another 4–5 minutes, they’re ready for the plates. And do *not* leave anything sitting in

the pan — every scallop abandoned there will dry out into a small, chewy eulogy to your efforts.

Asparagus in Butter with White Miso

Buy a big bunch of good, firm **asparagus** — **about a pound**. Trim the spears: peel the tough skin from the thicker half and cut off the fibrous bottoms. Peel **5–6 cloves of garlic** and slice them in half lengthwise.

In a wide nonstick skillet, melt **100 g of butter** with a couple of tablespoons of vegetable oil (the oil keeps the butter from burning), and bring it just to the edge of a simmer. Add the garlic, **1 heaping tablespoon of white shiro miso**, and **1 tablespoon of sesame oil**. Stir everything together with a wooden spatula over medium heat, then send in the asparagus. Keep it moving so the butter doesn't scorch and the spears cook evenly.

After 3 minutes, splash in a little vodka and add **2 tablespoons of lemon juice**. Let everything cook over high heat for one more minute.

Serve the asparagus with a light *Gewürztraminer*. Its faintly perfumed, fruity notes — if you ask me — fit this dish beautifully.

PS: White Sauce Suprême with Saffron:

This white saffron sauce is a perfect match for the fried shrimp or the asparagus. Give it a try yourself.

In a dry, heavy-bottomed steel saucepan, gently warm **2–3 tablespoons of all-purpose flour (about 30 g)** over medium heat until it gives off a faint nutty aroma. Add **50–70 g of butter**, press it into the flour with a fork, and use the melting butter to stir the flour quickly into a smooth, sandy mixture — a white roux. As soon as the flour melts into the butter, gradually — and without pausing your stirring — pour in **300 ml of cold fish stock**. Bring it to a boil over medium heat.

After 10–20 minutes, once the sauce has thickened to the consistency of pastry cream or loose sour cream, remove it from the heat. Now add **½ teaspoon Dijon mustard** and **200 ml of Half & Half**. Rub a pinch of saffron between your fingers straight into the sauce, bring it back to a gentle simmer over low heat, and let it warm for 3–5 minutes, stirring constantly. Finally, whisk in **about 30 g of butter** and spoon the sauce over the shrimp or asparagus just before serving.

Salads

A salad is non-negotiable. Dinner in a proper household — the kind where people actually sit down together in the evening, don't stare into their phones the whole time, and even talk about something at the table — always begins with a salad. In such homes, by the way, they don't hand out plastic forks. They bring out silverware — say, *Kirk & Son Repoussé*. Have a look in the sideboard, just in case. Who knows — you might discover you like old table silver too...

Fresh Figs with Sheep's Milk Cheese

The best figs are the ones from your own garden — ripe, heavy, their bottoms just beginning to split. And of course, we're talking about the second harvest, the one that ripens here in early August: those figs are spectacular. The first, June crop? Not so much — pale, mealy, a little sad. Either the honey-yellow figs or the deep purple ones will do. Just cut them into quarters and remove the stems. I'd go a step further and pare off the skin with a thin knife... As for the cheese, you have options: thin slices of aged *Pecorino Romano*, or a fresh young sheep's-milk feta. A few delicate ribbons of *prosciutto crudo* bring a savory umami note that matches figs beautifully. Remember how in Italy they wrap slices of melon in cured ham? Same principle — fruit, salt, sweetness, and that elegant little whisper of fat.

In a separate bowl, whisk together **2 tablespoons of honey**, **3 tablespoons balsamic vinegar**, and **4 tablespoons olive oil**. On a large plate or in a deep serving dish, layer washed leaves of **romaine**, some **arugula**, and a scatter of **cilantro** or basil leaves torn by hand. Top with the quartered figs and pieces of cheese. Right before bringing it to the table, drizzle everything with the honey-balsamic mixture and give it a gentle toss.

Proper Salad Dressings

All the salad dressings you might ever need are collected in this table:

Ingredients	Thai	French	Miso
Brown sugar	3		
Honey		2	2
Lime or lemon juice	1		2
Balsamic vinegar		2	
Fish sauce	2		
Soy sauce		2	
Shiro miso paste			1
White wine			1–2
Vegetable oil	3	3	3

NB: All measurements are **volume-based ratios**, even for sugar.

A quick note on technique:

All you have to do is choose the ingredients you want (olive oil is best — green, cold-pressed), mix everything together, and whisk until smooth. Dress the salad right before serving: acids wilt the greens quickly and make cucumbers go limp.

Salad with Greens and Soft Cheese

If you're lucky enough to get your hands on real mozzarella — whether **fior di latte** (cow's milk) or **mozzarella di bufala** (buffalo milk) — you can cut it into quarters (after draining the whey it comes swimming in), add some roughly chopped ripe tomatoes, a handful of dry-ish black olives, and whatever seasonal greens you have around. Costco occasionally carries very decent **burrata** — that soft, molten cheese sphere the size of an egg, also lounging in whey. While you're there, pick up a couple of long **romaine** hearts, break them into cheerful little boats, nestle mozzarella quarters inside, arrange everything on a platter, and drizzle with dressing.

Twenty-Four Hour Cabbage Salad with Orange Juice

Take **two small, dense heads** of red or green cabbage — about 3 kilos total — and shred them into fine ribbons with a sharp knife. Peel **3–4 carrots** and slice them into matchsticks as well (or go ahead and use the food processor; it won't judge you). Put the cabbage and carrots into a wide steel pot and knead them lightly with your hands until the cabbage begins to release its juice. Then dress it with this *marinade*:

- Good apple cider vinegar 5% (100 ml)
- Honey or brown cane sugar (3 tbsp)
- Dark soy sauce (100 ml)
- Dry white wine (1 cup — if it's handy; if not, skip it)

Let the cabbage marinate for a couple of hours. Meanwhile, prepare the **hot oil infusion**:

- One large onion (slice into feathers)
- One head of garlic (peel, separate cloves, crush each with a knife)
- Cloves (7–8 pcs.)
- Star anise (2–3 stars)
- Cinnamon sticks (3 pcs.)
- Cardamom (5–8 green pods)
- Fresh ginger (4–5 cm; peel if you have it, slice into thin sticks)

Pour **150–200 ml vegetable oil** into a nonstick skillet and sauté the onion and garlic over low heat until golden. Lift them out with a slotted spoon and set aside. Now add all the spices to the same oil and heat gently, just to the edge of a simmer; keep them there for 3–5

minutes. Then pour the hot, fragrant oil through a metal strainer directly into the pot of cabbage. Discard the spices.

Add the fried onion and garlic to the pot (unless you dislike them in salads — in which case, skip). Mix everything thoroughly.

If you have a **grapefruit**, segment it: peel away the tough transparent skin from each wedge, remove all seeds, and drop the ruby or pale segments into the marinade. Grapefruit and cabbage are marvelous together — truly. Then squeeze the **juice from fresh oranges** — we drown in them every winter — or use a high-quality, pulpy orange juice from a carton. Pour generously so that the cabbage floats in the juice, then send the entire pot to the fridge for 24 hours to infuse. Before serving, transfer the salad into a beautiful glass bowl, add a little finely chopped, thoroughly rinsed parsley or cilantro, and bring it to the table together with the marinade.

Olivier Salad “The Gray Joy”

Yes, this is *that* very salad — the one people chopped every New Year’s Eve in cramped Moscow kitchens, just as they still do today; not much changes there. In Russian restaurants you’ll encounter it under names like *Stolichny*, *Moscow Salad*, or *Jubilee*. The salad is named after *Lucien Olivier*, a French chef and restaurateur who lived and worked in Moscow in the second half of the 19th century. He owned and ran the fashionable restaurant *Hermitage*, a legendary place in pre-revolutionary Moscow. Sometime in the 1860s, Olivier created a luxurious signature dish made with grouse, veal tongue, black caviar, crayfish tails, and a proprietary dressing he guarded fiercely. This original salad became wildly popular, but after his death the recipe was simplified, reinterpreted, and eventually transformed into the humble Soviet version — the familiar New Year’s “Olivier,” made from whatever ingredients were available. That’s how a lavish, aristocratic 19th-century dish gradually turned into the gray, nostalgic classic of the socialist kitchen.

Well, if we’re doing nostalgia, let’s do it properly: at Costco pick up a rotisserie chicken so you don’t have to fuss with cooking one. Strip off the meat and bones and chop the meat finely. Throw away the skin. While you’re there, grab a large jar of mayonnaise.

Into a small pot, place:

- 4–5 peeled carrots
- 4–5 fresh eggs (or boil them separately: bring to a boil, turn off the heat, cover, and let sit 6–7 minutes)
- 1 medium potato (one is plenty — really. Or you can skip it altogether.)

Cover with water and cook until done. When a knife slides easily through the carrot and potato, drain the boiling water and fill the pot with cold water. Let everything cool completely, then chop all the ingredients very finely — ideally about the size of a pea.

Now the rest:

- Take 3–4 small, firm, fresh cucumbers and chop them finely;
- Find unsweetened jarred pickles with minimal vinegar (3 small ones are enough);
- If you can't get good salted pickles, replace them with **capers** (about 2 tbsp);
- Open a can of green peas, drain the liquid, and make sure the peas are tender — French young peas are ideal;
- Rinse a large bunch of cilantro very thoroughly in a bowl of water, then chop the leaves very finely and discard the stems.

That's it. Combine everything in a pretty glass bowl and dress with 4–5 tablespoons of mayonnaise. Mix well. And yes — add a couple of tablespoons of red caviar on top if you have it, and arrange it however your inner artist suggests. I've given you rough quantities, but of course you'll need to taste and adjust — balance the saltiness, sweetness, and softness. But don't add extra salt: the pickles, capers, and mayonnaise will take care of that.

The Real Olivier Salad, or *Mayonnaise d'Esturgeon*

Let's make a real French mayonnaise first. In the 19th century, the word *mayonnaise* had several meanings: it referred both to a cold meat or fish dish *and* to the dressing that defined it. The salad, invented by *Lucien Olivier*, appeared in *the Hermitage* menu under the name "*Mayonnaise of Game*". Olivier had several versions of the recipe, but unfortunately not a single one survived intact. What we *do* know for certain is that everything in his dish revolved around the sauce — and the rest we can handle ourselves.

The Mayonnaise:

Mayonnaise is made from warm egg yolks, lemon juice, and oil. In a warmed glass bowl, whisk together **two warm egg yolks, one tablespoon Dijon mustard**, and **¼ teaspoon salt**. No mustard at home? Use **½ tablespoon of 5% vinegar** instead.

Begin adding oil: a **teaspoon**, drop by drop, while whisking vigorously into the yolks. Then another teaspoon. And another. Something remarkable will happen: the mixture (now called a *sabayon*) will thicken and expand to two or three times its volume.

Now switch to an immersion blender and pour in **200–300 ml vegetable oil** in a thin stream. The sauce will greedily absorb it until a stable emulsion forms. Finally, whisk in **2 tablespoons lemon juice** (or vinegar, or dry white wine) so the mayonnaise stays smooth in the refrigerator.

The Sturgeon:

Take **500–800 g of yesterday's cold cooked sturgeon** and cut it into pieces the size of your little finger. Put **400–500 g of small Arctic shrimp** — already cleaned and thawed — into a colander and pour boiling water (about 2 liters) over them. Do not boil them. A hot rinse is enough.

Choose a beautiful deep glass or ceramic serving dish. Arrange the pieces of sturgeon in a ring around the edges, leaving the center empty. Surround the fish with good olives (our local *Mezzetta* olives, or the pinkish Turkish ones). The empty center will be for the shrimp salad.

The Central Salad:

- **3–4 small, firm fresh cucumbers**
- **400–500 g of cleaned Arctic shrimp**, already scalded with boiling water (if you don't have Arctic shrimp, thaw regular ones, peel them, and quickly sauté for 5–10 minutes)
- **3–4 eggs**, cooked slightly firmer than soft-boiled (bring to a boil, turn off the heat, cover, and let sit 6 minutes)
- **Capers** (about 2 tbsp)
- The tender inner leaves of **one romaine heart**, thoroughly washed
- **Red caviar** — spooned on top, *quantum satis*

Chop the cucumbers, shrimp, and lettuce finely, ideally pea-sized. Quarter the eggs. Combine everything in a bowl and dress it generously with a **cup of your homemade mayonnaise**. And absolutely no chicken, no potatoes, no carrots, no pickles, no peas — for heaven's sake! Mix well and place the salad in the center of the dish. Top it, of course, with a couple of tablespoons of red caviar. Now spoon some mayonnaise over the sturgeon around the edges — and serve. Do not salt anything. The capers, shrimp, and mayonnaise will take care of the seasoning.

You have just read a lightly adapted version of *Mayonnaise d'esturgeon* from *Ignaty Radetsky's St. Petersburg Cuisine*, published in 1862. If you're curious, the excellent work "*Russian Cuisine*" by *Olga and Pavel Syutkin* includes many more historic recipes from Moscow restaurants at the end of the 19th century.

Magnificent Cold Frutti di Mare Salad

Take a look at the section *Fish and Other Sea Creatures* for the proper way to cook octopus. Once it's tender, cut it into bite-sized pieces and toss it with **cilantro**, thinly sliced **fennel**, and dry, black **Kalamata olives** or the marinated **pinkish Turkish olives** (however your taste and imagination happen to lean). You'll want some **good olive oil** for the dressing and a squeeze of **lemon juice** to brighten everything up.

Warm Shrimp Salad

Take a large white onion and half a kilo (about a pound) of peeled small shrimp. Slice the onion finely and sauté it in a wide nonstick skillet with **one star anise** and **two tablespoons of vegetable oil** until it turns golden. Dry the shrimp thoroughly on paper

towels, add them to the skillet, and cook over high heat for 3–4 minutes, just until done. Now remove the star anise and season the contents of the skillet with a little salt.

Choose a ripe but still fairly firm **papaya** weighing around half a kilo (a Hawaiian one with yellow skin is perfect). Peel it, scoop out the seeds with a spoon, and cut the orange flesh into small cubes.

Rinse a large bunch of **cilantro** very thoroughly in a bowl of water to get rid of any sand. Tear off about half a cup of leaves, discarding the stems, and slice them into a fine confetti with your sharpest knife.

Combine the hot shrimp and onions with the papaya and herbs in a separate bowl and serve as a warm salad in wide glasses or small bowls. Top each portion with a tablespoon of **lime juice**, and scatter a few **pine nuts** over the top if you happen to have them.

If not — no tragedy. The proportions here are enough for 2–3 bowls.

True Broths and the Technique of *Pot-au-Feu*

It was *soup*, of all things, that first opened the door for me into the ancient cooking of China. And there may be no better place for such an introduction than *Xi'an* — once the beating heart of several imperial dynasties, a city crowned by the solemn Pagoda of the Wild Goose and guarded, not far beyond its gates, by the vast underground army of Emperor Qin Shi Huang.

Step out onto its narrow streets an hour before midnight and the past feels startlingly present. Long after the last diners have disappeared into the dark, kitchen windows glow like small furnaces. You hear cleavers tapping out their steady rhythms, smell broths that have been tended since dusk, and watch cooks move through thin curls of steam as they ready the next day's feast. In *Xi'an*, even at that late hour, the city seems to breathe through its kitchens — warm, ancient, and impossibly alive.

Under a great iron cauldron set into a low brick hearth, cooks coax flames to life, ladle in water, and drop in everything left from the day's butchery: chicken legs and carcasses, meat trimmings, massive beef bones and joints, onions, carrots, celery roots, parsley roots. (What they *don't* add — ever — is beef fat, lamb, chicken skin, or pork: those would cloud the flavor and swamp the aroma.) And of course, they add large, honest pieces of good meat.

The pot simmers for a couple of hours, then the fire is smothered, the lid set in place, and the whole thing wrapped in an old quilt. That's how the broth rests and deepens overnight, so that by breakfast the soups are already waiting — hot, clear, rich.

They assemble them like a construction set: into a warm bowl go strips of boiled meat and herbs — or wontons and herbs — or sauerkraut with a pair of modest red chilies — and then everything is flooded with steaming broth. And broth that has rested all night in one great pot has an entirely different soul: all the gelatin from bones and cartilage has melted into the vegetable stock until it clings to your lips like silk.

I've watched this midnight soup ritual in many parts of China, and there are no hidden secrets — only time, a vast pot, and patient heat.

Though it's worth noting one more thing. If you trace a finger down the map from *Xi'an*, southward, you soon hit Vietnam. There isn't really an "ancient" cuisine there in the same sense — but you've heard, of course, of *pho*, the beloved Vietnamese soup? I'm sorry to break it to you: *pho* is French *feu* — meaning *broth simmered low and slow*. The *pot-au-feu* technique arrived in Vietnam together with the colonial empire, just as baguettes did.

And the flavor of *pho* — like the crackling crust on good bread — comes from the *Maillard reaction*, when sugars and amino acids meet under heat. Pre-roasting meat and bones, with ginger and onion, spritzed lightly with oil, is what makes one of the finest broths in world cooking. And it's not complicated: all you need is to roast beef bones with meat, ginger, and onion at 475°F (246°C) until browned. The rest — I'll tell you in this chapter.

Meat Stock as the Foundation of All Other Soups

For 10 liters of plain white *consommé*, the French master *Auguste Escoffier* recommends using 10 kilograms of bone-in beef, including shanks; 4 kilograms of lean beef; 1 kilogram of carrots; 2 medium onions; ½ kilogram of leek; 1 kilogram assorted root vegetables; 14 liters of water; and 70 grams of salt. To draw out every drop of nutritive essence from the meat, the maître writes, “five hours of simmering will extract the juices from the beef — but crushing the bones alone is not at all enough to extract their soluble parts. To achieve that, they must be boiled for 12 to 15 hours.”

Don’t panic — we’ll go much faster. The *Maillard* reaction will help us. But first you’ll need a large **stainless-steel pot** with a lid — 15–20 liters minimum, and ideally two, which makes straining much easier later. Aluminum is not suitable: its thin oxide layer dissolves quickly in acid, leaving aluminum salts in the broth — entirely unwelcome guests. Why challenge your organs for sport when you can simply use good 18/10 stainless steel?

- Take **2–3 kg of bone-in beef**, or **2 kg of chopped beef bones** (joints and feet), plus **a couple of beef shanks**. Arrange them on a rimmed baking sheet lined with two layers of heavy foil, and roast at 475°F (246°C) for 40–60 minutes, until browned and beautifully crusted. Meanwhile peel onions and roughly chop your vegetables and mushrooms (see ingredient list below).
- Transfer the roasted beef and bones into the pot and add **5–6 liters of water** (distilled water from Safeway is ideal, just like for tea). On the baking sheet you’ll find rendered fat and a little juice with scum — none of that goes into the broth. Pour off the fat.
- To the pot add anything lingering in your freezer from previous poultry adventures — chicken joints, cartilage-rich frames stripped long ago for ground meat. Cartilage is your friend here: it releases gelatin. Add all vegetables, salt, and a touch of sugar.
- Bring to a boil, then reduce to the faintest simmer and skim the foam — twice, if needed. Pour in **a bottle of full-bodied white wine**, or a liter of inexpensive *Chardonnay*. Remember: gelatin extracts best in an acidic environment. Simmer gently for 2 hours, just barely trembling.
- Add spices at the end — but if you don’t have the right ones, don’t lose sleep over it.
- Turn off the heat, cover the pot, wrap it in old towels, and leave it overnight. It will finish cooking itself — warm and undisturbed under the blankets.
- In the morning, line a colander with double-layer cheesecloth, set it inside the second pot, and strain the broth. Pick out any good meat from the spent bones; discard the rest.
- Chill the broth quickly and remove every last drop of fat. The easiest way: put the pot out in the cold so the fat hardens into a crust you can lift out with a slotted spoon.

Use the broth immediately, or ladle it into *food-grade polypropylene (HDPP)* containers. Seal tightly and freeze for later soups — but remember frozen stock expands, so never fill to the

top. If you've done everything correctly, the broth will be dense, wine-rich, onion-warm, and it will gelatinize in the fridge. It will be only lightly salted — season to taste when serving.

Mandatory:

- Beef on the bone (2–3 kg) and/or chopped beef bones (2 kg) + 2–3 beef shanks
- Chicken joints (or skinless drumsticks), cartilage-rich chicken frames (2–3 kg)
- White wine (1 liter)
- Onion (2 heads)
- Carrots (2–4)
- Salt (1–2 tbsp)
- Brown sugar (1 tbsp)

Optional additions:

- Ginger or galangal (100 g)
- Celeriac (½ head)
- Leek (1 stalk)
- Parsley root (1)
- Shiitake mushrooms (½ kg)

Spices:

- Lemongrass (2–3 stalks, bruised with a mallet)
- Cinnamon (1 stick)
- Star anise (1 star)
- Cloves (4–6, stuck directly into an onion)
- Cardamom (3–5 pods)
- White peppercorns (6–8)

Important: Pot volume is *crucial*. In a small pot nothing will work — it cools too fast. A big pot is not an indulgence here — it's the law of thermodynamics.

Vietnamese *Pho Bo*

Cook your rice noodles separately — there are many kinds, so just pick the one you like. Once they're done, transfer them to a large bowl, ladle over hot beef broth, and season with soy sauce to taste.

Just before serving, slice the chilled beef — beef shanks work beautifully, or the roast beef loaf we'll prepare later in the "*Roast Beef*" section — into paper-thin slices and lay them into the broth along with the noodles. Scatter cilantro leaves on top if you like.

On a small side plate you must offer: **sliced chili, a sprig of fresh Thai basil, half a lime, one star anise, and a stick of cinnamon.** It is precisely the trio of *anise + lime + cinnamon* that transforms ordinary beef broth into *pho bo*. Naturally, the lime is squeezed into the bowl. As for why a dry star anise and a whole cinnamon stick are served with the soup — I can't say I fully understand, but in the finer Vietnamese restaurants, this is exactly how *pho* arrives at the table.

Japanese Miso Soup

This one is as simple as it gets: stir **100–130 g of white *shiro miso*** into **one liter of hot beef broth**, add a little **roasted seaweed (nori)** — and you're essentially done.

The flavor will be solid and whole, almost monolithic — the way the foundation stones of *Coricancha temple* still stand in Cusco. Those colossal granite blocks, carved by hand and fitted so precisely that even centuries of wind and rain have failed to slip a knife-blade of time between them. The great temple that once rose above them has vanished into history, but the base remains, steady as a heartbeat. People still come to lay their hands on the cool stone, to feel that impossible perfection, and sometimes, without quite knowing why, to brush a tear from the corner of an eye...

Sichuan Sour Cabbage Soup

Simmer a bowl of **sauerkraut with its brine** in **one liter of beef broth** for 5–10 minutes. If you like, add some finely shredded fresh cabbage and **pre-cooked Chinese wood-ear mushrooms** (only if you enjoy them — they really do look like soft black ears).

The Chinese scatter **two whole fiery chili pods** on top, uncut, and a spoonful of **cilantro leaves**. I don't eat chili myself — but you might try it, if courage strikes. This soup is also often served with **thin petals of boiled meat** floating over the surface.

Hot & Sour Soup — Shanxi Style

Start with the mushrooms. Northern Chinese cooks traditionally use dried ones, soaking them for thirty minutes before cooking, but if you can get fresh — do. The depth of this soup comes from three things: a strong broth, heat, and mushrooms. Rinse the fresh shiitake and wood ear mushrooms (*mu'er*) in a bowl of water to remove grit and sand. Trim off and discard the tough stems from the shiitake, then slice the caps into thin strips. For the wood ears, snip away the woody bases with kitchen scissors and cut the soft ear-shaped tops into fine ribbons about ¼ cm wide.

Slide everything into a non-stick pan with a splash of vegetable oil and sauté over medium heat for about 10 minutes. Add a cup of dry white wine, cover, and let them braise another 10 minutes. Set aside — they need a moment to rest.

Now move to your wok — the soup will be cooked right in it. Over medium heat, warm some vegetable oil and gently fry julienned ginger together with one or two whole chili pods until fragrant. Add a cube of red fermented tofu if you have one (if not, don't worry), toss in the sliced carrot, and stir-fry for another half-minute. Then add the sautéed shiitake and wood ears, wine and all, and pour in one liter of beef broth. Bring to a simmer, cover, and let it quietly bubble for 10–15 minutes. Meanwhile, whisk one egg in a bowl and dissolve 2 tbsp cornstarch in 6–7 tbsp cold water.

Lift the lid and fish out the whole chilies. They've done their job — all the fire is already in the broth. Season with sugar, apple cider vinegar, regular soy sauce, and dark soy sauce — these add acidity and give the broth its deep, handsome color.

Stir the soup continuously as you slowly drizzle in the cornstarch slurry. Add the sliced tofu — the broth should turn glossy and smooth almost instantly. Let it return to a soft simmer, then gently stream in the beaten egg. In seconds it will set into pale, silky ribbons. If you want the soup truly fiery, as in Shanxi, add a second chili pod sliced into thin strips (without seeds). Handle with care — the heat becomes formidable. Finish with a drop of sesame oil if you have it, ladle into bowls, and crown each serving with a sprig or two of cilantro.

Main Ingredients (for 4 bowls):

- Fresh shiitake mushrooms (6–8)
- Black wood ear mushrooms (*Auricularia heimuer*, 200 g)
- Vegetable oil (4 tbsp)
- Dry white wine (200 ml)
- Beef broth (frozen and thawed, 1 liter)
- Ginger, peeled and finely julienned (6 cm piece)
- Carrot, peeled and julienned (8 cm piece)
- Whole red chili pods (1–2)
- Firm tofu (150–200 g, cut into thin strips)
- Sugar (1 tbsp)
- Cornstarch (2 tbsp + 6–7 tbsp water)
- Soy sauce (2 tbsp)
- Dark soy sauce (1 tbsp)
- Apple cider vinegar 5% (2 tbsp)
- Cilantro, a generous handful

Optional, but excellent:

- One red chili pepper, seeded and sliced fine
- Red fermented tofu (fermented bean curd, 1 cube/1 tbsp)
- Sesame oil (1 tsp)

Wonton Soup, Chinese-style

Take a dozen *good, hand-folded, proper* frozen wontons from Ranch 99 — I'd suggest pork, or chicken with garlic chives. Simmer them gently in a small saucepan of barely bubbling water for 5–6 minutes, just until they relax and float. Then lift them straight into a hot bowl of beef broth. Scatter fresh cilantro leaves over the top. If you add thin slices of cooked meat — pale petals drifting in the bowl — the dish earns its grand name: *wor wonton*. The word "wor" is often cited as a phonetic spelling of a Chinese hieroglyph meaning "everything."

French Onion Soup

This is chef *Raymond Blanc's* version. For 4–6 deep, comforting bowls you'll need 1 kilogram of white onions, peeled and sliced into thin half-moons. Set a wide, heavy saucepan over the gentlest heat you can manage; add a slick of neutral oil and a tablespoon of butter. The butter should only *whisper* — barely bubbling, never sizzling or browning.

Add the onions and let them languish, stirring from time to time, for about 1½ hours. They will first sweat, then soften, and slowly begin to release their juice — which mingles with the butter into something lush, sweet, and fragrant. You may slip in another dab of butter as they go, but *do not*, under any circumstances, increase the heat. Harsh fire will scorch the onions, split the butter into fat and whey, and ruin everything this soup is about.

What you're looking for is the miracle that happens near the end: the onions reduce to a fraction of their size and turn the color of pale caramel. Only then, if you like, stir in a tablespoon of flour and cook another 5–10 minutes — it will lend a faint nuttiness and later thicken the soup to a beautiful velvet.

Next, pour in a cup of rich golden chardonnay and let it cook down for ten minutes. Then add one liter of strong beef broth and let everything come together until the sweetness of the onions winds itself through the stock. Salt to taste.

And forget the floating crouton and blanket of melted cheese — this was once the supper of market gardeners in Paris, bone-tired after a long day, cooking late at night with nothing more than the onions left unsold. Simple, honest, and perfect.

Vacaville Tomato Soup

Remember late August — when the whole garden situated in front of our lab in Vacaville countryside goes delirious with tomatoes? Red, sunburst-yellow, sunset-orange and those mottled green ones with bruise-colored streaks. There's no way eating them fast enough, so we freeze them by the gallon. First a rinse in the sink, then a quick blanch — peel slips off with one confident flick of a knife. Cores and pale ribs out, fruit halved, and into the freezer they go, like summer sealed in glass.

Now you see why we hoarded them.

In a deep nonstick skillet, warm a splash of neutral oil and slowly soften diced onion to a transparent caramel sheen — add thick slices of galangal or ginger, whole garlic cloves, let everything get fragrant and a little golden. Then scrape it all into a 10-liter stainless pot along with a sack of frozen tomatoes and a brick of frozen beef stock. Bring it to a full, rolling boil and stir in lemon juice, *miso paste* (white *shiro* or red *aka*, your call), a spoon of tomato paste, and a glass of white wine. Reduce the heat — let it barely tremble for 15–20 minutes, until the tomatoes slump into themselves and stop pretending to have structure.

Only then add the olives — the wrinkly, dry Turkish kind — and adjust with salt and sugar until it tastes like August again.

To serve: Drop a pinch of cilantro or torn basil leaves into warm bowls, ladle over a couple scoops of thick, red-gold broth, breathe in — and eat while it still hums with summer.

Essential:

- Frozen tomatoes (2–3 kg)
- Frozen beef stock (2–3 L)
- White wine (200 ml)
- White onions (2–3 medium)
- Garlic (5–6 cloves)
- *Shiro miso* or *aka miso* (100–150 g)
- Juice of 2 limes (~2–3 tbsp)

Optional, but lovely:

- Galangal or ginger (100 g)
- California tomato paste — 1 small can (170 g)
- Dry black Turkish olives (1–2 cups)
- Fresh cilantro or parsley — one generous handful

Fish Soups

There are many ways to make stocks, *demi-glace* (which is really just stock reduced by one-third), and *consommé* — and the most reliable of them are described with almost military clarity by *Auguste Escoffier* in his *Le Guide Culinaire*. Fish stock is even simpler than beef: no need to roast bones, brown shanks, or summon the Maillard gods.

Escoffier's "*special supper consommés*," as he calls them, are served either hot or cold and — crucially — with no garnish at all. They must have immaculate flavor and be completely transparent. He writes: "If consommé is served cold, it must have the consistency of a light yet firm jelly. If it is too thin, the taste will be incomplete. If it sets too rigidly, the flavor will be distorted. Therefore, it must be brought to the correct degree of firmness so that its delicate taste may be appreciated. As for cold consommés made with wines, they must be prepared from chicken — and the proper proportion is 80 ml of wine per 1 liter of *consommé*." Mark that down. It matters.

To prepare 10 liters of fish *consommé à la Escoffier*, you will need:

- 8 kg of fish with heads, skin, and backbones
- 700 g onions
- 400 g leeks
- 200 g assorted roots
- 10 liters water
- 1 liter white wine

Simmer gently for about 50 minutes, never boiling hard. Clarify if you want that gemstone transparency, then cool, portion, and freeze in *polypropylene or polycarbonate containers* — consommé is happily made once a month and kept on standby like a polite promise.

Perfect consommé is not difficult. It is simply precise — and precision tastes like elegance.

A Strong Fish Stock for Sturgeon Soup & Tom Kha Talay

As always, you begin with a large stainless-steel pot — 15 to 20 liters at least. Into it goes every fish frame you've been saving in the freezer like a squirrel saving acorns — all those carcasses from previous seafood days, finally called to duty. If you get lucky at Ranch 99 and spot **the massive head of a deep-dwelling ling cod (*Ophiodon elongatus*) or sturgeon head and cartilage**, take it. Or go simpler: **3–4 large salmon heads (2–3 kg)** will give you a thick, cloudy broth — something like an East Coast chowder in temperament.

You can even add **a couple of chicken frames or chopped joints** — leftovers from butchering. Why chicken in fish stock? For gelatin extraction. The best gelatin comes from ancient sturgeon — a fish with no bones at all, only cartilage (how to handle sturgeon appears later, in the sturgeon soup chapter). But modern dinosaurs work too: every chicken carries in its body the long memory of bird-hipped theropods who somehow dodged

Chicxulub asteroid approximately 66 million years ago. Lucky for soup — unlucky for celestial impact events.

- Remove the gills from the fish heads (kitchen shears are safer — no wrestling slippery gills by hand). You may remove the as well — they give a faint bitterness.
- Rinse the cleaned heads under cold water, place them into the pot, and cover with **3–5 L distilled water** (tea-grade, please). Bring to a boil, reduce to a bare simmer, skim foam, then add **~1 L full-bodied white wine** — gelatin loves acidity. Add **onions studded with cloves, celery stalks, carrots, celeriac, parsley root**, and leek if you have it; if not — no tragedy.
- Let the stock tremble, not boil, for 40–50 minutes, then season with **white peppercorns, two sprigs of thyme**, and **1 tablespoon salt** for the whole enormous pot. If you have **lemongrass**, now is its moment.
- Turn off heat. Cover with a lid, then insulate the pot with old towels, and leave overnight to steep like a secret.
- In the morning, line a colander with cheesecloth (2 layers), place it over a second large pot, and strain. Pick through the heads for every edible treasure — cheek meat, back meat, softened cartilage — return it to the broth; discard the rest.

Use immediately or portion into freezer-safe *polypropylene containers* — remembering that frozen stock expands and explodes only once.

You Will Need:

For a rich, opaque chowder-like broth: 3–5 large salmon heads (3–4 kg)

—or—

For a clear, elegant broth: 1 split ling cod head or halved sturgeon head and fish frames from the freezer (1–2 kg)

Plus — universally:

- Chicken joints / drumsticks without skin — or sturgeon cartilage (*quantum satis*)
- White wine (1 L)
- Onions studded with 4–5 cloves (1–2 pcs)
- Carrots (2 pcs)
- Salt (1 tbsp)

Optional enhancements:

- Celery stalks (2–3)
- Celeriac (½ root)
- Leek (1 stalk)
- Parsley root (1)

Optional spices:

- Lemongrass (2–3 stalks)
- Thyme (2 sprigs)
- White peppercorns (6–8)

Important: The size of the pot is everything. Too small — and the broth cools too fast, collapses in flavor, and you'll wonder why all your careful dinosaur archaeology tastes like dishwater. Big pot, slow heat, patience. That's the whole religion.

Sturgeon Soup

A fish that wears armor like a medieval knight — the freshwater sturgeon (*Acipenser oxyrinchus*) comes to us from the deep, ancestral dark. Its lineage descends straight from the Jurassic seas, side-by-side with dinosaurs. Fossils place its family in the *Upper Jurassic* — 165 to 145 million years ago. Look at it carefully: the long snout, the dorsal ridges like riveted plates, the heavy cartilage frame. It doesn't resemble a salmon or trout — it looks like a German U-boat, missing only the black crosses on the hull and the grim Kriegsmarine pennant snapping in the wind.

Yet despite all that paleontological gravitas, fresh sturgeon swim today in the live tanks at *Ranch 99*. You need a whole fish — alive — not the sad pale carcasses on ice. They will dispatch it after purchase, quickly, skillfully, without ceremony. Hard to watch, but necessary. Have the fishmonger cut it into pieces for transport, and guard the head and tail with your life — those belong to the broth. Do not skimp here. Sturgeon is my favorite fish for a reason: the flesh is pale, silky, rich with prehistoric fat. Spend freely, you won't regret it. And the soup...

Now slip on gloves. Using a short, sharp blade, cut the sturgeon into 8–10 cm segments and steam-blanch them just enough to loosen the armor: arrange the pieces in a deep skillet or Dutch oven with a tight lid, pour in one cup of water, and set over high heat. The moment the water boils, take the pan off the flame. Let it cool under its own breath — and the skin will peel away like soft leather from bone.

Strip the fillet from the cartilage spine. Discard the skin and scutes — they belong to the Pleistocene, not your dinner — but freeze the spine, tail, and head for stock. When you're done, you should have clean, milky-white pieces of sturgeon, barely cooked, unseasoned, and completely boneless. Keep a few for frying or roasting tonight. The rest — slide into a ziplock, press out the air, and freeze: the future soup is already waiting.

The next day defrost a pound of yesterday's sturgeon, cut it into pinkie-finger pieces, and slide them into your strong fish stock — the one you made with care, patience, and prehistoric cartilage. Bring just to a simmer, salt to taste, and serve. Nothing more.

You understand, of course, that you may replace sturgeon with another noble white fish — even large shrimp — and the soup will still be excellent. Only the name will change.

Tom Kha Talay

What we are making now is true *Tom Kha*, not that lukewarm coconut emulsion handed to charter tourists under the gaze of apologetic Thai waiters.

So, today in front of you sits a **3-liter pot of strained fish broth** — shimmering, pale, already fragrant. It contains fish collagen, chicken cartilage, the sweetness of onion, the roots of celery, carrot, parsley. A few soft flakes of fish drift in suspension like plankton in warm tidewater. Now it is ready to become soup.

Into the pot, still quiet and below a boil, drop:

- sliced galangal
- lemongrass stalks, flattened with a kitchen mallet
- a star anise pod
- kaffir lime leaves, torn to wake their scent

Bring the broth slowly toward a simmer. Add **a teaspoon of salt and a teaspoon of sugar** — balance is the entire religion of Thai soup.

Ladle **600–800 ml of hot broth** into a small saucepan and let it cool to 50–60°C — warm, not scalding. In a plastic bowl, whisk **2 eggs into foam**, add the juice of **2–3 limes** and **1 teaspoon sugar**, and whisk again until pale and airy. When the broth in the saucepan is warm-not-hot, trickle in the eggs while whisking constantly. You will watch it change color — suddenly cloud-white. What you have made is *a colloidal suspension*: microscopic droplets of albumin and phospholipids, held aloft in gently acidified stock. Stir for another calm minute. This mixture will give Tom Kha its body.

Now everything happens fast. If the main pot is now near-boiling, slide in chopped shrimp or diced white fish — and immediately kill the heat.

Add **a pinch of saffron**, just enough to tint the broth a sunrise orange — the color of Mekong at five o'clock in the morning. If you like, drop in **straw mushrooms from a can** and **quail eggs**, also canned, easily found in *Ranch 99*. The broth should smell of lime leaves, river, and heat.

Now — whisking steadily — pour the egg-broth mixture back into the main pot. Return to the lowest flame and let it approach, but never reach, a boil. 7–8 minutes of gentle stirring with a bamboo spatula — no more. The soup should thicken like thought, not like stew. Salt, acidity — adjust carefully. Serve immediately in broad deep bowls, steaming and alive.

Main:

- Arctic shrimp, cleaned & thawed (1 kg), or large shrimp tails 600 g, peeled & deveined, or diced white fish (½ kg)
- Galangal (50–70 g)

- Lemongrass (2–3 stalks)
- Juice of 2–3 limes
- Saffron (just a pinch)
- Salt (1 tsp)
- Sugar (2 tsp)
- Eggs (2)

Optional but recommended:

- Kaffir lime leaves (3–4)
- Star anise (1 pod)
- Straw mushrooms (200 g, canned)
- Quail eggs (200 g, canned)

***Fumet* — a light fish broth in just a few hours**

If the day has been generous and you've come home with fresh fish in quantity, congratulations — that already counts as good fortune. Now take **3–5 fish frames** (the ones left after your black cod in white miso), or the skeletons of a large halibut, just filleted. Remove the gills from each head — kitchen shears are safest — and if you want true clarity, take the eyes as well: they carry bitterness into the pot.

Rinse the heads and bones under cold running water until they look clean, pale, ocean-born. Set them into a 10–15 liter stainless pot and cover with **distilled water** — 3–4 liters should be enough to submerge everything without a rib peeking out. Add **two onions studded with cloves, a couple of sliced carrots, and a chunk of celeriac or parsley root**. Bring the pot to a gentle boil and skim the froth that rises — it's just albumin, but we don't need it.

When the surface clears, pour in **1 liter of white wine**, add **white peppercorns, two sprigs of thyme**, and **1 tablespoon of salt**. If you have **a few tart plums**, drop them in — they brighten fish stock beautifully. And if lemongrass is within reach, bruise **2 stalks** with the flat side of the meat mallet and send them in as well. Bring the pot back just to a boil, then let it tremble for 30 minutes at the lowest simmer — barely breathing.

Cut the flame. Let the broth relax. Then line a wide colander with double-layered cheesecloth, set it over a clean pot, and strain. All solids go to pasture — their work is done. Taste the broth. If it needs a deeper savory hand, stir in **1–2 tablespoons of shiro miso**, and only then serve.

Important: A light fumet does not want long boiling — gentleness is its virtue. Push it too hard, and you lose that silkiness, that whisper of the sea. If what you seek is a clear, jewel-bright broth — the kind you serve beside a cabbage pie — whisk 5–6 egg whites, pour them into the hot *fumet* along with crushed lemongrass stalks, and let them collect the cloudiness like a net in shallow tide. Strain everything through cheesecloth, after that just salt the clarified fumet to perfection and serve it hot, thin, shimmering, precise.

***Fumet* with Shrimp Wontons**

Finely grind **300–350 g of peeled shrimp tails** in a food processor or blender until smooth. Transfer the paste to a deep glass bowl and work it vigorously with a wooden spoon — aerating the mixture gives it bounce and elasticity. Add **1 tablespoon water, 1 tablespoon cornstarch, and 1 tablespoon oyster sauce**, stirring without pause. Then pour in **1 tablespoon soy sauce and 1 tablespoon sesame oil**. Mix again — and your wonton filling is ready, springy and fragrant like sea air before rainfall.

Now take a stack of **store-bought wonton wrappers** from the Chinese Ranch 99 market. One at a time: moisten the perimeter with water, lay the wrapper onto your palm, spoon **about 1 teaspoon** of filling into the center, close your hand, and pinch the edges together to

form a little dumpling. And yes — make a whole batch, freeze them, and future soup will take ten minutes instead of twenty.

Bring water to a boil in a small nonstick pan. Slip in the wontons and let them cook 5 minutes at a friendly, medium simmer. Almost there.

Divide the wontons between warmed bowls. Flood them with hot, clear fumet, taste for salt, and serve immediately. A soup both delicate and unforgettable — and truly easy to make.

Light Summer Soups

There are summer soups beyond counting — a whole shimmering sea of them — but let us make just two. Two most subtle and translucent, intimate in scale and delicate in hue, like the small upper chapel of Sainte-Chapelle, bathed in sapphire light, hidden like a jewel behind the courtyards of the Ministry of Justice on the *Île de la Cité* in Paris.

Cold Beet Soup

This is an adapted recipe from the chef of *Vanil'* restaurant in Moscow — the one tucked just to the right of the entrance to the Cathedral of Christ the Savior.

Peel **5–6 large beets** and cut them into fine matchsticks. Take a large onion, peel it, score the sides lightly with a knife and stud it with **5 cloves**. Peel **4–5 cm of ginger** and cut it into thin julienne as well.

Place beets, onion and ginger into a pot, cover with **2–3 liters of cold distilled water**, set over a low flame. As soon as the water warms, add **½ cup lemon juice** and **1 tablespoon honey** — this keeps both color and clarity. A couple of prunes, dropped into the simmer, make it even better. Heat the brew 20–25 minutes at a bare shimmer — just a few bubbles per minute — never letting it boil hard or foam. If you have thyme, drop in **a sprig or two**; it chases away that mournful earthy beet aroma.

Cool the broth and strain it through cheesecloth. Discard all solids. Taste for acidity, salt, sweetness. The flavor should already be boldly sour-sweet — add more lemon if it falls short. Store this beet consommé cold. Assemble the soup at the moment of serving — in a chilled bowl, or better still, in white porcelain so the color glows.

Into each bowl place **one egg, halved**. The eggs should be boiled just a little firmer than soft-boiled (Quail eggs from a *Ranch 99* tin will do in a pinch.)

Finely chop a little fresh herb — just a scattering: cilantro leaves torn by hand, or dill. You may add **matchstick cucumber**, peeled and sliced with a knife (never grated — it clouds the broth and slicks the texture). A couple of radishes cut into thin strips won't hurt either.

If you have it, add slivers of **braised tongue** or cold roasted beef (*see Roast Beef chapter*).

Finally — pour in the ice-cold beet broth. You *may* stir in sour cream immediately, but better preserve the transparent ruby glow of a broth and serve sour cream separately in a sauceboat — you do have a sauceboat somewhere, don't you?

This is a refined soup. It is worth a Mass.

Hot Porcini Mushroom Soup

Find yourself **2 kilograms of fresh porcini**, firm and unblemished, plus **1 large onion**, **1 carrot**, and **2 large potatoes**. Clean the mushrooms and cut them into generous pieces;

mince the onion and carrot very finely, and chop the potatoes a little larger — they will carry the body of the soup.

In a wide non-stick skillet, sauté mushrooms and potatoes together in a blend of **butter and vegetable oil**, stirring often, 10–15 minutes over medium heat. If you have fresh galangal root — now is its hour — drop 2–3 slices into the pan to perfume the mushrooms.

Transfer everything into a pot and pour in **3 liters of cold distilled water**. Add $\frac{2}{3}$ **tablespoon salt**, set over very low heat. When the soup reaches a gentle simmer, let it cook 30–40 minutes at a mere whisper — as with the beet broth, think a few bubbles per minute. Guard it from boiling; porcini thrive on quiet heat, not violent rolling.

While the soup hums softly, sauté the minced onion and carrot in vegetable oil until **the color of wildflower honey**. Add these caramelized vegetables to the pot, taste for salt, and let the soup rest beneath a folded towel **for a couple of hours to deepen**.

Serve in warm bowls. Thick sour cream belongs on the side — not in the pot.

Fish & Creatures of the Deep

Despite the ocean rolling so close to our doorsteps, half the time the sea's offspring reach our kitchen in a frozen trance — though many are sent into that icy sleep right on the trawler, so it isn't nearly as tragic as one might fear. And once you put them through the alchemy described in this chapter, the results will rival a coastal fish market where lobsters twitch their antennae, crabs hiss like steam valves, and cuttlefish flex their pale tentacles in slow displeasure. And then, of course, there are the freshwater residents — hauled from their tanks alive, right under the astonished gaze of the customers.

Sturgeon

We've already spoken — reverently, I hope — about how to approach a sturgeon in the chapter on soup. We'll assume you've acquired one. Now pull on your gloves and, with a small but wickedly sharp knife, break the beast down into sections 8–10 cm thick (head and tail included!). Steam the pieces gently: arrange them in a deep sauté pan or a lidded pot, add a cup of water, and set over high heat. The moment the water begins to boil, pull the pot off the flame, let it rest under the lid, and slip the skin off — it will peel away like old wallpaper now. Slice the fillets cleanly from the cartilaginous spine. The skin, studded with prehistoric armor plates, goes straight into the bin; the spine, tail, and helmet-plated head go into the freezer — they're destined for stock later, and they *must not be wasted*.

You should now have large, ivory-pale pieces of sturgeon — barely cooked through, raw at the core, unsalted, boneless. Set aside as many as you want for frying or roasting today. The rest go into a ziplock bag and into the freezer for soup or *Tom Kha Talay*. And who knows — if fortune smiles — maybe one day you'll make a *real Olivier*.

From here the path forks, both roads promising glory. The simple route: dust the sturgeon in rice flour or starch and fry in a mix of vegetable and butter, about 5–6 minutes per side, then serve with *Hollandaise*.

To make a proper Hollandaise, set a bowl over a barely warm bain-marie (it uses a hot water bath to gently and evenly cook delicate sauces), think 140°F (60°C) — no hotter, and whisk 4 egg yolks with 1 tbsp water and 1 tbsp of 5% apple-cider vinegar. Whip 8–10 minutes, slowly, until the sabayon goes pale, thick, doubled or tripled in volume. Guard the temperature like a dragon — above 149°F (65°C) and the yolks will seize into scrambled tragedy. Touch the bowl: if your hand flinches, take it off the heat and keep whisking. A thermometer with a probe is a perfectly honorable crutch. Now — slowly, drop by drop at first — beat in 150 g melted, warm butter. Rush this step and the sauce will mutiny and split. When glossy and mayonnaise-thick, season with ¼ tsp salt and finish with 1 tbsp lemon juice.

P.S. Sturgeon with Herbs

You can also roast the sturgeon under a robe of herbs and cheese. Start by sweating two sliced **white onions** and **3–4 crushed cloves of garlic** in vegetable oil until gold and fragrant — then let them cool. Wash **2–3 generous bunches of cilantro** thoroughly (they love hiding sand between the stems), discard the tough stalks, and whirl the leaves in a blender along with the cooled onions and garlic, **70–100 g shiro miso paste**, **50 ml vegetable oil**, and **1 tsp sugar**. A pinch of fresh nutmeg or a handful of ground walnuts will do wonders here.

Lay the raw, barely-steamed pieces of sturgeon in a ceramic or glass baking dish, tuck them into the emerald paste, and blanket with **grated Gruyère or Parmigiano** — any respectable hard cheese will do. Bake at 450°F (230°C) for 25–30 minutes until the top bronzes like late-day sunlight on riverwater. Serve blazing hot.

And pour something worthy beside it — a rich yellow champagne made from Chardonnay grapes grown in the rolling hills of Carneros.

Halibut in Brownd Butter

Halibut — that broad-shouldered cousin of flounder — prowls the deep, cold waters of the North Pacific. Like flounder, yes, but infinitely finer: its flesh snow-white, tight-grained, silky but firm. Here in California, you can often buy it straight off the fishing piers, right beside the Dungeness crabs — remember those garlicky beauties we drowned in Marsala at the very beginning?

Choose a **halibut weighing a good 3–4 kilograms**. Make one long cut along the spine, head to tail, and lift the fillet cleanly off the bones — skin and all — with a fillet knife. (Blessedly, there are no scales.) The entire skeleton can go directly into stock; the fillets should be cut into neat portions for frying — something like 10 × 7 cm, 2–3 cm thick — and lightly salted.

Pour **150–200 g of rice flour** (wheat flour is fine in a pinch) into a deep dish and dredge each piece of fish well. Every surface must be dry and evenly coated.

Meanwhile, warm **2 tbsp vegetable oil** in a wide nonstick pan and melt **80–100 g butter** into it over medium heat. When the mixture begins to bubble and shimmer, lay in the floured halibut pieces with space between them, and immediately turn the heat up high. The flour needs to seize and seal the surface — if the juices run, the fish will steam, not fry.

Keep the pan moving — slide it back and forth by the handle so nothing sticks and the butter boils actively between the pieces. After 6–8 minutes, flip each portion with a wooden spatula: the underside should be crusted gold. Fry the second side another 6–8 minutes, then lift the fish onto pre-warmed plates.

This halibut is magnificent with the *Hollandaise* you made earlier for the sturgeon. Or — for something more refined — surround each piece with a leek *coulis*, following the recipe of the great *Michel Roux Sr.*

Trim **two large leeks** (about 500 g), using only the white parts. Split lengthwise, rinse out every stubborn grain of sand, and slice thinly. Melt **50 g butter** in a saucepan, add the leeks, and let them sweat gently for **10–15 minutes**. Pour in **2 cups fish stock**, **1 cup heavy cream (33%+ fat)**, add a couple of pinches of saffron, and let it whisper and reduce over low heat for 15–20 minutes, stirring occasionally. In the end, purée with an immersion blender until perfectly smooth, salt to taste, and spoon the hot *coulis* in a wide ring around each halibut portion.

Now open a bottle of **Mumm Napa Brut Rosé**, cold enough to haze the glass. That, to me, is exactly what quiet domestic happiness looks like.

Shrimp in Chinese Mayonnaise Sauce with Glazed Walnuts

This charming dish was invented not in Shanghai or Guangzhou, but right here in America — sometime in the 1980s — and now appears on Chinese menus from San Francisco to Boston. Its creator remains unknown, and although the word *fusion* usually makes me think of malicious La-Bu-Bu dolls with stitched-on smiles, here it actually feels... appropriate.

Take **about half a kilo of medium shrimp tails** (26–30 per pound). You can buy them in full chitin armor or already peeled. To save effort later, let them thaw slowly in a mixture of beaten egg whites and white *shiro* miso. That means you must remember to start in the morning, so by evening the shrimp will be waiting — plump, obedient, ready to hit the pan.

You will need:

- *Shiro* miso paste (1 tbsp)
- Egg whites (2–3)
- Vegetable oil (1 tbsp)
- Sugar (1 tsp)

Whisk everything in a wide plastic bowl until smooth, toss in the frozen shrimp straight from the freezer, and coat each one thoroughly. Cover the bowl with plastic wrap and leave at room temperature until dinner.

The “secret” Chinese mayonnaise sauce — is as simple as it gets:

- Mayonnaise (4 tbsp)
- Sweetened condensed milk (3 tbsp)
- Lemon juice (2 tsp)
- Honey (½ tbsp)

Whisk into a satiny, seamless sauce.

The “secret” walnut glaze — equally uncomplicated:

- Sugar (½ cup)
- Honey (2 tbsp)
- Water (½ cup)
- Frozen walnut halves (100–150 g)

In a shallow saucepan combine the sugar, honey, and water. Heat slightly above medium, stirring occasionally, until the syrup turns golden. Lower the heat, add the walnuts, and let them simmer and bubble 5–10 minutes, stirring so nothing burns. Lift the walnuts out with a slotted spoon, lay them in a single row on parchment, and let them dry to a crunchy lacquer.

Evening. Now everything comes together:

Remove the chitin shells from the shrimp, pull out the dark dorsal veins, discard the egg-white marinade, and slit each back slightly — like opening butterfly wings. Put **a few tablespoons of cornstarch** into a plastic bag, drop in the shrimp, and shake thoroughly until each is evenly dusted (Yes, this is a shortcut from the traditional multi-step dredging ritual — otherwise you’d stop reading and never cook this, and that would be tragic).

Heat **two centimeters of oil** in a wide non-stick skillet over medium-high. When it’s hot — really hot — fry the shrimp 3–4 minutes per side, until crisp and golden. Let them rest briefly on paper towels so excess oil leaves but the crunch remains. Then slide them into a glass bowl and pour in the secret mayonnaise sauce. Toss quickly and gently. Arrange the shrimp on a generous serving platter, crown them with the glazed walnuts — lavishly, joyfully — and serve immediately, while they still crackle between the teeth.

Important: Heat the oil thoroughly, but don’t scorch the coating. To test temperature, dip the edge of a bamboo spatula: a fringe of tiny bubbles should appear like a soft foam beard along the blade.

Octopus from Vivari

This is a dish that demands patience — ideally you should begin the day before your dinner.

Take **two large frozen octopuses (2–3 kg in total)**, rinse them, and place them into a stainless-steel pot. Add **2–3 whole heads of garlic**, unpeeled but with the tops sliced off, and **a bundle of thyme** tied with string so it can be pulled out later in one clean motion. Pour in **one cup of white wine** and drop in **100–150 g of butter**.

And here’s the key: Do. Not. Salt. Anything.

Clamp the lid down tight and leave the pot over the lowest heat for 1–1.5 hours. Octopus is made of formidable connective tissue — but once it reaches above ~70°C, that collagen quietly melts into gelatin. Keep it just below a boil, sealed in steel, and by the time you lift

the lid the next morning, the transformation will have already happened: the octopus will be floating in its own rosy juices mixed with melted butter.

Trust me — don't open that lid prematurely. Let the night do the work.

Next morning discard the thyme and what remains of the garlic. Lift out the octopus, remove the beak, and slice the tentacles into pieces the size of a fingertip phalanx. Strain all the buttery octopus' liquor through cheesecloth and reduce it over low heat to about half its volume. When it becomes glossy and concentrated, stir in **2–3 tablespoons of apple cider vinegar** and salt to taste. Now drown the sliced tentacles in this sauce and serve warm, scattered with a snowfall of **finely chopped cilantro leaves**.

Or — and some would say *this is the better path* — refrigerate the octopus in its sauce for a day. The flesh will tighten, mellow, and slowly drink in the tang of the vinegar. This is exactly how they serve it in *Vivari*, a tiny *Peloponnesian* village southeast of ancient *Mycenae*, where the sea is warm, the octopus is plentiful, and time — like good stock — is allowed to simmer.

PS: The *sous-vide* approach

If you're expecting a crowd and would rather not have cephalopods weighing on your mind all afternoon, this is where *sous-vide* earns its keep: 6 hours at 170°F (77°C) will turn rubbery octopus into velvet — tender, yielding, perfect for *frutti di mare* with cilantro, thin-shaved fennel and black Kalamata olives. Try it once and you won't go back.

And since we're here — let me tell you quickly what *sous-vide* actually is. Tough meat, a whole duck, anything dense and unfriendly to quick cooking — octopus included — is sealed into a plastic pouch, the air is drawn out with a vacuum sealer, and the package is slowly cooked at a precisely controlled low temperature in a water bath.

The science behind this is beautifully simple:

Under conventional roasting or pan-searing, the outer surface becomes much hotter than the interior — meaning that to reach 140°F (60°C) inside a leg of lamb, your oven must be blazing at 450°F (230°C). One moment of distraction, and you've overcooked it. Skill and vigilance are required.

With *sous-vide*, the cook simply sets the water bath to 140°F (60°C), walks away, and comes back later to perfectly cooked meat — no risk, no drama. In restaurants, this method guarantees the most valuable commodity in a professional kitchen: reproducibility.

PPS: The *confit* alternative

And of course, you can skip the water bath entirely. A slow cooker with temperature control filled with duck fat or vegetable oil will make octopus just as tender in the same amount of

time, at the same temperature. This slow oil-poaching technique is called *confit* — you’ve met it before when we made *duck confit*.

For octopus, it’s simple: 2 hours in hot oil at 176°F (80°C) — that’s it. Slow, steady, fool-proof. Afterwards, slide the tentacles under a broiler for a touch of char and serve immediately.

Pan-Fried Flounder

Flounder is like a slim, orphanage-raised cousin of halibut — leaner, humbler, but deeply grateful when kissed by butter. It fries beautifully in twenty unhurried minutes.

Choose a **medium flounder, about 2 centimeters thick**, just wide enough to lie comfortably in your largest nonstick skillet. Trim off the tail, remove the gills and innards, and snip away the frilled, prickly edge of the fins with kitchen scissors. Do not skin it. Flounder has no scales to speak of, and its skin adds flavor and structure in the pan. That’s the whole preparation — now simply salt it lightly and pat it dry with paper towels.

Meanwhile, heat a couple tablespoons of vegetable oil in a wide skillet and melt **50–70 g of butter** into it. Medium heat — you want the fat to foam gently, like champagne in a tall flute, not brown or smoke. When the butter begins to bubble, slide in the flounder — now just a single, round flatfish pancake staring up at you with one sorrowful eye.

After 8–10 minutes, slip a wooden spatula beneath and flip with care. Confirm that the underside has turned golden, like the crust on well-toasted brioche, then fry the second side for another 8–10 minutes. Serve immediately, on a warmed plate — simple, shining, and perfect.

Fish Baked in a Salt Crust

If you ever spot a live carp in a market tank — shimmering rainbow scales, weighing two kilos or so — take it home without hesitation. Yes, cleaning a carp is tedious, and the flesh hides more bones than seems fair, but that hardly matters when you bake the fish *whole*, sealed inside a salt shell.

Preheat your oven to 475°F (246°C), convection mode. Line a baking sheet with two layers of heavy foil and pour out a broad bed of salt — as long as the fish and about half a centimeter thick. No scaling, no gutting. Simply lay the whole carp onto the salt bed and bury it under another layer of salt, again about half a centimeter deep. Slide the tray into the oven and roast 30–40 minutes.

Now put on rubber gloves. Remove the fish from the oven and crack open its salt armor at once — *quickly*, before the salt begins to seep into that tender, pearl-white flesh. Lift out the entrails carefully (puncturing the gallbladder would release bitterness and spoil

everything), then gently flake the soft meat into a glass serving dish. Just remember — carp bones still remain, as numerous as stars, and must be removed patiently by hand.

If carp bones test your patience, use a large ocean fish instead, thawed if frozen. This one *must* be gutted, the gills removed, and two bruised stalks of lemongrass tucked into its belly. Lay the fish on the baking tray back-side up, its belly resting on the lemongrass so the flesh does not touch the salt bed below. Bake in the same salt crust — and serve at once with fresh, warm *Hollandaise*.

Giant Cuttlefish from the Indian Ocean — *Sepia apama*

Slow-thaw a large cuttlefish in the refrigerator — *Sepia apama*, a serious creature, about forearm-length, with a thick buoyancy tube (the walls are often 2–3 cm thick) and a frilled skirt running its perimeter. You can cut it into pieces and pan-cook it like squid — but roasting the whole beast in the oven is even better.

You'll usually find cuttlefish already skinned in the freezer section of *Koreana Plaza*. Choose the biggest and most handsome one — around two kilos.

Score the thick tube crosswise in a shallow diamond pattern with a sharp knife, careful not to cut all the way through. Lay it in a pot and pour in a dense marinade of **soy sauce, oyster sauce, fish sauce, and brown sugar**. The cuttlefish won't be fully submerged, so turn it once or twice as it rests. Add the head and tentacles, cover, and let it cure 12–24 hours in the refrigerator. In that time the flesh will swell, darken, and become glassy within — the salt and sugar binding moisture so it won't weep out during high-heat roasting.

In the morning, blot the marinade off with paper towels. Slice through the partitions, open the body tube flat, and lay it onto heavy foil folded 2–3 layers thick. Fold the foil edges slightly upward — just enough to keep any drippings from burning.

Preheat the oven to its absolute maximum — 500°F (260°C) — and heat a thick steel baking pizza slab on the top rack. (This technique lives in detail in the *Pizza* chapter — remember it takes about one hour for the slab to fully saturate with heat.)

Slide a pizza peel or stiff cardboard sheet under the foil with the cuttlefish and quickly transfer it onto the scorching steel. *Careful — it's volcanic.*

Close the oven and let the bottom roast on maximum heat for about 20 minutes. Cephalopods behave strangely when heated — they twist, contract, inflate, as though something alive were still inside them. If needed, press the cuttlefish flat with a wide plate or an inverted cast-iron pan.

Now turn the oven off and switch the broiler to full power. The logic is simple: the thermal mass of the steel slab cooks the underside evenly, while the broiler browns the top. Broil about 5–10 minutes, until the surface turns evenly golden.

Remove from the oven, tent loosely in foil, let it rest, then slice into portions and serve immediately.

Required:

- Cleaned cuttlefish, skin removed (1.5–2 kg) including tentacles
- Brown cane sugar (50 g)
- Rice flour or corn starch (3 tbsp)
- Soy sauce (100 ml)
- Oyster sauce (200 ml, *Lee Kum Kee* recommended)

Optional, but excellent:

- Fish sauce (4–5 tbsp, *Nuoc Mam Nhi*) for a deeper marinade

Fried Calamari from a Tiny Taverna in Alyki Bay, Gulf of Corinth

Thaw about a kilo of already-cleaned squid in a plastic container in the refrigerator — or simply in cold water if you're impatient. Of course, you could buy fresh squid or small cuttlefish at the market, peel away the skin and membrane yourself, and pull from each tube those long transparent plates that stand in for a spine — but let me warn you now: it's a project.

However you acquire them, cut the squid tubes into easy strips about 8 × 3 cm, and score each one into a shallow cross-hatched grid — long slashes, and then short ones, but do not cut all the way through. Why the grid? Because the moment those strips hit hot oil, they curl into cheerful golden diamonds like a net coming alive.

But first, soften them — give them seasoning and structure before frying. In a large plastic bowl whisk together cornstarch and water, then add fish sauce, sugar, a raw egg, sesame oil, a spoonful of lemon juice — and whisk again until smooth and glossy. If you lack sesame oil, use neutral cooking oil; if you have no fish sauce, you can always salt them later, once fried. Now drop in the scored squid strips, stir them well, cover with plastic wrap and leave them on the counter 1–2 hours.

Half an hour before frying, pour the entire bowl into a colander in the sink. Drain the marinade — you won't need it again — and lay the squid on a wide plate, blotting them dry with paper towels. They must be absolutely dry. Dust them with another **½ cup of cornmeal or cornstarch**, tossing with your hands until every strip is evenly coated.

Heat **about 3 cups (≈ 600 ml)** of neutral oil in a wide, deep steel or non-stick pan to 360°F (180°C) — a probe thermometer is ideal here — and lower the squid in. They must float freely. Wear rubber gloves if that makes you braver, and keep a lid nearby in case the oil spits. If you have too many strips, fry in two or even three batches. Heat: slightly above medium.

After 2–3 minutes, lift and stir with a skimmer spoon — those broad perforated ladles perfect for the job. The strips will have curled beautifully by now; turn them and let them brown another 2–3 minutes. In the end they should be golden, crisp at the edges, tender inside. Scoop them out onto paper towels to absorb excess oil.

Required:

- Cleaned squid tubes (5–6 pcs, or approximately 1 kg)
- Cornstarch (2 tbsp)
- Water (2 tbsp)
- Lemon juice (1 tbsp)
- Sugar (1 tbsp)
- Egg (1)
- Cornmeal or additional cornstarch for dredging (½ cup)
- Neutral frying oil (3 cups or 600 ml)

Optional, but lovely:

- Sesame oil (*Lee Kum Kee*, 1 tbsp)
- Fish sauce (*Nuoc Mam Nhi*, 2–3 tbsp)

Important: Heat the oil well — but not to the point of scorching the coating. If you dip the edge of a bamboo spatula into the oil, it should bloom with a lace of tiny bubbles — then, and only then, fry. Work in two batches — crispness rewards patience.

Lobster Thermidor

Most people are simply terrified of lobsters. They spot those armored creatures in the supermarket and veer away like from a tax audit — or worse, they throw them straight into boiling water. The price doesn't help either: What if I ruin this precious, moody sea beast? Relax — we're going to do this properly. All you need is a Costco tray of **frozen lobster tails** and one crucial skill: thawing. Just move the whole foam package from freezer to refrigerator overnight. Or, if you're cooking tonight, drop the tails into a bowl of **50% heavy cream** for half an hour — it works like a charm.

Now slip on rubber gloves, pick up a pair of kitchen shears, and cut through the green–brown lobster armor from the base of the tail toward the fan. You're cutting only the dorsal shell — leave the belly and the small walking legs untouched. Gently pry the cut edges apart with your fingers, just enough to tuck inside a **stick of butter**, roughly **4 × 2 × 2 cm**. Do this with each tail — this is your only real labor here.

Arrange the prepared tails in a ceramic roasting dish or Pyrex tray, butter-side up. Slide them into an oven preheated to 450°F (230°C) for 15–20 minutes. When the shells blush red and the butter has melted into the flesh, pull them out and lay over each tail a **thin slab**

of French brie or German cambozola, about $\frac{1}{2}$ **cm thick**, enough to blanket the tail nearly end-to-end. Return the tray to the oven for another 5–10 minutes, or set it under the broiler (grill) until the cheese turns molten, golden and scorch-speckled like the crust of a very good baguette.

Serve each tail on its own plate — ideally with proper lobster crackers or a curved crab-pick, so every sweet pearl of meat can be rescued from its shell.

Wine pairing: A young Spanish *Albariño* — *Faustino Rivero Ulecia*, for instance — is perfect. Just don't forget to chill it properly. The colder the bottle, the happier the lobster.

Sashimi

Sashimi calls for only the freshest fish — the kind flash-frozen at sea, on the boat, while the catch is still glittering and cold from the ocean. The key is not just how it was frozen, but how it's thawed afterward. If you're new to this, start with **salmon and tuna**. Don't fear parasites — once properly frozen, they are gone. Truly.

If you've bought good sashimi-grade fish at Koreana Plaza, simply tuck it — still sealed — into the back of the fridge inside a polypropylene container with a lid. Leave it there overnight, or even a full day. Lay a couple of paper towels on the bottom of the container to absorb any meltwater. Slow thawing preserves the firmness and that almost-sweet ocean smell.

Once thawed, slice the fish into pieces of whatever geometry pleases you — about 1 cm thick — and arrange them on beautiful Japanese plates. Add a tear of wasabi paste, a dish of dipping sauce, and don't forget **pickled ginger**, which Koreans and Japanese sell alongside wasabi. You'll want about **50 g per serving**. Trust me — it elevates everything.

And since sashimi is lonely without its sauce:

Pour $\frac{1}{2}$ cm of vegetable oil into a small pan and warm it gently. Add:

- a 5–6 cm nub of ginger, finely chopped
- 2 stalks of green onion, sliced thin
- 1 stalk of lemongrass, crushed with a kitchen mallet
- 3–4 cm of galangal, if you have it
- 1–2 whole chilies, slit lengthwise if you like heat

Let everything simmer on low for 10–15 minutes, just until fragrant. Remove from heat, let it cool slightly, then strain or pour the oil into a small bowl, discarding the spent aromatics.

Now whisk in:

- 50 ml regular soy sauce

- 20 ml dark soy sauce (optional)
- 1 tbsp brown sugar
- 2 tbsp Marsala wine

Cover and refrigerate until serving. Right before dinner, whisk again until glossy and unified, then pour into tiny dipping dishes — one per guest, as it should be.

Wine pairing: Serve sashimi with a bottle of chilled, feather-light Portuguese *Vinho Verde*. Cold, fresh, and green like sea wind — the perfect companion.

Meat

We talked way back at the beginning about how to sear a proper steak from excellent beef. Now let's see what can be done with other meats. We'll start with lamb and pork. Then move on to hearts and tongues — and after that, we'll just let curiosity lead.

Before anything else, you'll need a good knife for breaking down large cuts. I'd recommend German steel — Henckels, Wüsthof, or Solingen. First in line: a small 3–5 inch paring knife made of X50 CrMoV15 steel. Naturally, it must be sharp. So do yourself a favor and buy a proper sharpening stone — a two-sided *whetstone* with medium grit J1000 and fine J3000. Hone the blade on the fine side under a thin stream of water, holding the edge at a shallow 10–15° angle and drawing it toward you in one smooth direction. Repeat on the opposite face of the blade. It won't take more than two minutes — and you'll have a knife that cuts like intention itself.

Pan-Seared Lamb in Half an Hour

Good lamb needs no sorcery. Take a rack of young lamb — sliced into medallions 1.5 cm thick, rib bone still in place — or loin chops, tenderloin, any of those sweet muscles running along the spine. Heat a wide non-stick skillet with a slick of oil and lay the lamb in with carrot pieces the size of your pinky finger and whole cloves of garlic. The carrots will caramelize in the lamb fat and turn sweet. On high heat: about 10 minutes per side, turning once or twice. Then salt, lower the heat slightly, splash in half a cup of Marsala (100 ml), and let it boil away quickly. That's it — and those caramelized carrots with Marsala lend a honeyed edge and soften lamb's wildness in the most pleasing way.

Serve it with a silky celery-root *coulis*:

Peel a large celeriac (about half a kilo), dice, and simmer in a saucepan of boiling water until tender. Blend it with a cup of heavy cream until smooth as thought. If it comes out too dense, loosen it with a knob of butter or a little more cream. Salt, pepper — done. Spoon it beside the lamb.

If you prefer something brighter, swap the celeriac for the same weight of young green peas: five minutes in boiling water, then blitz with cream just as you did before. Pea *coulis* makes lamb feel like spring.

Important: for the lamb skillet — high heat first, medium heat after.

I would pour alongside this lamb a splendid *Crozes-Hermitage* from the northern Rhône — built on *Syrah*, with sometimes a flirt of white grapes, *Marsanne* or *Roussanne*, for intrigue and lift.

Slow-Roasted Lamb Shoulder or Ribs — a Five-Hour Story

And what about those other cuts of lamb — the ones streaked with stubborn connective tissue and veined with fat? They're hopeless for quick searing. But *shoulder and ribs* (lamb shoulder, ribs, shanks) were made for the oven.

Cut the ribs into comfortable pieces, roughly a pound each. **A whole shoulder** can go in as one glorious slab. Rub every piece generously with oyster sauce and let them lounge at room temperature for two hours. Then wrap each piece separately: first in a sheet of parchment (culinary parchment), adding **5–6 peeled garlic cloves** to each parcel, then seal the parcel tight in two thick layers of wide aluminum foil. Be lavish with the foil — it traps steam and lamb fat, letting the meat braise in its own juices, never drying.

Arrange the wrapped bundles, about a kilo each, on a foil-lined baking tray and slide them into a 340°F (170°C) oven for 1½ hours. After that, drop the temperature to 270°F (130°C) and roast for another four hours.

When it's time to serve, cut the foil open, peel back the parchment, lift the meat into a clay or glass baking dish, and let it pick up some color under the broiler. Serve with vegetables or a salad. And pour out the lamb fat — it smells rather fierce and is useful to no one.

Important: If you crave a crisp caramelized crust, whisk together *2 tbsp honey* and *2 tbsp 5% apple cider vinegar* (balsamic works too). Beat in *a couple tablespoons of vegetable oil*. Brush this glaze over the shoulder or ribs, turn the broiler to high, and give them another 5–10 minutes in the oven until the surface bronzes and shines.

Pork Ribs — Low Heat, High Certainty

A slab of pork belly (or pork flank) where ribs and silvery connective seams alternate with pockets of fat — there is hardly anything to *chew* on, yet everything needed to make something wonderful. Cut it into manageable pieces, roughly *20 × 8 cm*, place them in a steel pot and drown them in a thick marinade whipped from oyster sauce and soy. If you have cinnamon, green pods of cardamom, cheerful yellow ginger and a star anise or two — send them into the marinade as well. Without spices it will still emerge surprisingly life-affirming, but with them you'll feel you're steering something properly decadent.

Let the ribs rest in this bath at least half a day; better still, forget about them in the refrigerator for a full 24 or even 48 hours.

When the time comes, lay 3–4 pieces of pork belly onto a sheet of culinary parchment and wrap them tightly — the parchment shields the meat from drying out in the oven. Do *not* discard the marinade; it has more to give. Now roll the parchment bundle in **two generous layers of heavy foil**, snug as a winter coat: the steam and pork fat will remain inside, cooking the meat gently in its own essence. Don't be stingy with the foil.

Set the parcels on a foil-lined baking tray and into a 340°F (170°C) oven they go for 1½ hours. Then lower to 270°F (130°C) and leave them for another 3–4 hours. In that time the excess fat renders out, basting the meat, coaxing the connective tissue between the ribs into tenderness.

For the finale, open the foil and parchment, transfer the ribs to a clay or glass roasting dish, brush them with the remaining marinade and brown them quickly under the broiler. Or, if you prefer a glossy finish, use ***Kikkoman teriyaki glaze*** instead. As always — pour off all the pork fat; delicious as the ribs are, that richness is too heavy to keep.

You'll Need:

- Pork ribs (5–8 kg)
- Oyster sauce (2–3 cups)
- Soy sauce (1 cup)

Optional Spices:

- Cinnamon sticks (3)
- Star anise (4)
- Fresh ginger (100 g)
- Cardamom pods (5)

Chinese Red Pork — Fast, Expensive, and Beautiful

For this dish, choose the priciest, softest cut you can: ***pork tenderloin***. It's a small, slender muscle tucked just beneath the two long columns of meat that run along the spine (those are the pork loins). This delicate strip hardly works during a pig's short but vivid life, which is precisely why it's so tender.

Take **two tenderloins**, cover them with **one cup of oyster sauce**, and leave overnight in the refrigerator. If you want the meat to pick up a little heat and an elegant ruby sheen, grate in **5–6 cm of ginger** and **one raw beet**, and let it rest in that mixture for 12–24 hours — not required, simply delightful.

Before your guests arrive, preheat the convection oven as high as it will go — 475–500°F (246–260°C). Wipe excess sauce off the tenderloins, place them on a foil-lined baking tray, and roast for about 30 minutes. What matters most is the ***internal temperature***: you must not overcook this cut. Check with a metal probe thermometer, and the moment it reaches 140°F (60°C), pull the tray out of the oven.

Tip for a crackling caramelized crust: In a small bowl whisk together **2 tbsp honey** and **2 tbsp 5% apple cider vinegar** (balsamic works too), then whisk in a **couple tablespoons of vegetable oil**. Brush this glaze generously over the top of the tenderloins.

Turn on the broiler, return the meat to the oven for 5–10 minutes, but watch closely — internal temperature must not climb above 150°F.

Wine Pairing: Red Bordeaux is perfection here — from the southwestern French region that has been growing grapes since Roman times. Its classic grapes — *cabernet sauvignon*, *cabernet franc*, *merlot*, *petit verdot*, *malbec*, *carménère* — allow endless variations, which local winemakers explore with the patience of jewel-cutters.

Roast Pork Shank with Crackling Skin — Slow, But Great Fun

Whenever a pig is broken down, a surprising number of inexpensive cuts remain — often still wrapped in skin as thick as hide. The Chinese mastered the art of making pork both tender and crackling, and we'll borrow from that ancient, slow, street-food tradition. There is no single canonical method — so take **pork shoulder**, **pork hocks**, **shanks**, anything with bone inside and skin still on, the very thing that turns into a golden, airy crust in skilled hands.

Cut the shanks and shoulders into manageable 1–2 kg pieces. It makes sense to cook several at once — two shanks, a shoulder, perhaps a hock or two. Pack the pork into a large stainless-steel pot and add all the spices, one cup of soy sauce, and two cups of oyster sauce. Mix thoroughly and leave to marinate 24–48 hours in the fridge, turning the pieces 2–3 times a day.

When cooking day arrives, wipe off the excess marinade with paper towels and slice 4–5 onions into thin feathers. Now take a huge sheet of **culinary parchment**, wrap each piece of pork tightly, tucking in plenty of fresh onion slices and spices from the marinade — this keeps the meat from drying out. Wrap each parchment bundle again — **twice** — in heavyweight foil. The logic is simple: slow heat melts connective tissue, pork fat and onion juice turn to broth, and the gelatin soaks into both meat and skin, making them soft, lush, and flavorful.

Place all the bundles on a foil-lined baking sheet and slide into the oven at 250°F (121°C) for 6–7 hours. Yes, it's long — but trust me, absolutely worth it. After 6–7 hours, tear open the parcels, transfer the shanks either into a clay or glass baking dish or back onto the same foil-lined tray. Mix together **1 cup brown sugar** and **4–5 tbsp apple cider vinegar**, brush the skin generously with this glaze, and turn the oven to maximum heat — 500°F (260°C). Roast until the skin bubbles and bronzes, another ~40 minutes, turning pieces every 15 minutes and glazing constantly.

Wear good rubber gloves — crackling skin burns without mercy. If your oven has a broiler, you can finish much faster: raise the tray closer to the element, broil on full power, and keep brushing the skin with sugar-vinegar glaze until it blisters and shines.

Meat:

- Pork shoulder, pork shanks, pork hocks (5–8 kg)
- Onions (4–5)
- Oyster sauce (*Lee Kum Kee* — 2–3 cups)
- Soy sauce (1 cup)
- Apple cider vinegar 5% (5 tbsp)

Spices:

- Cinnamon sticks (4–5)
- Star anise (5–8)
- Cloves (10–15)
- Ginger (100 g)

Optional additions:

- White peppercorns (6–8)
- Cardamom pods (5–10)
- Ground fenugreek (*methi* — 2 tbsp)
- Cumin (*jeera* — 2 tbsp)
- Mild curry powder, *10-spice blend* (2 tbsp)

Crisp Pork Belly with Skin — A Quick, Cloud-Light Roast

Well... “quick” meaning about two hours, give or take. This is another old, beautifully reliable recipe from the countryside kitchens of China. The Chinese have a deep, instinctive love for pork fat — you’ll see glistening slabs of crispy pork belly, skin crackling like lacquer, hanging right next to Beijing duck in the hot-food stalls of big Asian markets like Ranch 99. To recreate that same magic at home, you’ll need one generous slab of pork belly, about 25 × 20 cm and roughly a kilo in weight. The only non-negotiable requirement is the skin — do not buy belly without it. Avoid overly thick cuts, too: they tend to be nothing but pale fat. The sweet spot is about 3 cm thick, alternating layers of meat and white fat. Don’t worry about the richness — most of the fat will render away in the oven, leaving you with something rustic, fragrant, and deeply satisfying.

Scrape the skin clean with a small sharp knife and pat it completely dry with paper towels. No need for obsession — just make sure the surface feels smooth and dry. Lay the belly skin-side down on a board (important!) and score the meat crosswise every 3 cm, stopping halfway down toward the skin. Turn the slab 90° and repeat. You should end up with a checkerboard of neat 3 × 3 cm cubes, about 2 cm deep. Pat dry again, then massage the cuts with a mixture of salt, brown sugar, and spices. Tuck shards of star anise and thin garlic petals right into the cuts — like tiny aromatic anchors. Spoon a little oyster sauce over the top, letting it seep into all the corners.

Fold a large sheet of heavy-duty foil into two or even four layers and set the pork belly in the center — *now* skin-up, meat-down. Curl the edges up to form a tight shallow tray about 3 cm tall, exposing only the smooth skin. Brush the skin with 5% vinegar and blot it dry — this first wash dehydrates the surface so it will blister beautifully later. Scatter over a teaspoon of salt, brush again with vinegar, and blot once more. Now it's ready for the oven.

Slide the foil tray onto a rack in a convection oven heated to 200–220°F (93–104°C). After 20 minutes, open the door, pull out the rack, brush the skin with vinegar, then blot gently with a towel. After one hour total, check whether the skin has dried and the vinegar has evaporated. Brush the top lightly with vegetable oil, then raise the heat to 400°F (205°C) — convection still on. Your goal now is blistering: bubbles, crackling, golden sunburned peaks. This will take around 40 minutes.

Remove the tray, transfer the pork belly to a cutting board skin-side up, and slice into warm, crunchy squares.

Essential:

- Skin-on pork belly (1 kg)
- Oyster sauce (4 tbsp)
- 5% vinegar (5 tbsp)

Spice mix:

- Star anise (4–6 whole pods, optional)
- Garlic (thin slices tucked between the cuts, optional)
- Salt (2 tbsp)
- Brown cane sugar (5 tbsp)
- Ground cumin (*jeera* 2 tbsp)
- Chinese five-spice, *a blend of star anise, clove, cinnamon, Sichuan pepper, fennel seed* (4 tbsp)

Orange-Braised Pork — Slow, Simple, and Radiant with Citrus

This recipe I'm giving in memory of chef *Alexei Zimin* and his three wonderful books. It was invented for the cheapest, toughest cuts of pork — the kind most people overlook. There is no marinade, no frills here: just straightforward cooking with things you usually have lying around the kitchen. Pork neck, shoulder, picnic ham, Boston butt — any of these will work. Bone-in is fine, skin-off is necessary.

So — take two solid slabs of meat, 4–5 kilos total. We are not here to fuss with timid quantities, right? Cut them into manageable pieces, about half to one kilo each. Squeeze the juice from five oranges, shaving a few long strips of zest from every fruit — and remember to avoid the white pith underneath: bitterness lurks there. If fresh oranges haven't

happened to enter your house today, use four to five cups of store-bought juice. Or even a generous pour of full-bodied yellow Chardonnay — it works surprisingly well.

Now stir the juice and zest together, add four large onions, chopped not too finely, along with spices, honey, and half a cup of vegetable oil. A cup of soy sauce is ideal — but if none is available, two tablespoons of salt will do the job. If you like heat, drop in a couple of red chilies. They play beautifully with sweetness.

Arrange your pieces of pork in a wide stainless pot, pour the orange mixture over the top, cover with a lid, and slide it into the oven at 280°F (138°C) for six hours. You can even lower the heat to 250°F (121°C) and leave it for 7–8 hours, if the day is long and no one is watching the clock. What comes out will be meat tender as a ripe fig splitting under its own weight, with a flavor that is distinctly sweet — or sweet-hot, if chilies were invited. And the only thing you'll want to add at the table is a handful of thinly sliced white onion, lightly pickled in a 1:1 mix of sweet white wine and vinegar. As *Zimin* wrote once, *“with the right tilt of gastronomic vision, you might not quite make the pig fly — but you’ll see her consider the option.”*

Essential:

- Pork shoulder / neck / Boston butt (4–5 kg)
- Onions (4 large)
- Orange juice (4–5 cups and/or white wine)
- Vegetable oil (½ cup, 100 ml)
- Soy sauce (1 cup, 150 ml)

Spices:

- Oregano (3 tbsp)
- Star anise (1 whole pod)
- Ginger (100 g)
- Cardamom (2–3 pods)
- Ground cumin (*jeera*, 2 tbsp)
- Honey or sugar (3 tbsp)
- Hot red chili (1–2 pods, optional)

And with this orange-glazed pork, I'd pour a glass of dark ruby *Carménère* from Chile — fragrant, structured, and just bold enough to keep up.

Beef Tongue with Quince and White Wine — a diamond in the rough...

Don't be frightened by those frozen ox-tongues glowering from the butcher's counter like relics from a monastic exorcism fresco. They only *look* intimidating. In truth, they are

magnificent — I’ve cooked them dozens of times, and I’m still in love with their unforgettable dark, tender flesh.

Take **three large beef tongues**, drop them into a roomy stainless pot, cover with water, and let them simmer gently for about two hours. Then haul the pot to the sink, drain the boiling water, and run cold water over the tongues for ten minutes — this will loosen the skin and make your next task less of a trial. With a small, sharp paring knife, peel away the coarse, speckled rind — the same tough armor the cow once used to grasp meadow grasses. Yes, it’s not the most poetic stage of the process, but it rewards you with a heap of dense, dark meat marbled with fat. After a couple more hours of braising with onions, all that fat and hard-worked connective tissue will melt into a gelatin-rich sauce — the sort that makes children’s lips stick together. Now trim away the fat and sinew from the underside. These scraps, along with the discarded skin, can be gifted to a friendly neighborhood dog, who will never forget your kindness.

Slice the cleaned tongues crosswise into round medallions about two centimeters thick and arrange them snugly in a low stainless pot or a glass casserole with a lid. Add **four finely chopped white onions**, a **whole head of garlic separated into cloves**, and **two to three sliced quinces** (or apples, or even pitted plums if quince is nowhere to be found). Pour in **half a liter of white wine**, cover, and slide the pot into a 425°F (218°C) oven for about forty minutes. Once everything is merrily bubbling, reduce the heat to 300°F (150°C) and let the tongues braise for another hour and a half to two hours.

About an hour before the finish, add a tablespoon of salt and whatever spices speak to you. Thyme and galangal are lovely here, but if they’re absent, a tablespoon of mild curry powder will do the job gracefully.

Serve these braised tongues with a full-bodied, luminous yellow Chardonnay — ideally one born in vineyards along the Russian River.

Turkey Legs & Wings in Orange Sauce

Here’s a short and wonderfully straightforward recipe for a generous dinner for three to five people. Whenever you break down a turkey — that plump, modern dinosaur — you’re left with a heap of dark, stubborn meat: the massive legs, the neck, and those surprisingly large wings. Assume you’ve already sliced the breasts into homemade turkey jerky, the carcass is headed for stock — but what becomes of the rest? If you have freshly squeezed orange juice, you can turn those leftovers into tender, luscious meat in just a couple of hours, no brining, no fuss.

Strip the skin off both turkey legs. Cut them apart through the knee joint. Fish out the neck and the gizzards — they’re usually cleaned and halved already — and separate the wings from the frame, skin-on. Arrange all these noble scraps in a deep glass pan or a steel roasting tray with high sides. Spoon a little vegetable oil over the bottom, scatter in a large chopped onion, add a tablespoon of salt and ten whole cloves of garlic, then pour in enough

orange juice to cover the meat by about two thirds. If bottled juice is all you have — perfectly fine, we're not staging a royal banquet.

Heat the oven to 425°F (218°C) and braise your turkey in its citrus bath until the juice reduces to a thick, glossy sauce — about two hours, give or take. Turn the pieces once or twice so they brown evenly. If the juice cooks down too fast, splash in a cup of white wine. When the meat finally slumps into tenderness, pull the pan from the oven, let it cool just enough to serve, and bring it to the table warm — ideally with a cabbage or tomato salad alongside.

*A wine pairing? Dark, silky turkey in a bright orange glaze calls for a great Spanish *Ribera del Duero*, born on the banks of the river Duero in northern Spain. The local hero there is *tempranillo*.*

When the Beef Lets You Down — Turn It into *Julienne*

It happens to the best of us: that handsome piece of beef you proudly carried home from the supermarket turns out chewy and stubborn — absolutely unfit for steaks. No tragedy here. With a little patience you can transform it into a delicate, fragrant julienne of meat and mushrooms, a dish that's lovely hot but arguably even better cold the next morning.

Let's turn to one of the fundamental techniques of Chinese cooking — softening muscle fibers by marinating and then searing over high heat. Take a sharp knife and slice the beef into thin pieces, about half a centimeter thick, *across* the grain. Stack the slices three at a time and cut them again lengthwise into ribbons about a centimeter wide. You should end up with tender meat strips, half a centimeter thick, one to two centimeters across, and of variable length. You can do the very same thing with duck breast — and the julienne will turn out even more refined.

Next step: into a deep bowl go **4 tablespoons of soy sauce**, **1 heaping tablespoon of fine rice flour or corn starch**, and **1 egg**. Whisk until smooth. If the mixture seems too thick or the starch hasn't fully dissolved, add a splash or two of **white wine**. Now drop in your meat ribbons, knead them lightly by hand so the starch can penetrate, and let them rest for 3–4 hours at room temperature. In that time the fibers will relax, tenderize, and take on flavor.

While the meat is “thinking things over,” finely chop a **large onion** (or **two small shallots**, which work beautifully here) and sauté in vegetable oil over medium heat until honey-colored. Clean **half a kilo of mushrooms** — button or portobello — slice them thinly and add to the softened onions. Let everything simmer on medium for about twenty minutes. If the mushrooms begin to stick, just deglaze with half a **cup of white wine**. Once tender, scrape the mixture into a bowl and wash the pan — you'll need it for the meat.

Set a large skillet or wok over high heat, add fresh oil, and lay the marinated meat strips out in a single layer. Here's the entire trick: sliced thin and coated with starch and egg, the meat needs to be fried *fast* in small batches. Too much in the pan and it'll steam instead of sear.

Give each batch 6–10 minutes until the surface browns and the inside stays soft. Remove the finished strips to a bowl, wipe the skillet clean, refresh the oil, and repeat until all the meat is done.

To finish, fold the beef into the mushrooms and onions in a ceramic or glass baking dish, scatter a modest layer of good cheese — *Gruyère* or *Parmigiano* — across the top and slide into a hot oven at 475°F (246°C) for 15–20 minutes, or under a broiler for about ten. Serve bubbling and fragrant. And tomorrow, cold from the fridge, it will be perfect again — a quiet reward for yesterday’s patience.

Note: a good crust only happens over high heat. Don’t be shy with the flame.

I would pour a Spanish *Rioja* alongside — a wine of the Basque north, built on *tempranillo* and made for evenings like this.

Restless Little Hearts

The very same Chinese trick that rescues tough beef — tenderizing with starch and egg — can redeem even the most modest poultry scraps, including chicken hearts. Don’t turn up your nose: once treated properly, they’ll come back to you transformed and unrecognizable — lively, savory, and deeply satisfying. Take about a kilo of fresh hearts and trim away the top portion where the vessels cluster, along with that little band of fat wrapped around the upper rim. Off it goes.

In a deep bowl whisk together oyster sauce, a splash of sesame oil, a spoonful of rice flour or plain cornstarch, and one egg until smooth. Drop in the cleaned hearts, and massage them well with your hands so the starch and albumin sink into the meat and begin their quiet alchemy. Leave them to rest for two hours at room temperature.

Now heat a little vegetable oil in a wide nonstick skillet and tumble in the entire bowl of marinated hearts. If you’re fond of warm, sweet spice, add a stick of cinnamon or a couple of star anise pods — optional, but enchanting. Keep the heat medium and stir occasionally with a wooden spatula as the hearts soften — about 30–40 minutes. Toward the end, when most of the sauce has bubbled away, pour in half a cup of Marsala and let it reduce over high heat. What emerges will be a new discovery altogether: springy, dark meat cloaked in anise-and-cinnamon perfume.

Required:

- Chicken hearts, trimmed (about 1 kg)
- Rice flour or cornstarch (1 tbsp)
- Oyster sauce (½ cup, 80–100 ml)
- Egg (1)

Optional additions:

- Sesame oil (2 tbsp)
- Marsala (100 ml)
- Cinnamon stick (1)
- Star anise (2 pods)

With this dark, resilient meat in its warm spice lacquer, I would pour a bottle of *Gigondas* — one of my favorite sterns, provincial Rhônes. Three or four years of age is quite enough. *Gigondas* is grown in the old Roman spa-town of the same name in Vaucluse, Provence — a place where the Rhône valley narrows, where Petrarch once walked with his Laura along the “cool crystal waters” of the Sorgue. A proper *Gigondas Rouge* should rely on at least 80% *grenache*, the rest filled with *syrah* — austere, sun-dark, and perfect for a dish like this.

Pork in Sweet-and-Sour Kumquat Glaze

A dish like this can easily take the center of a long table and feed five, maybe ten guests — especially if you serve it beside a pot of fragrant basmati, steamed, dried, and fluffed to perfection. But first comes the soul of the whole affair — a bright, amber-gold sweet-and-sour sauce built entirely around kumquats.

For the sauce:

- Kumquats, halved (400 g)
- Sugar (200 g)
- Butter (60 g)

Wash the kumquats, slice them neatly in half, and stir them with sugar and butter in a wide nonstick skillet over low heat. As the sugar melts and the fruit begins to surrender its juice, take the pan off the flame and let it cool a little; then return it to low heat and bring it back to a soft simmer. At this moment — and only now — add **a pinch of good Iranian saffron**, **5–6 whole green cardamom pods**, and **a few sticks of cinnamon**, letting their oils tinge the syrup with warm spice. Turn the heat down again, cool the pan slightly, then warm it a third time until the kumquats turn tender and translucent like tiny stained-glass domes. Your sauce is essentially ready (and it will keep for a couple of weeks in an airtight container). Which means — onward, to the meat.

For 4–5 servings:

- Pork tenderloin (800 g)
- Egg (1)
- Cornstarch for dredging (1 cup)
- Neutral oil for frying — peanut, rice-bran, or refined vegetable (2 cups)
- Cashews (1 cup)

- Soy sauce (3 tbsp)
- Your kumquat sauce (1 cup)
- Sesame seeds (2 tbsp)

Cut the tenderloin into small pieces, each about half the length of an index finger, and coat them with beaten egg. Mix well with your hands — cooking starts with touch — then tumble the pieces into cornstarch, dusting them evenly and generously.

Heat a wok or deep skillet and bring your frying oil to 350°F (177°C). Fry the pork in batches — small batches — so it sears instead of stewing, turning lightly golden in eight or nine minutes. Lift each batch onto paper towels to drain, and proceed until all the meat is crisped.

Now wipe the wok clean, crank the flame to high, add two fresh tablespoons of oil, and return all the pork to the pan along with **a cup of dry cashews**. Pour in the kumquat sauce and a splash of soy for umami, stirring constantly with a bamboo spatula. In a few minutes, lower the heat and let the sauce thicken and lacquer the meat in a glossy orange-amber sheen. Another five — maybe ten — minutes, depending on your pan. When the nuggets shine like candied jewels, scatter over the sesame seeds, toss once or twice, and serve on a wide platter. Meat — separately. Rice — separately. Let your guests assemble their own pleasure.

And if you want something decadent beside it — glaze a handful of walnut halves. Simmer **½ cup sugar** with **½ cup water** until golden, add **100–150 g walnuts**, stir five to ten minutes, lift them out with a skimmer, and dry on parchment in a single glittering row. A minute in the oven won't hurt.

Tip: This recipe works just as beautifully with chicken — white breast meat or dark thigh, no changes in proportions, no change in method. The only law here: hot oil. Very hot oil. The bamboo-spoon test never lies — dip the flat edge in, and look for a beard of tiny silver bubbles.

With sweet-and-sour pork I'd pour a confident *red Bordeaux*; with chicken — a good, honest Spanish *Cava Brut*, ice-cold and lively.

A Feast Made Simple: Slow-Roasted Meats for Many

There comes a moment in every home cook's life when you realize the limits of frying pans and portioned steaks. Ten guests are coming, the fridge is full, and there is no physical way to sear ribeyes to order while juggling sides, crab, and fish like a short-staffed brasserie. That's when we turn to the ancient, deeply comforting solution: roasting whole birds and massive cuts of meat.

A turkey in full regalia. Two ducks, maybe three. A couple of lamb legs or beef joints the size of firewood. They feed a crowd without frenzy — and nothing pairs better than a loose, fragrant Persian saffron pilaf made with steamed basmati. Not the fastest route, perhaps, but one of the most reliable and least stressful ways to feed an army using nothing more exotic than a home oven.

Step One — The Essential Brine (non-negotiable)

Skip this step and your roast will either dry out, or stay annoyingly tough. Brining is why restaurant roasts are succulent and forgiving — and why fast-food poultry rarely is. What does salt do inside meat? Two things:

First, osmosis. Salt draws water in and keeps it there, even as heat tries to drive it out. Sugar, meanwhile, helps salt pass deeper into muscle fibers and distribute evenly rather than sit on the surface like cold frost.

Second, salt changes protein structure. It subtly firms the muscle so that, after roasting, the texture is both tender and springy — that elusive restaurant quality we call *juicy*. Brine also boosts flavor from the inside out. A miracle in a pot.

All you need is:

- 1 small cup of salt (150–200 g)
- 1 small cup of brown sugar (about 150 g)
- 5–6 liters of water

Heston Blumenthal suggests an 8% brine and pages of scientific footnotes, but let's be practical. I've brined meat more times than I can count, and a teacup of salt in a large pot works just fine. The only rule: don't rush.

A 15–20 liter stainless stockpot will hold one turkey, or two or three ducks, or a couple of lamb legs, or three or four large beef pieces (a tri-tip works beautifully). Pretty much anything you want — the magic is in the waiting.

How to Make the Brine

Pour one liter of water into the pot. Add the salt and sugar, halve two heads of unpeeled garlic, toss in a few white peppercorns, maybe two inches of ginger if you're feeling

generous. Bring it to a boil just long enough for the crystals to dissolve. Then top up with cold water.

Lower the meat into the brine — gently, like launching a ship — and leave it outside overnight, provided the air is neither freezing nor above 73°F (23°C). If your turkey resembles a small Zeppelin and won't fit into a pot, use a heavy plastic bag filled with chilled brine, nestle it into a cardboard box, and tie it shut so the saltwater wraps the bird like a tailored coat.

Important: timing is everything. Begin brining the day before the feast — the roast deserves the night to drink, relax, and become someone's unforgettable dinner.

The Low-and-Slow Method for Butter-Soft Meat

In the morning, lift the meat from its brine, trim off any excess fat, and cut it into three pieces of roughly 1–2 kilos each. Now take a generous sheet of **culinary parchment** and wrap each piece tightly. You can tuck in 5–6 cloves of garlic and a few sprigs of thyme, or slip in 3–4 stalks of bruised lemongrass instead. Next, you'll need **six sheets of heavy-duty foil** — the kind they sell at Costco, *Reynolds Heavy Duty 18" × 50"*. Place the parchment-wrapped meat onto one sheet of foil, wrap it snugly — no gaps for steam or juice to escape — then wrap it again in a second layer. Do the same with all three pieces.

Set the parcels on a foil-lined baking tray and slide them into a 340°F (170°C) oven for 1½ hours. Reduce the heat to 270°F (130°C) and let the meat roast for another 3–4 hours, depending on size. Nothing will burn at a temperature this low — and those hours are yours: read, walk the dog, answer emails, forget about the oven entirely. The foil and parchment handle everything for you, sparing you later from scrubbing dishes like a medieval penitence ritual.

When time is up, turn off the oven, let the parcels cool slightly, then unwrap and transfer the meat into a deep roasting pan. Save every drop of pan juice — it will make a brilliant saffron **Persian pilaf** later. If you want color, return the meat to a blazing-hot oven for 10 minutes, or simply finish it under the broiler until the surface turns glossy and bronze.

Tip, if crackling is your weakness: Whisk together 2 tbsp honey (or 4 tbsp plain sugar), 2 tbsp apple cider vinegar (5%), and 2 tbsp soy sauce. Brush generously over the hot meat and send it for a quick kiss of fire under the broiler.

The Most Tender Slow Duck You Will Ever Pull Off

The morning after brining, trim away the tails and loose neck skin from **two or three ducks**. Wrap each bird tightly in **culinary parchment** — don't skip this step; it keeps duck from drying out as it cooks. Then wrap each parchment parcel in two layers of wide, heavy **foil**. The fat must stay inside, the steam contained — that is where the magic happens. Place them on a foil-lined tray and into a 340°F (170°C) oven they go for 1½ hours.

Lower the heat to 270°F (130°C) and let them roast another 3½ hours. Turn off the oven, take the tray out, and allow the parcels to cool slightly so they don't scald your hands. When it's time to serve, cut open the foil and parchment, pour the rendered fat and juices into a bowl — save that treasure for **glorious potatoes roasted in duck fat** — transfer the ducks to a clay or glass dish, and finish under the broiler for 10–15 minutes: first breast side up, then the back.

A shortcut to lacquered crisp skin: Whisk 2 tbsp honey with 2 tbsp apple cider vinegar (or balsamic), add a splash of neutral oil, brush the mixture over the duck, and broil until the skin blisters into amber glass.

PS: Slow Duck, Sichuan-Style — Ten Minutes to Glory

Once your slow-roasted duck from the previous recipe has been bronzed under the broiler, you could carry it straight to the table with something simple — say, potatoes roasted in duck fat. Or you could take it one step further and turn it into something perfumed, lacquered and unforgettable — a Sichuan take, brightened with fresh pineapple instead of the traditional dried dates. The finishing stage takes no more than ten minutes, but believe me: duck in a wok leaves memories that outlive dinner.

Start by breaking the duck (hot from the oven or even leftover from yesterday): cut each leg in two, slice the breast into four pieces, remove the wings and the neck, and pile everything onto a large plate.

Heat 2 tablespoons of neutral oil in a steel wok. Add the garlic, shallots, lemongrass and ginger. Stir-fry over high heat for about two minutes before tossing in the pineapple slices and the dry spices. If you want a little danger, you may drop in 4–5 whole red chilies — whole, not sliced or crushed; otherwise, the dish becomes unreasonably fiery. Let everything sizzle together for another minute or two.

Now pour in the oyster sauce and marsala (and if a bottle of hoisin somehow survived the *Cantonese chapter* in your pantry — add a spoonful of that too). If you like your sauce slightly thicker, whisk 1 tablespoon cornstarch into 2 tablespoons water and stir it through.

Slide the duck pieces into the wok and cook over high heat for 5 minutes, stirring constantly, until every surface glistens in a deep, even coat. Serve with rice or steamed vegetables.

For one or two slow-roasted, broiled ducks you will need:

- Lemongrass (1–2 stalks, bruised with a knife and cut into 3 cm pieces)
- Ginger (4–6 cm piece, peeled and sliced into thin matchsticks)
- Garlic (3 cloves, smashed)
- Shallots (2 bulbs, sliced into thin petals)
- Pineapple (~100 g, peeled, cored, cut into thin wedges)

- Cinnamon (2 sticks)
- Star anise (1 pod)
- Oyster sauce (2 tbsp)
- Marsala (½ cup)

Optional, but recommended for swagger:

- Hoisin sauce (2 tbsp)
- Whole red chilies (4–5 pods)

And if a few spices are missing — don't worry. For this dish, the wok, the heat, and the timing matter more than absolute orthodoxy.

Guryev-Style Roast Turkey for Thanksgiving

This method — pieced together over time by a thoughtful, technically astute cook, after whom I named it — is wonderfully straightforward. Once your whole turkey has been through a proper brine, all you need to do is pat it dry with paper towels and settle the bird, breast-side up, onto a deep baking tray. Line the tray with a double layer of foil first, so you don't spend the evening scraping off baked fat with a sense of regret. Rub the skin generously with neutral oil, and leave the cavity empty except for 5–6 stalks of lemongrass — just enough to perfume the bird with a clean, bright scent. Slip the neck and gizzard — usually tucked discreetly inside the carcass — beside the turkey on the foil.

The principle here is simple: scorch and seal. You want the skin to tighten, crisp, and shield every drop of juice beneath it. So set your oven to its absolute maximum, about 500°F (260°C) and slide in the turkey for 25–30 minutes, just long enough for the skin to take on freckled brown blisters. Then lower the heat to 350°F (177°C) and continue roasting for 2–2.5 hours — long enough for the dark meat on the legs to soften into tenderness. The breast, however, cooks faster; once it's nearly there, shield it carefully with several layers of folded foil, leaving the legs and wings exposed to the heat. Turkeys vary wildly in size, so trust your thermometer more than the clock: pull the bird when the thickest part of the breast reaches 160°F (71°C). Rest it well, carve without haste, and serve — especially the white meat — with a gentle *Suprême* or a classic *Hollandaise*.

Tip for a bronze, crackling finish: Stir together **2 tbsp honey** and **2 tbsp apple cider vinegar (5%)** — balsamic will also do — then whisk in **2 tbsp neutral oil**. Brush this glaze over the breast or leg pieces and finish under a roaring broiler for 3–5 minutes, just until the surface shivers into lacquer.

Roast Beef — the kind children remember

I make this one often — it's one of those unfussy, deeply comforting dishes that seems to survive unchanged from generation to generation. One large **round eye beef roast**, a

proper cylinder weighing **3–4 kilos (6.5–9 lb)**, is enough to feed eight, maybe ten people. Once it's roasted, you slice it *hot*, cross-grain, into thin rosy sheets and serve it on a platter with something bright and sharp alongside — sweet pineapple salsa, grated horseradish, a spoon of grainy Dijon. That's all it really needs. And if by some miracle there's roast beef left the next morning, it becomes *Veau Orloff-style* leftovers — tender, layered, gratinéed — a recipe worth seeking out in the “Chopped Meat” section.

Start a day ahead. Trim away the silver skin, drop the roast into a **brine overnight** (exact ratios on the previous pages), pat it bone-dry with paper towels and set it fat-side down on a foil-lined tray. Heat your oven as high as it will go — 500°F (260°C), blasting. Slide the tray in for 30–40 minutes, long enough for the exterior to sear, tighten, and seal in all the salted juices, forming a deep gold crust — even a few scorch marks here and there are welcome. Reduce the heat to 300°F (149°C) and roast another 20–30 minutes. The only number that truly matters is the one inside the meat: the moment it reaches 130°F (54°C), pull it out. Don't carve yet — tent it loosely in foil and let it rest for about 30 minutes, the way you would let a story settle before telling it.

Meanwhile, make the pineapple salsa

Peel a medium pineapple, carve out the stiff pale core, and cut the flesh into 1 cm dice. Rinse a generous bunch of cilantro in cold water, pluck only the leaves (no stems here), and chop them fine. Warm a nonstick skillet over medium heat and add **2 tablespoons brown sugar**; once it melts and turns amber, tumble in the pineapple and stir with a bamboo spatula so each piece glazes evenly. Pour in **1 tablespoon oyster sauce**, **1 tablespoon dark soy**, add the chopped cilantro, squeeze in **half a lime**, and — if heat makes you happy — a pinch of chili. Warm it just a minute more, then spoon it over the sliced roast beef.

Important: never overcook a roast like this — 130°F internal max. For a crisper, lacquered crust, whisk **2 tbsp honey (or 4 tbsp sugar) + 2 tbsp 5% apple cider vinegar + 2 tbsp soy**, brush it over the roast, and finish under the broiler for 3–5 minutes.

And to drink? With roast beef this honest — a slab of meat, mustard, horseradish — pour something equally straightforward: an old-vine Argentine *Malbec* from the high slopes of Mendoza, dark, dry, full of sun and altitude.

Chopped Meats: Cutlets, *Pâtés*, Kebabs — and *Veau Orloff*

Not every piece of beef or lamb is destined for steaks or a proud roast. The less photogenic cuts — the ones riddled with seams of fat and stubborn silver skin — can be trimmed, freed of membranes, and turned into something finer: hand-chopped kebab, or a processor-quick mince whirled beneath fast, razor-sharp blades. (Keep your knives astoundingly sharp — dull steel crushes meat instead of cutting it, and crushed meat cooks dull.)

And then there is chicken breast — pale, lean, modest — which under the right touch becomes a marvel: *Pojarski cutlets*.

Pojarski Cutlets — the Best Thing That Can Happen to a Chicken Breast

If we're being honest, this may be the greatest destiny that an ordinary chicken breast can hope for. The recipe is old—old enough to have wandered into Pushkin's verses, and to have carried its fame along the muddy coach road between Moscow and St. Petersburg. Legend holds that it was invented by *Evdokim Pozharsky* and his daughter, who kept an inn in the small town of Torzhok in the early 1800s.

After Napoleon's wars, French cooking had begun seeping into Russia like a fashionable perfume, and you can taste that influence here. The original name even said as much: *Côtelette de volaille à la Pojarski*. The magic of the method is almost ridiculous in its simplicity—chopped chicken mixed with frozen butter, which melts during cooking and transforms the cutlet from something familiar into something lush, tender, almost aristocratic.

Our adaptation is not difficult. Just follow the rhythm.

The Crust:

Leave a slice of plain white bread *unwrapped* in the fridge for a full day. It should dry out, lose moisture, and take on that brittle fragility that a knife can shave into thin, fluttery flakes — about 1 × 1 cm each.

If life is short (and it is), and drying bread feels like excessive romance, you may take a shortcut with panko. Pozharsky may forgive you.

The Mixture:

Trim the crusts from fresh white bread, cut it into pieces, and soak them in cream for an hour—long enough for every crumb to drink deeply. This is one of those rare moments when you do not wring bread dry; the cream is part of the soul of the cutlet.

Grate ice-cold butter on the coarse side of a box grater — or chop it finely with a heavy knife — and return the shavings to the freezer.

Now, chop the chicken breast by hand — small pieces, not paste; or pulse it in the processor just until it resembles pebbles, not porridge. Combine chicken with the soaked bread, add salt, and if you feel bold, a pinch of saffron. Those sunlit threads will glimmer like tiny coins inside the cutlet. Mix everything with your hands, folding air into it. Chill the mixture 1 hour (or 30 minutes in the freezer) — it must be cold before butter enters the dance.

The Cutlets:

Now work quickly. Knead the frozen butter shavings into the chilled mixture and form four large cutlets, each about the size of your palm — roughly 200 g. Their size matters: smaller patties lose their butter to the pan, and along with it their poetry.

Roll each cutlet generously in your bread flakes or panko. Heat oil in a nonstick skillet until lively, then fry the cutlets 5–6 minutes per side, until gloriously golden. Be generous with the oil; stinginess serves no one here.

The centers will still be slightly underdone — perfect. Transfer them to a foil-lined tray and finish in a 360°F (182°C) oven for 8–10 minutes, just until the butter melts into every corner of the meat and turns tenderness into velvet.

Serve at once, blazing hot, with *Suprême* or *Hollandaise*, and watch how quickly silence descends over the table.

You'll need:

- Chicken breasts (4 pcs, about 800 g or 1.75 lb)
- White bread, crusts removed (150 g for the mix)
- Cream or Half & Half (200 ml)
- Frozen butter (150 g)
- Dry white bread for the crust (300 g, sliced into flakes *or substitute panko*)
- Salt (2 tsp)
- Saffron (a pinch, optional, but wonderful)

Minced meats, kebabs & pan-fried cutlets

You can, of course, pick up pre-ground beef and pork at the store and knead them together with your hands — but there is another way, more honest and more satisfying. Take a heavy, sharp knife and chop the meat yourself: lamb (chops, loin, leg, tenderloin) and a well-marbled piece of pork. Fat is not the enemy here — in kebabs and cutlets it is the soul. As it melts, it bastes the meat from within, keeping it tender, and most of it will remain behind on the tray or in the pan. And if the knife feels like too much labor, get yourself a powerful meat chopper with four quick blades spinning inside a glass bowl — a small modern miracle.

If you're making kebabs — small sausages meant for the grill — mix together **500 g beef and 500 g pork**, season with **½ teaspoon salt**, and leave the rest to the onion. Finely dice a

large onion (white is best), sauté it in vegetable oil until golden, and let it cool. Work it into the meat with your hands, then add **a shot of Marsala, cream sherry, or plain vodka** — alcohol lifts the aroma, and the mince becomes supple and perfumed.

For lamb kebabs, use **lamb and pork 1:1**, with the same golden onion and the same little splash of Marsala or sherry. A **½ teaspoon of ground cumin (jeera)** fits lamb perfectly — warm, earthy, faintly smoky. Shape long, even fingers of meat and roast them on a foil-lined tray. In convection mode at 475°F (246°C), they take 20–25 minutes. If you like a deeper crust, give them a minute or two under the broiler — they bronze beautifully.

If what you're after is simple pan-fried cutlets, make your mixture from **1 lb beef + 1 lb pork**, add **½ teaspoon salt** and **one onion**, finely chopped and fried in oil until soft and amber. Pour in **a shot of Marsala, sherry, or vodka**, add **one egg**, and **two thick slices of white bread**, briefly soaked in warm water and squeezed dry. Now knead the mixture well — really well — until it turns smooth, elastic, a little sticky with promise. Shape oval patties, giving them space to breathe in the pan, and fry in vegetable oil 8–10 minutes per side. Begin with a flame just above medium, lower it toward the end, and watch the crust — it should deepen to a warm, confident brown without burning.

***Veau Orloff* — A Dish Worthy of a Count**

Count *Grigory Orlov* — *Catherine the Great's* favorite — had a nephew, *Alexei Orlov*. He served as Russia's envoy in Constantinople and later headed the delegation in Paris during the signing of the peace treaty after the Crimean War, in 1856. A man of rank, appetite and influence, he fell — as so many diplomats do — in love with French food. In Paris he met a young cook named *Urbain Dubois*, brought him home to St. Petersburg and put him on a generous salary. *Dubois*, grateful and ambitious, later named one of his finest dishes after the count. *Escoffier* himself would one day study under *Dubois* — a fine culinary lineage behind the recipe you're about to make.

But to the stove. Veal may be scarce in California — this isn't Paris — but yesterday's roast beef eye round will do beautifully. In fact, this dish was invented for leftovers: a princely afterthought. Slice 400 g of cold roast beef across the grain into ½-cm rounds, then into narrow strips. Lay the meat loosely into a glass baking dish.

Slice 400 g mushrooms thinly and sauté them in a wide nonstick skillet with a little oil, over high heat, about 20 minutes, until their moisture cooks off and they turn nut-brown. Move them to a bowl. Cut shallots or onion into fine slivers, sauté in the same pan in fresh oil until golden, then return the mushrooms and let everything soften together for a minute or two. This is your base — mushroom-dark, sweet with onion.

Now for the sauce — the quiet heart of the dish:

The French invention known as *Béchamel* is defined by a sweet creaminess, a faint perfume of nutmeg, and that unmistakable milk-white color that settles on the spoon like early snow. It is easier to prepare than its elegance suggests.

Set a clean, dry steel skillet—or a wide, heavy sauté pan—over medium heat and warm 2–3 tablespoons of all-purpose flour, just until it takes on a pale toastiness and releases a subtle nutty aroma. Then add 50–70 g of butter, pressing it to the pan with a fork so it melts evenly. Use that melting butter as your paddle and immediately work it into the flour until both fuse into a smooth, sandy paste. This is your *white roux*—yes, the same foundation we used for fried shrimp and scallops.

Once the flour has fully dissolved into the butter, begin adding about 2 cups of cold milk, slowly, in a thin ribbon, stirring constantly with a spatula or wooden spoon so no lumps survive. Season with a pinch of salt and just the lightest dusting of freshly-grated nutmeg—enough to perfume the sauce, not to dominate it.

After another minute or two, the *Béchamel* will thicken to something between pastry cream and loose sour cream. Remove it from the heat and cover so it doesn't develop a skin. Better yet, pour it into a wide ceramic bowl, where it will cool more quickly.

Now separate two eggs, whisk the yolks, and beat them gently into the slightly cooled sauce — steadily, without interruption—so the yolks emulsify instead of scrambling. The sauce should become richer, silkier, almost custard-like.

Assembly:

Scatter your sautéed onions and mushrooms into the glass baking dish, directly onto the sliced beef. Pour the warm béchamel over them and fold everything together gently but thoroughly — the sauce should cling to every ribbon of meat.

Slide the dish into a 400°F (205°C) oven. After 20–30 minutes, when the mixture is bubbling softly at the edges, pull it out and shower the top with a generous layer of grated *Gruyère* or *Parmigiano*.

In a separate small bowl, whisk the two reserved egg whites to a light foam, add 1 teaspoon of sugar, and pour this froth over the cheese. Use a fork to feather and swirl it lightly across the surface — it will bake into a golden, soufflé-like crust.

Return the dish under the broiler (top grill). In a few minutes the top will blister and brown, forming a thin, crisp shell of cheese and egg that gives way to tender meat and velvety sauce beneath.

You'll need:

- Cooked roast beef (400 g)

- Milk (300 ml)
- Butter (50–70 g)
- Eggs (2)
- Flour (2–3 tbsp)
- Nutmeg (a pinch)
- Mushrooms (portobello or button, 400 g)
- Shallots/onion (2–3)
- *Gruyère*, *Parmigiano*, or any firm aged cheese (1 cup)
- Sugar (1 tsp)
- Salt (½ tsp)

And with it? I'd pour a crisp Spanish *Cava Brut* — bubbles for lift, acidity for clarity, brightness for the richness of cream and cheese.

Chicken Liver & Onion *Pâté* — slow, light, elegant

This recipe belongs to chef and writer *Alexey Zimin*, and there is nothing to correct or embellish — only to pass it on whole, like a folded note that already says everything. Nearly half of the ideal chicken liver *pâté* is onions. There is butter, of course — and only then, almost as an afterthought, the liver itself. Yes, liver gives depth and shadow, but elegance, power and bloom arise from what surrounds it: the sweetness, the creaminess, the slow transformation that happens in a shallow pan over a gentle flame. A *pâté* is built not on liver but on onions losing their water, then their form, and finally themselves, turning from sharp and white to amber syrup and, at last, a flowing caramel. Because chicken liver, with all affection, is not foie gras — its greatness needs a stage.

Start with 500 g of onions, sliced into crescent moons. Cook them low and slow — almost an hour — in a non-stick skillet over medium or even slightly below medium heat, in a mixture of butter and olive oil. Stir constantly, guarding against burning, and keep the onions just barely wet by adding — now and then — either a splash of cheap bottled *Chardonnay* or a little orange juice.

The liquid slows caramelization just enough and prevents the onions from drying out, while adding new brightness and sweetness. Reduced *Chardonnay* turns nearly to syrup; fortified wines, especially *Madeira*, are even better — smoky, honeyed, amplifying the onion and flattering the mild bitterness of liver. Remember: the onions should **never stew in liquid**. There must be just enough to sizzle away quickly. After an hour, your mountain of onions will have collapsed into a brown, marmalade-like mass. Transfer it to a wide steel pot — this is where your *pâté* will be born.

In the same skillet, heat butter + oil over high heat and sear 500–700 g chicken livers until medium-rare — fully cooked through but still moist, never chalky. This takes about 10 minutes. Midway, add a splash of white wine and orange juice; once the livers reach perfect doneness, lift them out with a slotted spoon into the pot of caramelized onions. Reduce the

remaining pan juices over high heat, add a grating of nutmeg and ½ teaspoon saffron. A touch of balsamic or 5% apple vinegar helps — acidity plus bitterness lightens the liver's weight like wind under fabric.

You may enrich the pâté with vegetables: sauté diced parsley root (or celery root) and two carrots in a separate pan until soft, then add two peeled eggplants cut small. Eggplant will drink oil like a sponge and then take on color. Add the vegetables to the onion-liver mixture, along with the reduced juices, and blend everything in a 5–10 liter pot with an immersion blender. Don't forget the 100–150 g of cold butter — it brings the mass together into a glossy, tender paste. The goal is a smooth, lump-free texture, like pale, pourable dough.

The color may look somber — grayish-pale like winter light — but saffron will warm it. You may sift the pâté through a fine sieve, though rustic texture has its charm. Transfer to a mold and chill until firm.

Serve cold, but on hot toasted bread — ideally white.

Required:

- Onions (500 g)
- Chicken livers (500–700 g)
- Butter for frying (50–70 g)
- Olive oil (50–70 ml)
- Butter for the *pâté* (100–150 g)
- Balsamic or 5% apple vinegar (20 ml)
- Chardonnay (boxed is fine, 250 ml)
- Madeira (250 ml)
- Orange juice (100 ml)
- Nutmeg, salt, pepper — to taste

Optional, but lovely:

- Parsley root or celery root (1)
- Carrots (2)
- Eggplants (2)
- Sunflower oil for sautéing (1 cup)
- Saffron (a pinch)

Wine pairing: Serve with ice-cold Portuguese *Vinho Verde* — lively, green, a bright counterpoint to all that caramel and gold.

Chicken with Walnut & Broth Sauce — in the spirit of *Satsivi*

Satsivi is a traditional Georgian dish made with walnut sauce and served cold, either as a dipping sauce for fried turkey or chicken. Traditionally, *Satsivi* is made of walnuts, garlic

and fine herbs. This comes together fast — suspiciously fast for something this good. Chances are you have a stash of homemade stock in the freezer, and maybe, in a corner behind the ice packs, a bag of walnuts from last year's harvest. Pick up two rotisserie chickens at Costco — no need to roast your own tonight — strip off the meat, carve it into bite-sized shreds, and discard skin and bones. The rest is almost effortless.

Assembly:

- Finely slice **about 1 kg of white onions**, and slowly sauté them in vegetable oil over low heat until pale-gold and sweet. Add **5–6 garlic cloves**, and at the very end drop in a couple of pinches of **Iranian saffron**.
- Meanwhile, thaw **about 1 kg of walnuts**, and pulse them in a food processor until finely, evenly chopped.
- Transfer the cooled onions, garlic and ground walnuts to a wide stainless pot, add **two raw egg yolks**, and stir to combine.
- Thaw **about 1 liter of beef broth**, and pour it in gradually while blending the mixture with an immersion blender, until it becomes a thick, velvety sauce.
- Set the pot over low heat and warm it *almost* to a simmer — but don't let it boil. Stir occasionally. Add your shredded chicken, season with salt and a touch of sugar. If the sauce turns too thick, loosen it with more hot broth or even a splash of dry white wine.
- Rinse **a very large bunch of cilantro** in cold water, shake it dry, and chop the leaves — only the leaves — as fine as if you were writing tiny green letters with a knife.

That's it. Chill the walnut sauce with the chicken, add **a couple tablespoons of 5% apple cider vinegar** and your mountain of cilantro. Stir well, transfer to a shallow glass bowl, scatter a few **pomegranate seeds** over the top — and the dish is complete, cool and fragrant.

Wine pairing: Serve *Satsivi* with an amber Georgian *Kisi Qvevri* or *Mtsvane Qvevri* — wine made in *Kakheti* the old way, in giant clay amphorae buried up to their throats in earth. Crushed grapes — skins, stems, pits and all — ferment in the cold for months, then rest until spring, when the wine is finally drawn golden and alive.

Persian *Pilaf*, Buckwheat with *Porcini*, and Pasta

This chapter is devoted to three humble grains on which entire civilizations quietly raised their kitchens and their hopes: rice, wheat, and buckwheat. For thousands of years, these small seeds helped humanity slowly unlearn the old terror of winter hunger — that long, prowling season that crept toward every village each year, stealing the frail, the aging, the unlucky. Rice and wheat, especially, could wait out the cold in sealed clay jars until the sun returned; simmered in small, careful portions with whatever scrap of meat or fish a family could spare, they stretched poverty into something that felt, for a moment, like abundance. They were the first real promise that spring would come, and that the household would live to greet it.

Over time, those same farmers learned to trade their precious grain for dried meat and cheese from the nomads who wandered the borders of their fields — a quiet exchange between two worlds that needed each other more than they knew. And when they finally discovered how to grind those seeds into flour, when the first breads, flatbreads, noodles, and dumplings appeared on their tables, something fundamental shifted. Culinary life — and life itself — opened into a new chapter: warmer, steadier, richer in possibility, as if humanity had suddenly been handed a gentler way to live.

Basmati Rice

The name *basmati* (from Sanskrit वासमती, *vasamati*) literally means “fragrant.” When steamed properly, the grains develop a faint sweetness and a remarkably delicate, nutty aroma — especially if you buy *sela*, the partially parboiled variety. Most likely, long-grain basmati was developed centuries ago in the Himalayan foothills from cultivated Chinese rice varieties. What sets it apart is its protein structure: basmati contains more protein and noticeably less starch than ordinary rice. Its glycemic index sits somewhere between 56 and 69; regular white rice typically hovers near 89.

Raw basmati has a curious scent — almost mousy — and keeps for ages, improving in both aroma and flavor as it matures. It’s usually aged for about a year, while the finest varieties are left to rest for five to ten years. India’s markets, alas, are full of counterfeits and blends, so buy from reliable stores (Costco, for example, is a surprisingly safe bet), taste widely, and stock up on the bags you fall in love with. Believe me: basmati is the finest rice you can buy for cooking — and the one most cherished in refined Persian cuisine.

Persian Steamed *Pilaf* to Serve with Meat or Poultry

Let’s talk rice. How much water does it need, how much salt, and how do you manage a full kilo of basmati when you’re cooking for five to eight people? Don’t use more than that — a larger batch becomes awkward to drain, and you’ll struggle moving the hot grains from pot to pot to finish the steaming properly.

It begins, as many good things do in Persian cooking, with a quiet, almost meditative ritual: washing the rice. Cold water, once, then again, until the cloudiness disappears and the grains seem to remember what it means to be clean.

Then the drama begins.

Bring a large pot of water to a fierce, rolling boil—six or seven liters, generously salted, the way the sea might be if it cared about flavor. Tip in the rice and watch it come alive, the grains swirling, rising, finding their rhythm.

Stir it with a sturdy wooden paddle, not constantly, but often enough to keep it from settling into complacency at the bottom. After ten or twelve minutes, it will be nearly ready—but not quite. The grains will begin to drift upward, as if eager to escape. Take one, bite into it: soft on the outside, with a faint resistance at the center. That is your moment.

Now comes the part that requires a bit of courage. The pot is heavy, the water furious. In one decisive motion, pour everything into a large colander waiting in the sink. The water rushes away at once, but the rice — remarkably — holds on to its warmth, its structure, and more moisture than you might expect.

Do not underestimate it.

Take a wide, heavy-bottomed pot with a tight-fitting lid. Pour in a thin veil of vegetable oil — just enough to protect the grains as they finish their journey. Add the rice gently, letting it fall into place without pressing or flattening it. It should feel loose, almost effortless.

Set it first over medium heat, then lower it and let it rest there for thirty to forty minutes. Under the lid, a quiet life resumes: steam rising, shifting, escaping in a steady breath. To keep it from condensing and dripping back, place a cotton towel beneath the lid, tucking the edges safely away from the flame.

Why all this patience?

Because now the rice begins to change. As it releases its remaining moisture, it becomes receptive — almost hungry. Ready to absorb whatever you choose to give it.

And this is where things become interesting.

Remember the juices from the meat you roasted earlier — beef, perhaps, or duck? Bring them back. Pour them into a deep skillet, bring them to a boil, and let them reduce slightly. Add cinnamon sticks, a star anise, a few crushed cardamom pods. Let them simmer gently, filling the air with warmth, then remove the spices — they have said everything they needed to say.

Meanwhile, melt a generous amount of butter — no need to be shy — and warm in it a handful of golden raisins and chopped dried apricots until they swell and soften. At the very end, stir in a pinch of saffron and a scattering of almonds or cashews.

Now open the rice.

It will greet you lightly, almost delicately — each grain separate, poised. Pour the saffron butter over it, the fruit glistening, the aroma rising at once. Add a few ladles of the reduced meat juices, then gently fold everything together with your wooden paddle.

The rice will take it all in. The gold of saffron, the sweetness of fruit, the depth of the meat — it will absorb it without resistance, as if this had always been its purpose.

Serve it on its own, or beside slices of roasted meat or carved duck.

At this point, it is no longer just rice. It is something that required time, attention, and a small measure of faith — and, as it turns out, was worth every bit of it.

Tip: To check whether your rice is properly cooked, simply pinch a grain between two fingertips. It should flatten easily with no chalky core at the center.

A dense, sun-colored *Chardonnay* from Carneros or Russian River Valley is the perfect companion here — just don't chill it too aggressively.

Buckwheat

Buckwheat (*Fagopyrum esculentum*) is one of those wonderfully odd ancient crops that refuses to behave the way its English name suggests. Despite the “wheat” in it, buckwheat is no cereal at all, and botanically it has nothing to do with the grasses that feed most of the world. Its closest relatives, surprisingly, are sorrel and rhubarb.

Its homeland lies in Southeast Asia, where people began cultivating buckwheat some six thousand years before our era. From there it traveled westward across Central Asia and onto the Tibetan plateau. Pollen traces found at archaeological sites in China and Japan show that buckwheat was part of everyday life there three to four millennia ago.

In California you'll find it easily — in Russian grocery stores or tucked on the shelves of Korean markets, where buckwheat noodles and flours are standard staples.

A Taste of Old Moscow: Buckwheat with *Porcini*

Buckwheat is at its best not when boiled to an obedient mush, but when toasted, covered, and left to rest with just enough broth and butter to coax out its aroma. And nothing flatters it more than *porcini* — fresh, frozen, or dried.

Start with the aromatics. In a wide nonstick skillet warm about 50 ml of vegetable oil and gently sauté a finely chopped onion together with thick slices of galangal root until the mixture turns soft and translucent.

While the onion lazily softens, turn to the mushrooms. Frozen *porcini* should be thawed in cold water and squeezed dry with paper towels; dried mushrooms deserve a good two-hour

soak in cool water, after which you must squeeze them thoroughly — sometimes a bit of grit settles at the bottom, so be watchful. Fresh *porcini* simply need slicing.

Add the mushrooms to the pan and cook them over medium heat, stirring, until most of their moisture evaporates and the edges begin to caramelize ever so slightly. This is your cue to remove the pan from the heat and set it aside.

Now for the buckwheat itself:

Heat another 50 ml of vegetable oil in a deep, heavy skillet or sauté pan — something that holds about five liters — and toast the grains for about five minutes, stirring constantly. They should smell warm and nutty, like autumn fields after harvest.

At this point fold in the mushrooms, stir, and let everything cook together for another couple of minutes.

The final stage is almost meditative. Pour in the meat broth, season with salt, bring the mixture to a strong boil, then cover the pan tightly and lower the heat to a gentle simmer. Let the buckwheat cook undisturbed for about half an hour.

When the timer goes off, scatter generous cubes of butter over the top, stir once more, cover again, and let the dish settle and gather itself for five quiet minutes. The grains will finish absorbing the broth, the mushrooms will soften further, and everything will become wonderfully fragrant.

Serve warm — buckwheat likes to be the rustic, honest backbone of the table.

Essential:

- Buckwheat (3 large cups, about 600 g)
- Meat broth (5 large cups)
- Fresh or frozen *porcini* (500 g) — or two generous handfuls of dried, grit-free mushrooms
- White onions (3–4)

Optional, but excellent:

- Butter (100–150 g)
- Galangal root (about 100 g)

Roman Pasta

One of Rome's great culinary technologies is the art of drying dough — a simple mixture of durum wheat flour, eggs, and water — and turning it into something that keeps well, travels well, and cooks into pure comfort. The oldest written recipe we have for *lagana* (very likely

the ancestor of today's *lasagna*) appears in a work by *Athenaeus of Naucratis*, a Greek author writing in the age of Emperor *Marcus Aurelius*, in the second century CE.

To be fair, Chinese archaeologists have found dried noodles made from rice, buckwheat, and wheat dating as far back as the second millennium BCE. So, the idea of preserving dough by drying it is very ancient indeed.

Gogol, for what it's worth, spent years living in Rome — he wrote *Dead Souls* there — and in the breaks between chapters played with pasta like a delighted child. He even brought boxes of well-dried spaghetti and wedges of Parmesan back to St. Petersburg, trying earnestly to convert his friends. They, however, ate it only out of politeness. *Gogol* insisted on serving his pasta *al dente*, and that was simply too much for them.

Let's start you off with a recipe whose elegance lies in its austerity — the wonderful *carbonara*, born somewhere in the impoverished Italian south just after 1944. In those hungry, rubble-strewn years, Italians cooked with skill and imagination using whatever arrived in American relief packages: bacon, flour, and powdered eggs.

Pasta Carbonara

Slice about **200 grams of dry-cured bacon** — ideally Italian *pancetta* — into thin strips, and brown them quickly in a nonstick skillet over medium heat until roughly half the fat renders. Use a spatula to lift the bacon onto paper towels so they can drink up the excess fat.

Crack **three eggs** into a bowl and, with your hands, gently separate the yolks into a smaller bowl. Grate about **200 grams of cheese** on a coarse grater: *Pecorino Romano* is ideal, but *Parmigiano* or *Grana Padano* will do nicely.

Set a large pot with 5 liters of water over high heat. When it comes to a rolling boil, salt it generously and drop in a full **500-gram package of spaghetti**. Cook it exactly as the package suggests; when the timer rings, drain the pasta immediately through a wide colander.

Let the water run off, then transfer the steaming spaghetti into a deep glass bowl. While it's still hot, pour in the three raw yolks and toss thoroughly. Add the crisped *pancetta*, sprinkle generously with grated cheese, toss again — and serve right away.

Pasta Bolognese

The first published recipe for *ragù alla Bolognese* — the ancestor of the modern Bolognese sauce — came from *Alberto Alvisi*, the cook to Pope Pius VII. It was always intended for broad, ribbon-shaped pastas like *tagliatelle* or *pappardelle*.

Take a wide steel pot, five to seven liters in volume, with metal handles so you can later send it into the oven. This is where you'll build your *soffritto*, that Italian foundation of finely chopped vegetables. Warm about half a centimeter of olive oil until shimmering, then

sauté **two finely diced onions, two stalks of celery, two carrots, and three to five cloves of garlic**. Stir constantly. In about ten minutes the vegetables should take on a pale caramel tint; set them aside.

Now comes the most monotonous and essential step. Take roughly **two kilos of modest, slightly tough beef** and chop it by hand into tiny pieces — about a centimeter square, or smaller. It must be chopped, not ground; grinding ruins the texture and drains the meat of its juices.

Heat olive oil in a wide nonstick pan and brown the beef in three small batches, about ten minutes per batch, until lightly caramelized — this seals in the juices. Each finished batch goes straight into the pot with the vegetables.

Next come the cured meats: chop about **300 grams of Italian dry sausages, *pancetta*, *prosciutto***, or — if you have some on hand — that glorious dry-cured pork described later on in “*Pastarma* from Pork.” Add this to the pot as well.

Pour in a **bottle of simple white wine**, return the pot to medium heat, and let the ragù simmer for half an hour, until the wine cooks down. Then stir in a spoonful of good **tomato paste** and let it fry gently for a minute or two. Add **two to three kilos of peeled frozen tomatoes** from your freezer stash in Vacaville — or, if you don’t have them, **two liters of Italian *passata di pomodoro*** or two kilos of excellent canned tomatoes such as San Marzano (never pickled!). Add a **couple tablespoons of chopped parsley**, bring to a boil, and slide the pot — uncovered — into a 300°F (150°C) oven for a couple of hours.

Don’t forget it entirely; check occasionally, stir, and add a little water if needed, until the ragù thickens into an unglamorous but deeply flavorful sauce. It will keep well in the fridge for a few days.

Cook **300 grams of *tagliatelle***, spoon over a generous cup of the sauce, and serve with freshly grated *Parmigiano*.

Pasta with *Porcini*

Begin with the ***porcini***. You’ll want 500–600 grams. Frozen mushrooms should be thawed in water first and squeezed dry with paper towels; dried porcini need a few hours in cold water, followed by a firm squeeze (sometimes there’s a little sand at the bottom — it happens). Fresh mushrooms simply need slicing.

Sauté the porcini in a large wide skillet with a mixture of **two tablespoons vegetable oil and two tablespoons butter**. Stir as they cook. Let most of the mushroom liquid evaporate, and allow their edges to pick up a faint caramel color. Take them off the heat and set aside.

In a saucepan, melt **two tablespoons of butter**, add a finely diced **white onion**, and sauté gently over low heat for eight to ten minutes. Add half the cooked porcini (250–300 g), pour in 300 ml of meat broth, and simmer over medium heat for another ten minutes. Let it cool

slightly, then purée everything with an immersion blender until perfectly smooth. Salt to taste.

Now the pasta. Set a pot with four to five liters of water on high heat. When it boils, salt it and drop in a **package of rigatoni or penne** — about 100 grams per person. These sturdy tubes are built to soak up mushroom sauce. Cook according to the package instructions; as soon as the timer rings, drain well in a wide colander.

Transfer the pasta to a large skillet with the whole mushrooms. Add the remaining *porcini* (250–300 g), warm everything over high heat with brisk stirring, pour in the sauce, toss once more — and bring it straight to the table.

Pasta Gratin for Kids, or Simply Mac-N-Cheese

The children have arrived — yours and the guests’ — and within minutes a small mutiny is underway: *I’m not eating fish. I won’t eat pilaf. I hate meat. I hate everything.* Tearful Jane, meanwhile, has woken up this morning determined to become a vegan, forever and irrevocably, because she refuses to “eat cows with sad eyes.”

The adults’ eyes, in the meantime, are slowly filling with despair, and the situation clearly requires intervention. Make Mac-N-Cheese!

Once upon a time this clever bit of culinary diplomacy was known as “*pasta gratin with Mornay sauce*,” but who remembers that now? The performance itself will take you about forty minutes, and afterwards everyone will feel restored, and you can finally sit down with a glass of wine alongside the other frayed parents.

Start by placing a pot with five liters of water on high heat. When it comes to a rolling boil, salt it and drop in a **full package (500 g) of penne or rigatoni**. Cook for ten minutes, then drain the pasta in a colander and rinse briefly with warm water. Let every last drop run off, then transfer the pasta into a deep glass baking dish. Set the oven to preheat at 400°F (205°C).

Now make the *Béchamel*, the creamy backbone of the dish. In a clean, dry stainless-steel skillet or a wide sauté pan, warm two or three tablespoons of flour over medium heat until it gives off a faint nutty aroma. Add a **column of butter (about 80 g)**, press it lightly with a fork, and use the melting butter itself to whisk the flour into a smooth, sandy paste. As soon as the flour dissolves fully into the butter, begin adding two cups of cold milk in a thin stream, stirring constantly with a spatula. Season with a pinch of salt and just the barest scrape of freshly grated nutmeg. After a couple of minutes, the sauce will thicken to the consistency of pastry cream or loose sour cream; take it off the heat and let it cool slightly.

Now turn that béchamel into *Mornay* — essentially the same sauce, only enriched with cheese and egg yolks. Separate the yolks from two eggs and whisk them into the slightly cooled sauce, moving the whisk briskly so the yolks don’t scramble.

Add **200 g of finely diced ham** (and tell tearful Jane later that it's a very special vegan pink marshmallow, crafted for pastel ponies who graze exclusively on rainbows) along with grated cheese: **150 g of Gruyère** and **150 g of Parmigiano**. If you don't have these on hand, 300 g of any firm, flavorful cheese will do the job.

Now pour the sauce over the pasta in the glass dish. Stir everything together thoroughly, scatter a little more cheese on top, and slide the dish into the oven for about half an hour.

I promise you: this will be the best Mac-N-Cheese within a two-hundred-mile radius. And yes — the children will devour it happily.

A Quiet, Elegant Cauliflower Gratin for the Adults at the Table

No sense getting up twice. I can assure you the mothers in the room aren't going to touch the children's Mac-N-Cheese — not after months of iron discipline and quiet salads. Fine by me. We'll simply swap out the pasta and bring in a **pair of small cauliflower heads**. They can roast in the very same oven as the Mac-N-Cheese, and with almost the very same sauces.

Set the same pot — five liters of water — back on the stove over high heat. When it comes to a boil, drop in the cauliflower, cut into florets. Cook for the same ten minutes, then drain them in a colander. Let every drop fall away, then transfer the florets to a deep glass baking dish lightly greased with butter. Preheat the oven to 400°F (205°C).

Now make the creamy backbone of the dish, the *Béchamel*. In a clean, dry stainless-steel skillet or a wide sauté pan, warm two or three tablespoons of flour over medium heat until it releases a faint nutty aroma. Add a column of butter (about 80 g), press it gently to the bottom with a fork, and use the melting butter itself to whisk the flour into a smooth, sandy paste. Once the flour has dissolved completely, begin adding two cups of cold milk in a thin stream, stirring constantly with a spatula. Season with a pinch of salt and just a whisper of freshly grated nutmeg. Within a few minutes the mixture will thicken to something like pastry cream or loose sour cream — that's your cue to take it off the heat and let it cool slightly.

Now turn it into *Mornay*, the elegant sister of béchamel, enriched with cheese and egg yolks. Separate two eggs, whisk the yolks into the slightly cooled sauce, and keep the whisk moving so the yolks stay silk-smooth rather than scrambling. Add 200 grams of grated *Gruyère* or *Parmigiano* (or whatever good hard cheese you managed to rescue from the back of the fridge). Pour the sauce over the cauliflower in the baking dish. Stir gently but thoroughly, scatter a little more cheese on top, and slide the dish into the oven for about half an hour. Now — finally — everyone, children and adults alike, should be content.

As for the adults, pour them cold rosé for full emotional anesthesia. Or open a couple of icy bottles of Mumm Napa Brut for the women while you finish cooking — they've earned it.

Steam, Fire, Soy: Adventures in Cantonese Cooking

Canton — known today as Guangdong — was already a crossroads of the world by the time the Tang dynasty flourished between 618 and 907 CE. Waves of travelers and traders from every corner of the Silk Road slowly wove themselves into the fabric of the south. Even the language of the region, Cantonese, grew apart from the Mandarin spoken in the northern capitals. The rulers of the south, cosmopolitan and unusually tolerant for their age, set aside a vast district on the banks of the Pearl River expressly for merchants from Sogdiana, Persia, and later from the Arab world and the West. Out of it grew the thriving city of Guangzhou.

On the shipyards of Guangzhou, enormous ocean-going junks were built—vessels on which Admiral Zheng He's fleet sailed to the Malay Peninsula, Arabia, even the eastern shores of Africa. Right up until the twilight of the Ming dynasty in 1644, China's emperors actively encouraged such maritime expeditions.

Naturally, where people mix, their culinary habits mix with them. Over centuries, techniques from many traditions fused into a singular southern vocabulary of cooking: tiny steamed dim sum snacks — those translucent dumplings filled with garlic chives, *ku chai kueh*, made of sweet potato dough and tapioca starch, or crisp little wontons; the brilliant Cantonese habit of roasting pork while it hangs suspended from hooks; the practice of plunging pieces of squid or chicken into boiling oil; and the mastery of deep, layered sauces like black bean or hoisin. All this, combined with an extraordinary abundance of ingredients — from delicate fish served over fragrant rice to marvelous Sogdian peaches and perfumed Hami melons—gave birth to one of the world's most subtle and intricate cuisines.

The south was always densely populated, and its people spilled over the rim of the Cantonese bowl to Rangoon, Singapore, Jakarta, London, and Monterey. They called themselves *Huaqiao*, overseas Chinese, worked from dawn to dusk, taking any job that allowed them to support families. Language was difficult at first, but they carried their inheritance with them: parents, children, and recipes — sometimes tucked into memory, sometimes scribbled in fading characters on worn scraps of paper.

Once they managed to save a little money — often while laying track for the railroad that cut across the North American continent (and no, it wasn't cowboys who built it) — many *Huaqiao* opened small restaurants and prepared-food shops. There, slowly and patiently, Cantonese dishes adapted themselves to the cravings and expectations of local diners. It is no exaggeration to say that nearly every Chinese restaurant on our Pacific coast traces its lineage to Cantonese cooking. And many dishes we Americans think of as “classic Chinese” — say, shrimp with glazed walnuts in a mayonnaise sauce, which you and I have already cooked together, or General Tso's chicken — were invented only recently and are virtually unknown in mainland China.

And before these memories drift too far out of reach, let us pause and look closely at four quietly wondrous Cantonese arts: the feather-light steaming of dim sum; the slow, lacquer-

deep roasting of red pork on a wire rack; the quick, bright flare of squid or chicken meeting shimmering oil; and the long, meditative braise of cuttlefish in soy, as patient as an evening tide. None of these methods are simple, I admit, yet each one returns far more than it asks of you. Try them, even once, in the privacy of your own kitchen — and I promise, the very shape of your idea of good food will tilt and open, like a door you didn't know was there, onto a richer, more fragrant world.

Steamed *Dim Sum*

Let's begin with dumplings — both the closed, translucent *har gow* and the open-topped *siu mai* — those small steamed delights collectively known as *dim sum*. Their reputation has, sadly, been thoroughly compromised by the frozen heaps of mediocrity piled high in most supermarkets: dough as limp as a damp paper towel, made from soft wheat flour; fillings cobbled together from the cheapest cuts of sinewy meat. Then comes the dunk into boiling water, the squirt of mayonnaise or ketchup on top, and, inevitably, heartburn inside and new folds of regret outside.

On the other hand, let's be realistic: rolling egg-based durum dough into delicate, nearly transparent wrappers at home is more devotion than most kitchens can handle.

In Canton itself, though, the rules are stricter. No one would dream of eating frozen filling. When I studied dumpling-making in a culinary school in Guilin about fifteen years ago, I was astonished by how deeply layered a flavor could be when built from the simplest ingredients, steamed gently with herbs. Of course, in school there were dedicated chefs to handle the dough. In California, figuring out where to buy it — let alone how to set up a steamer — was another matter entirely.

Today things are wonderfully easier. A quick trip to Ranch 99 will get you excellent, fresh dumpling and wonton wrappers — properly rested, thinly rolled, cut into tidy 8×8 or 10×10 cm squares, and packaged neatly. They sit in the same refrigerated case as tofu and soybean pastes. While you're there, pick up a set of round bamboo steamers with fitted lids — the very baskets Chinese cooks rely on for steaming everything under the sun.

And the steamer itself? You already own it, practically. Just brush the bamboo baskets lightly with oil, arrange your freshly shaped dumplings inside, stack the baskets, and lower the whole tower into a roomy 15-liter steel pot — the same one you've used for soups. Pour in a centimeter of water at the bottom, enough for a leisurely simmer, and cover with a tight metal lid to trap the steam.

There's an even simpler shortcut: use a shallow pot, or even a wok without a lid. Pour in a liter of water, bring it to a lively boil, set the bamboo tower right into the pot (leave the bottom basket empty), and cover the top basket with its own bamboo lid. You'll lose a bit of steam that way, but for a first attempt it works remarkably well.

At this point you can make a quick dozen dumplings for a quiet dinner for two—or prepare five varieties for a crowd and serve them with a glossy Hollandaise. The whole craft is now in your hands. If you'd like, let's simply revisit a handful of reliable fillings from my Guilin school days.

Har Gow Filling: Pork and Garlic Chives

For *har gow*, choose the softest, most tender cut of pork you can find: **pork tenderloin**, about 200 g. This slim muscle sits just behind the two long loins running along the spine; it does almost no work during the pig's short life, and cooks quickly as a result. You'll find tidy vacuum-sealed packs of tenderloins at Costco—four per package. Chop off what you need and mince it finely with a very sharp knife on a wooden board. You want pea-sized pieces, not a paste.

The second ingredient is **garlic chives** (*Allium tuberosum*) — *djussai*, as it's known in Chinese markets — **about 100 g**. You can always find it at Koreana Plaza or Ranch 99. The Cantonese adore it in dumplings: it lends a soft, fragrant garlic note. Slice it as finely as you possibly can.

Cut **100 g of carrot** into thin sheets, stack them, and slice them into slender matchsticks.

Combine the pork, garlic chives, and carrot in a bowl. Add **2 tablespoons oyster sauce** (Lee Kum Kee), **1 teaspoon sugar**, and **1 tablespoon sesame oil** (also Lee Kum Kee).

Now, working one wrapper at a time, moisten the edges with water, place it on your palm, spoon in about half a tablespoon of filling, close your hand slightly, and pinch the edges together to seal. Brush the bottoms of the bamboo steamer baskets with oil, arrange the dumplings neatly, and stack the baskets in a pot with 4–5 cups of boiling water at the bottom. Cover tightly and steam for 10–15 minutes.

Har Gow Filling: Pork and Portobello Mushrooms

Finely mince 200 g of **pork tenderloin** with a sharp knife. Slice 3–4 large **portobello caps** into small pieces and sauté them in a wide skillet with 2–3 finely chopped **shallots** (or a single white onion). Add a splash of vodka and cook until all liquid evaporates. If a bit remains, squeeze it out through a layer of cheesecloth.

Combine the pork, mushrooms, and shallots. Add **2 tablespoons oyster sauce**, **1 teaspoon sugar**, and **1 tablespoon sesame oil**. You should end up with roughly 200 g of filling.

Chill the mixture in the freezer for 20 minutes — it's much easier to shape dumplings when the filling is firm. Then proceed as before: dampen the wrapper edges, spoon in half a tablespoon of filling, pinch closed, brush the bamboo baskets with oil, arrange the dumplings, stack the baskets over boiling water, cover tightly, and steam for 10–15 minutes.

Har Gow Filling: Fish and Onion

Take about 200 g of a pleasantly fatty white fish — **halibut** or **ling cod** works beautifully. Remove all bones and skin, then chop the flesh into a coarse mince.

Sauté **2–3 shallots** (or one white onion) in a wide pan with a little oil. You can add finely sliced white leek or a bit of grated ginger. Cook until all liquid evaporates; if not, squeeze through cheesecloth. Measure out about 200 g of the cooked onion mixture.

Combine the fish and aromatic onions with **2 tablespoons soy sauce** and **1 teaspoon sugar**. Chill for 20 minutes, then assemble the dumplings as before. Steam for 10–15 minutes under a tightly sealed lid.

Siu Mai Filling: Shrimp, Pork, and Shiitake

Now let's make the open-topped *siu mai*. Start with **250 g of pork tenderloin** (or pork loin, trimmed of silverskin). Mince it with a sharp knife into pea-sized pieces. Marinate the pork in **2 tablespoons oyster sauce, 2 teaspoons sugar, 1 tablespoon soy sauce, 2 tablespoons cornstarch**, and **½ teaspoon salt**. Refrigerate the mixture in a sealed container for at least 4 hours, or ideally overnight.

In the morning, chop **150 g raw shrimp** into small pieces. Simmer **4–5 fresh shiitake mushrooms** for 5–10 minutes, then mince them and mix with the shrimp. Add the marinated pork — squeezing it first to remove excess liquid — and **1 tablespoon sesame oil**. Stir until cohesive.

Now take a round **siu mai wrapper**, place it on your palm, spoon in about half a tablespoon of filling, and gently squeeze to shape a small, open cup filled right to the top. You should get about 20 dumplings.

Brush the bamboo baskets with oil, arrange the siu mai inside, stack over boiling water, cover tightly, and steam for 10–15 minutes. Just before serving, top each one with a tiny spoonful of **tobiko** or **masago**; it adds a bright, saline sparkle.

Red Cantonese Char Siu in Honey Glaze

Char siu — the lacquered, ruby-red Cantonese barbecue pork — may well be one of the small miracles of southern Chinese cooking.

Traditionally, the ritual begins by briefly blanching the meat, letting excess fat melt away. Then the pork is hung on metal hooks to dry in open air, so that its surface tightens and crisps. Only after that does it get brushed with a glossy honey glaze and roasted in a clay charcoal oven built specifically for this purpose. But trust me: if you have a convection oven, a sturdy wire rack, and a baking tray, you can produce something every bit as wonderful at home. And if you pour half a cup of water into the tray beneath the rack, you can even skip the blanching entirely.

Three ingredients are non-negotiable — the soul of that unmistakable texture, flavor, and color: **honey**, **hoisin sauce**, and **red fermented tofu**. Without them, you're simply not making *char siu*.

Start with about a kilo of inexpensive pork — shoulder cuts like **pork shoulder**, **picnic ham**, or **Boston butt**. (The “butt,” confusingly, refers not to the rear of the animal but to a firm, marbled cut sitting just above the foreleg.) Even better is **pork sirloin**, which cooks up beautifully tender. Trim off excess fat and cut the meat into pieces roughly the size of an adult palm — about 7 × 4 × 1 inches. Pierce each piece all over with a fork or sharp knife; be bold here. The more holes you make, the deeper the marinade will sink in.

For 1 kilogram of meat, make the following marinade:

- 1 tablespoon garlic salt
- 4 tablespoons brown sugar
- 2 tablespoons oyster sauce (Lee Kum Kee)
- 1 tablespoon hoisin sauce
- 2 tablespoons cheap red wine
- 1 tablespoon Marsala or port
- 2 tablespoons red fermented tofu (Wangzhihe)
- 1 tablespoon five-spice powder (the Chinese blend of star anise, clove, cinnamon, Sichuan pepper, and fennel seed)

Combine everything thoroughly with the meat, then slip it all into a glass container, seal it tightly, and let it sit for about eight hours at room temperature — long enough for the pork to think deeply about its future.

When it's time to cook, line a deep metal baking tray with foil and set a sturdy wire rack on top, leaving a small gap between the rack and the surface of the tray. Pour half a cup of water into the foil-lined bottom.

Heat the oven to 425°F (218°C), preferably on convection. Arrange the pork pieces on the rack and roast for 15 minutes. Don't discard the marinade — now comes its encore. After the first quarter-hour, pull the tray out, brush the pork generously with the marinade, flip the pieces, brush the other side, and return the tray to the oven for another 15 minutes.

Now comes the glaze. Mix:

- 2 tablespoons honey
- 2 tablespoons water

Brush the pork on both sides once again and return it to the oven for 10 minutes.

Finally, switch the oven to broil, full power. Give the pork one last brush of honey-water glaze, slide the tray under the broiler, and let it bronzed and blister for about 5 minutes — but stay nearby. Honey burns faster than you can say “char.”

Pull the tray out, let the meat rest for 5 minutes, and it’s done.

A note: If you plan to serve Chinese barbecue pork for dinner, start marinating it in the morning. Total roasting time is about 50 minutes, and the internal temperature of the pork should reach roughly 150°F (65°C).

The Boiling Heart of Cantonese Cooking

Like so many trusting nations along Asia’s great rim, China found itself — almost without noticing — slipping into the sticky, clinging syrup of Marxist socialism in the early twentieth century. It settled over the country like an unwelcome fever: the kind that leaves you weak in the knees, dulled in spirit, unwilling to work or even move. And those who survived the shivering spell sat together in their dim kitchens, debating how to divide the last, pathetic handful of belongings “fairly,” as if fairness alone could warm their hands.

For more than a century China wrestled with this strange Marxist inheritance, and only recently has it begun to breathe freely again. No one kept a proper ledger of the dead from the civil war — how could they? — but famine and ration cards did their silent arithmetic, tallying tens of millions of vanished lives. I still remember the years when villagers in the humid south received half a liter of cloudy rapeseed oil per soul each month. Gaunt pigs and wiry chickens were guarded in backyards like family secrets, saved for the rare days when joy dared to show its face. And when such a day finally arrived, the wok was lifted out, the oil poured in, and a small miracle unfolded on the flame for the whole family to share.

I ate at those tables. I smuggled jars of fragrant peanut oil from Burmese traders for them. And I remember — so vividly it almost startles me — the look and smell of simple, honest Chinese happiness rising with the steam.

But we’re wandering. Let’s get back to the kitchen.

What you need now is a solid steel wok and a generous 1.5 to 2 liters of oil — refined corn oil or clarified sunflower oil will treat you kindly. To make working with hot oil less dramatic, order yourself a small steel frying basket on a long handle and a sturdy steel spatula to stir inside the wok. A thermometer with a thermocouple is also extremely useful when you’re deep-frying chicken or squid in a whisper-thin golden batter.

If you want to feel truly modern, you can even get a laser infrared thermometer. It’s a delightful little gadget — and surprisingly handy.

Battered chicken can be the star of a big family table — five to ten people easily — served with basmati rice (see the section on *Persian Steamed Pilaf* for that), along with cabbage salad, peeled peaches sliced into crescents, and whatever small plates you feel inspired to

add. Wok-fried squid, on the other hand, is the perfect end-of-day indulgence — light, crisp, a little mischievous. And don't let the number of words in the recipe intimidate you; the cooking itself is far more straightforward than it seems.

Salt & Pepper Calamari in the Wok

Begin by stripping half a kilo of squid of its thin membranes and dusky skin; remove the heads and fins. Cut the bodies into rectangles roughly three by two inches, and score each piece in a neat crosshatch with your sharpest knife. Halve the clusters of tentacles and lay everything out on paper towels so the surface dries a little. And yes — if you prefer the convenience of frozen squid rings or pieces, use them without shame; they'll behave beautifully here.

Start with a quick marinade:

- 1 tablespoon Marsala or dry sherry
- 1 egg yolk
- 1 tablespoon cornstarch

Whisk them together in a bowl, add the squid, tumble it all well, and let it rest for half an hour. Don't salt a thing — salt inside a batter draws moisture, and moisture is the enemy of crisp frying.

While the squid luxuriates, make the cloud-light Chinese batter. You could buy a packaged mix — Korean markets sell them by the dozen — but mixes are fickle creatures, and as *Alexey Zimin* liked to mutter, *pluralia tantum* words are always suspicious.

Here is a trustworthy, time-tested formula for squid batter:

- 4 tablespoons flour
- 2 tablespoons cornstarch
- 1 teaspoon baking powder (or a pinch of plain baking soda)
- ½ teaspoon salt
- 4–6 tablespoons water
- 1 tablespoon sunflower oil

Whisk the dry ingredients first, then add four tablespoons of water. As you stir, the batter will begin to gather itself; add another splash or two until it reaches the texture of pourable crème anglaise or loose sour cream — smooth, glossy, and able to fall from the whisk in a slow ribbon. Finish with the oil and beat it once more until satiny.

Now heat your wok with **1.5–2 liters of clarified vegetable oil** to 350°F (177°C). We're ready for the first fry.

Pour the batter over the marinated squid and toss gently to coat every nook. Check the oil temperature, then lower in half the squid — using tongs, chopsticks, or simple bravery. The

pieces should bob freely, each one crowned with a halo of cheerful, fast-rising bubbles. The oil temperature will fall by 30–40 degrees; don't panic, that is exactly what should happen. Keep the heat medium. After about three minutes, scoop the squid into a frying basket and lift it from the oil. Spread it out on paper towels to rest while you repeat with the second batch — making sure the oil climbs back up to 350°F before you drop them in.

At this point the squid is technically cooked: the batter should be a shy, pale gold.

But the Cantonese secret is resilience — making the crust firm and shatter-crisp, then perfuming it with aromatics. That means a second fry.

Raise the heat and bring the oil to 380°F (193°C). Combine both batches and lower them in for 30 seconds only. Lift them out onto fresh towels. Now the color should be an unapologetic, confident gold. You could serve them right now — absolutely. They'd be wonderful.

But Cantonese cooks like to take it one graceful step further.

Pour almost all the oil out of the wok, leaving just a shimmering couple of spoonfuls. Into that thin slick will go your fragrance base:

- 5 crushed garlic cloves
- ½ teaspoon garlic salt
- A handful of sliced scallions
- A few strips of red bell pepper, purely for beauty
- 3 tablespoons Marsala or sherry

If something from the list is missing, don't fret; the principle matters far more than the precise lineup.

Set the wok over medium heat and sauté the garlic and scallions until the kitchen smells like heaven. Add the red pepper. Now tip in all the golden squid, pour in the Marsala, and toss for a minute so the flavors mingle, cling, and glow. Finish with a dusting of garlic salt — or white pepper, if you're a believer — and rush the wok straight to the table.

A few last, essential notes: Heat the oil properly — use an infrared thermometer or a probe. Lower the battered squid gently; they should float freely. Wear rubber gloves if splatter worries you, and keep a wok lid nearby — but never clamp it down fully over hot oil. Condensed droplets will fall, the oil will spit, and the kitchen gods will not be amused. And remember: once the squid goes in, the oil temperature drops. That is why we fry in modest batches, twice over, at medium heat.

General Tso's Chicken

The general with a fondness for battered, deep-fried chicken was none other than *Tso Tsung-t'ang*, the nineteenth-century statesman who subdued the *Ili* region — what we now

call *Xinjiang* — when it was still a contested frontier between the Qing dynasty China and the Russian Empire. And yet, in the general's home province of Hunan, no one has even heard of such a dish. Naturally: *General Tso's Chicken* is pure émigré imagination.

You'll laugh, but this marvel seems to have been invented either by *Chef Peng* on East 44th Street or *Chef Wang* on East 55th sometime in the New York of the 1970s. Of course, they quarreled about who created it first — how could they not? Let us simply agree that both men were geniuses, and turn to the matter at hand: producing this miracle in your own kitchen. For that you'll need **500–600 grams of chicken breast**, sliced into bite-size pieces roughly the size of half your index finger — give or take — and left to luxuriate in a simple marinade.

For the marinade:

- 2 tbsp oyster sauce
- 1 tbsp Marsala or sherry
- 1 egg white
- 1 tbsp cornstarch

Whisk everything together, add the chicken, mix until every piece is glossed and coated, and let it rest for half an hour.

While the marinade does its quiet work, prepare the cloud-light Chinese batter.

For the batter:

- 3 tbsp flour
- 1 tbsp cornstarch
- 1 tsp baking powder (or just a pinch of baking soda)
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 egg white
- 4–6 tbsp water
- 1 tbsp sunflower oil

Start by whisking the dry ingredients. Add four tablespoons of water, whisk again, then blend in the egg white. You will most likely need to add another splash or two of water until the mixture resembles loose sour cream or pourable custard — a batter that falls from the whisk in a slow, silky ribbon. Finish by beating in the oil.

Set a wok on the stove and heat **1.5–2 liters of clarified vegetable oil** to 325°F (163°C) — medium heat will do. Pour the entire bowl of batter over the marinated chicken, stir well so everything is evenly coated, and prepare for the first fry.

Check the oil temperature, then ease in half the chicken, piece by piece. Raise the heat a little. The pieces should float freely, each wrapped in a crown of lively bubbles. After 7–8

minutes, scoop them into a steel frying basket, lift them out of the oil, and lay them onto paper towels to drain. Bring the oil back up to 325°F, and repeat with the remaining batch. At this stage, the crust should be a shy, pale gold.

The chicken is already cooked through. But the Cantonese secret lies in strengthening that crust — then flooding it with perfume and sweetness. In other words: a second fry.

Fish out any stray crumbs from the oil so they don't burn. Raise the heat a little and let the oil reach 350–380°F (177–193°C). Lower all the chicken pieces in for 1-2 minutes, then return them to fresh paper towels. Now the crust should be confidently golden.

Pour almost all the oil from the wok into a metal pot (you'll use it again), leaving just a fragrant sheen. This is the beginning of the sauce.

For the sauce:

- 5 crushed garlic cloves
- 3–4 cm fresh ginger, cut into matchsticks
- 2 lemongrass stalks, bruised with a kitchen mallet
- 2 tbsp brown sugar
- 2 tbsp Marsala or sherry
- 2 tbsp oyster sauce
- 2 tbsp soy sauce
- 1–2 tbsp apple or rice vinegar

Optional, for brightness or heat:

- ½ red bell pepper, sliced into thin ribbons
- 3–4 fresh red chilies

Sauté the garlic, ginger, lemongrass, and chilies (if using) in the couple of tablespoons of oil left in the wok. After 3–4 minutes, add the sugar, wine, vinegar, and sauces. Bring everything to a lively boil over high heat, and let it bubble for a minute. Dissolve **1 tablespoon cornstarch** in **2 tablespoons water**, pour it in, and stir until the sauce thickens and shines.

Now, for the finale:

Lower the chicken into the bubbling sauce and give it 30 seconds of fierce heat. Toss until everything is lacquered and gleaming. Shower the top with toasted sesame seeds if you have them, and rush it to the table.

This is victory.

A few essential notes: Heat the oil properly at the start and check it with an infrared or probe thermometer. Lower the battered chicken gently — they should

float easily. Gloves are helpful, and keeping the wok lid nearby is wise, though remember: never cover hot oil completely. Condensed droplets will fall back into the wok and make the oil spit angrily. Once the chicken goes in, the temperature will drop by about thirty degrees — perfectly normal. This is why we fry in batches, twice, at medium heat.

Butterfly Shrimp from Guangzhou

Here's a quick — and surprisingly faithful — version of the feather-light fried shrimp you might order in any good Guangdong restaurant. The dish takes its name from the way the shrimp are prepared: the shells come off, the backs are slit, and the tails open wide like the wings of a resting butterfly.

Start with **half a kilo of shrimp tails**. Peel them, but leave the last segment and the fan of the tail attached—it makes them easier to hold later and far prettier on the plate. Remove the dark vein along the spine, make a shallow cut in the same spot halfway through the flesh, and gently open each shrimp as though you were unfolding a delicate paper fan.

Now prepare the airy batter:

- 4 tbsp flour
- 2 tbsp cornstarch
- 1 tsp baking powder (the old-fashioned, soda-based kind)
- ½ tsp salt
- 4–6 tbsp cold water
- 1 tbsp sesame oil

Mix the dry ingredients. Add four tablespoons of cold water and whisk until smooth. You'll likely need to trickle in a bit more water: the goal is a batter with the texture of thin sour cream — one that drips off the whisk in a soft, continuous ribbon. Finish by whisking in the sesame oil (regular vegetable oil will do in a pinch) until the surface looks glossy and relaxed.

Set a small wok over medium heat and warm **1–1.5 liters of clarified vegetable oil** to 350–380°F (177–193°C). Transfer the prepared shrimp into the bowl of batter and stir until every fold and curve is coated.

Check the oil temperature, then spoon in half the shrimp. Pick them up one by one with chopsticks, let the excess batter fall away, and lower them gently into the hot oil. They should float freely, each one surrounded by a halo of playful, rising bubbles. Keep the heat steady. After 3–4 minutes, scoop the shrimp into a steel frying basket, lift them from the oil, and set them on a wide plate lined with paper towels. Repeat with the remaining batch, and lay those onto the same paper bed. Mind your butterflies — your goal is a tender, pale-gold crust, nothing darker. Serve immediately, before their wings cool.

A few important notes: Heat the oil properly before you begin; check the temperature with an infrared thermometer or a probe. Lower the battered shrimp gently — they should drift and float, never sink. Rubber gloves aren't a bad idea, and keep the wok's lid nearby, just in case the oil begins to spit. But never cover the wok completely — condensed droplets from the lid will fall back into the oil and cause more sputtering, not less.

And don't let the temperature drop worry you: once the shrimp go in, the oil will lose about twenty degrees. That is exactly why we fry in batches, in two calm installments. Medium heat is your friend.

Crisp Little Quails from the Wok

Pick up four quails — supermarkets usually sell them in tidy packs of four, which is just right for two generous servings. In a deep bowl, stir together a teaspoon of salt and half a cup of Marsala or dry white wine, slip the birds into this perfumed bath, and let them rest for a couple of hours. Try not to forget them entirely; turn them once or twice so the marinade can do its quiet work. And leave the skin on. It rewards you later.

When the quails are ready, lift them from the marinade, wrap them in paper towels, and dry them thoroughly. Then dry them again. The drier the skin, the crisper the finish — you are, quite literally, setting up the crackle.

Set a small wok over medium heat and warm **1–1.5 liters of clarified oil** to 350–380°F (177–193°C). Lower the dry birds into the oil gently, one by one, and fry them for 5–6 minutes, turning them a couple of times with a bamboo spatula until their skin turns the color of late-afternoon sunshine — deep golden and promisingly crisp. Lift them out in a wire basket, let them rest on a plate lined with paper towels to shed any excess oil, and bring them to the table hot, with lemon wedges. Your guests will know what to do.

A few important notes: Heat the oil properly and check it with an infrared thermometer or a probe. Ease the quails in — one after another — and make sure they can float freely. Rubber gloves won't hurt, and keep the wok lid nearby in case the oil grows temperamental. But never cover the wok completely: droplets condensed on the lid will fall back into the oil, and the oil will protest in the usual way. Don't fret when the temperature drops by thirty degrees as soon as the birds go in — that's just physics. Fry in batches, in two calm installments. Medium heat is your ally.

Golden Shrimp Pops from the Wok

Take about **600–700 grams of peeled shrimp tails** and pulse them in a food processor until they turn into a smooth, pale paste. Tip this mixture into a deep glass bowl and work it vigorously with a wooden spoon. The goal is not strength but breath: you want the mixture to take in air, to grow springy and alive under your hand.

Now fold in **2 tablespoons of water**, **2 tablespoons of cornstarch**, and **2 tablespoons of oyster sauce**, stirring steadily. Add **1 tablespoon of soy sauce** and **1 tablespoon of sesame oil**, and mix once more. With damp hands, shape the mixture into small balls — 3 to 4 centimeters across — then roll them lightly over a plate dusted with cornstarch so they don't cling to one another.

If you happen to find those half-shelled crab claws sold in many Chinese and Korean supermarkets, you can tuck one into each shrimp ball before frying. Your guests will remember these golden creatures long after dinner. But truly — this step is pure whimsy, not necessity.

Set a small wok over medium heat and warm **1–1.5 liters of clarified oil** to 350–380°F (177–193°C). Lower the shrimp balls gently into the oil with a skimmer and fry them for 4–5 minutes, until they turn crisp and golden, as though sun-lit from within. Lift them into a wire basket, let the excess oil drain onto paper-towel-lined plates, and bring them straight to the table with lemon wedges. Shrimp, like applause, is best served hot.

A few important notes: Make sure each shrimp ball is well coated in starch and dry to the touch before it meets the oil — moisture is the enemy of crispness. Heat the oil properly and check it with an infrared thermometer or a probe. Lower the fritters in gently; they should float freely, each one surrounded by a little halo of bubbling joy.

Rubber gloves help, and keeping the wok's lid nearby is wise — though the lid should *never* sit fully on the wok while the oil is boiling. Condensed droplets will fall back into the oil, and the oil will protest, loudly.

After you add the shrimp balls, the oil temperature will drop by thirty degrees or so; this is perfectly normal. Fry in batches, in two calm rounds. Medium heat is your friend.

The Kowloon Kraken: Soy-Braised Cuttlefish

This old street recipe came to me from the days when Hong Kong was still a far-flung British outpost, a place where the air smelled of salt, diesel, and something delicious simmering just around the corner.

So — thaw your great sea creature from the Indian Ocean, a **two- or three-kilo cuttlefish**, and trim away the soft cartilage from its belly. I'd also suggest removing the hard core from the head and discarding the eyes. Everything else stays. Dry the cuttlefish thoroughly on paper towels — really thoroughly — and tie its tentacles back over the head, like a scarf on a stubborn traveler.

First, prepare the aromatics. In a wide nonstick pan, heat **2–3 tablespoons of oil** and sauté **a good length of ginger** (about 6–8 centimeters), smashed with a kitchen mallet, along with a couple of **bruised lemongrass stalks** and **6–8 crushed cloves of garlic**. When they

release their fragrance, add **600–800 grams of inexpensive pork** — its fat will enrich the sauce and keep the cuttlefish from drying out later. **Four pork sirloin fillets** are perfect; they're usually sold at Costco pre-cut in tidy 6 × 2 × 1-inch slabs. If you have a whole piece of sirloin instead, just cut it into generous chunks, fat and all. Medium heat. Once everything has taken on a bit of color, set the pan aside.

Now for the cuttlefish itself. Heat **3–4 tablespoons of oil** in a large wok (or a wide, heavy pan with a tight lid) and sear the beast for 5–6 minutes on each side over medium heat. Then tumble in the pork, garlic, ginger, and lemongrass from the first pan and add the following:

- Soy sauce (200 ml)
- Brown sugar (60 g)
- Cinnamon (2 sticks)
- Star anise (3–4 pods)
- White wine (120 ml)
- Water (400 ml)

Cover tightly, bring the liquid to a boil, then turn the heat down to the gentlest whisper. The soy broth should come high enough to almost cover the thick swimming tube and tentacles. Let everything braise for about an hour, turning the cuttlefish once or twice. Then add **2 tablespoons of curry powder**, cover again, and continue cooking on low heat for another half hour. By then the cuttlefish will have become wonderfully tender, its skin touched with the golden color of spices.

Lift the cuttlefish and pork onto a heatproof glass platter or tray. Brush the whole creature with **Kikkoman Teriyaki glaze**, or with a simple mixture of honey and vinegar (1:1), and slide it under the broiler for about 5-10 minutes. Slice and serve.

Remember, we once roasted cuttlefish using a much fussier recipe. With slow braising, though, there's nothing to fear — this one simply can't fail.

Mushrooms and Vegetables

The green aisles of any market — even a modest European one, to say nothing of those in Burma or southern China — promise adventure the moment you step into their shade. Here are cauliflower heads shaped like small starships, thistles disguised as artichokes, mushrooms wearing couture hats, bundles of proud asparagus, pods of all colors and temperaments, and herbs so unfamiliar you hesitate for a second, unsure whether the leaves or the roots hold the secret.

What follows is only a small handful of the most faithful, time-tested ideas. In truth, this whole chapter opens into a boundless field. Don't be afraid to wander.

Mushrooms, Just Mushrooms

Porcini or *chanterelles* — about a kilo to a kilo and a half — bought from a good farmers' market or a trustworthy grocery store, barely brushed clean of leaves and pine needles, are all you need for a dish so comforting it practically cooks itself. Whatever you do, don't wash them: rinsed mushrooms steam instead of sear, and steam is the enemy of flavor here. Just take your time choosing the cleanest-looking baskets, and let the rest be simple.

Set a wide nonstick skillet over medium heat, melt a little oil, and let the mushrooms settle in for a slow, steady browning — twenty to thirty minutes is about right. Near the end, if the mood strikes, add separately sautéed onions or shallots, or even a few cubes of potatoes fried to a gentle gold in vegetable oil. *Separately* is the key word: toss raw onions or potatoes straight into the mushrooms, and they'll steam into a sulky gray heap.

To finish, stir in a couple of spoonfuls of rich sour cream, or — even better — about a cup of heavy cream. Add half a tablespoon of salt and the barest whisper of brown sugar, then let everything murmur together on low heat for another ten or twenty minutes.

The result will be astonishingly deep and balanced — the kind of dish you can serve entirely on its own, without a thought for meat. Just mushrooms, doing what mushrooms do best.

Five-Flavor Vegetable Stew with Three Mushrooms and Snow Peas

Numerology is woven tightly into Chinese culture. It says that the body stays in balance when five elements are in balance: Water feeds Wood, Wood fuels Fire, Fire leaves behind Ash that becomes Earth, and from Earth, Metal is born. I couldn't tell you exactly what symbolic role the vegetables play in this particular pot, but whatever the theory, the practice is excellent.

What I especially love here is the way different mushrooms, *bok choy*, and snow peas keep each other company — soft, crisp, earthy, green.

Start with the mushrooms. Rinse the fresh shiitakes and wood ear mushrooms in a bowl of water to rinse away sand and grit. Trim off and discard the shiitake stems, then cut the caps

in half. With the wood ears, keep only the tender “ears” themselves: slice them into ½-cm strips and snip off any tough stems with scissors — those can go straight to the compost.

Heat some vegetable oil in a wide nonstick skillet over medium heat and add the mushrooms. Let them fry gently. After about 10 minutes, pour in a cup of dry white wine, cover, and let them braise another 20 minutes. Salt lightly at the end.

In another pan or a wok, warm some oil and sauté the garlic and ginger over medium heat until they turn golden and fragrant. Add the red fermented tofu, hoisin, and oyster sauce; fry for another 30 seconds so the flavors open up. Then in go the canned straw mushrooms, the snow peas, and the bok choy — they only need another half-minute or so, just enough to get glossed with sauce.

Now bring it all together: tip the sautéed shiitakes and wood ears, along with their juices, into the wok. Add a cup of water, cover, and let everything simmer very gently for 15–20 minutes, until the flavors mingle and relax into one another. If the liquid gets too low, drizzle in a bit more water — you want a soft simmer, not a rolling boil.

When the stew smells irresistible and the vegetables look happy in the pan, take it to the table just as it is — spooned over rice, or simply in warm bowls with good bread alongside.

For 4 servings you’ll need:

- Fresh shiitake mushrooms (8–10 caps)
- Wood ear mushrooms (black fungus, 250 g)
- Canned straw mushrooms (*Volvariella volvacea*, 150 g)
- Vegetable oil (6–8 tbsp)
- Oyster sauce (Lee Kum Kee, 2 tbsp)
- Hoisin sauce (Lee Kum Kee, 2 tbsp)
- Dry white wine (200 ml, about 1 cup)
- Garlic (6 cloves, halved lengthwise)
- Ginger (about 4 cm, peeled and cut into fine matchsticks)
- Snow peas (about 20 pods, trimmed of stems)
- Bok choy (200–250 g, cut into 4–5 cm ribbons)
- Red fermented tofu (fermented bean curd, 2 tbsp)

Quick-Marinated *Enoki* Mushrooms

Enoki mushrooms — those pale, grasslike clusters that look as if they sprouted overnight from a patch of moonlit soil — need almost no preparation. Trim off the bottom 4–5 centimeters of the stems, where the mycelium still clings together, but don’t wash them: like all delicate mushrooms, they prefer to meet the pan dry.

Before the enoki ever touch the skillet, though, the stage belongs to aromatics. Set a deep steel pan over medium heat, pour in a generous slick of oil, and warm the lemongrass, the

galangal, and a whole head of garlic sliced cleanly in half. No need to peel it — the heat will coax out its sweetness just the same.

Let the spices lounge in the oil for a good twenty minutes, long enough for the perfume to settle into the kitchen and for the oil to taste fully awake. Only then are the mushrooms invited in.

The enoki need barely ten minutes in the fragrant oil to soften and catch a little color. After that, it's time for the marinade: soy sauce, oyster sauce, white wine, and brown sugar — all the deep, savory, gently sweet notes that make mushrooms feel at home. Bring everything to a simmer and let it burble softly for 5–7 minutes.

At the very end, add the vinegar and let the pot warm for another minute or so, just enough for the acidity to find its place among the other flavors. Then remove the pan from the heat.

You can cool the mushrooms right in their marinade and serve them together — the liquid is part of the experience — though you might want to fish out the garlic halves and the lemongrass stalks before bringing the dish to the table.

It's astonishing how quickly something so aromatic and satisfying can come together. An hour from start to finish, and the result tastes like it spent the afternoon in the care of a patient cook.

You will need:

- Enoki mushrooms (*Flammulina filiformis*, 6 packs of 150 g each or 900 g total)
- Vegetable oil (50–70 ml)
- Lemongrass (2–3 stalks, bruised with a kitchen mallet)
- Galangal or ginger (2–3 cm)
- Cloves (3–4 pieces)
- Garlic (1 whole head, sliced in half crosswise)
- Soy sauce (200 ml or 1 cup)
- Oyster sauce (100 ml or ½ cup)
- White wine (200 ml or 1 cup)
- Brown sugar (80 g or ½ cup)
- Apple cider vinegar, 5% (100 ml or ½ cup)

Note: You can double the amount of mushrooms without adjusting the marinade — there will be plenty.

Cabbage

Cabbage tends to stand a little apart from the vegetable crowd — sturdier, sterner, as if it's been around long enough to know that real flavor sometimes requires time, patience, and a little controlled chaos. Fermentation or pickling softens its stubbornness, tames its crunch,

and coaxes out the bright, earthy tang that makes it worth every minute you spend preparing it.

Four-Day Sauerkraut

Craving a bit of homemade sauerkraut? We can make that happen. Sauerkraut is simply cabbage transformed by fermentation — the quiet work of natural yeasts living on the leaves, breaking down sugars in the absence of oxygen and turning them into something tangy, refreshing, and alive.

Start with **3–4 tight, heavy white cabbages**, which should give you roughly 3 kilograms (about 6½ pounds) once shredded. Slice away the green outer leaves, then cut the rest into thin ribbons. Peel **3–4 fresh carrots** (about 700 grams) and shred them into matchsticks. A mandoline or food processor will do this in minutes, though the old-fashioned knife method is oddly satisfying. Just be sure to weigh everything — precision matters here — because you'll need exactly **75 grams of coarse rock salt** for this amount of vegetables. Less salt means sharper, quicker sourness; more salt slows the fermentation and helps the kraut keep longer in the cold.

Choose a clean 7–8-liter steel pot with a tight lid. Layer the cabbage and carrots inside, sprinkling the measured salt between the layers. With each layer, press lightly — truly lightly — with your hands until you see the first glimmer of juice. When all the vegetables are in, press them down firmly to drive out as much air as possible.

Now make a simple weight: lay a few pieces of plastic wrap over the surface, set a large plate on top, and place a small jar of water on the plate. The weight will keep the vegetables submerged so fermentation can begin. Leave the pot at room temperature for about two days, until you see foam and bubbles gathering under the plate — a sure sign that the cabbage is waking up.

At that point, remove the weight and mix the cabbage thoroughly with your hands, right down to the bottom. This releases trapped carbon dioxide and keeps the fermentation friendly rather than funky. Replace the plate and weight, cover the pot, and move it to the lowest shelf of your refrigerator. Two days later, give the cabbage another good turn with your hands and return it to the fridge once more.

There it will live — happily, quietly — until you eat every last bit. Which, trust me, won't take long.

Important: Always follow the ratio of **20 grams of rock salt per 1 kilogram of shredded cabbage and carrots**. Use only rock salt — never sea salt and never iodized salt.

Moo Shu Pork or Moo Shu Shrimp (Served in Lettuce Cups)

Think of this dish as a small celebration of cabbage and mushrooms — a Cantonese classic that the cooks at *R & G Lounge* on Kearny Street in San Francisco assemble as quickly and deftly as magicians pulling scarves from a sleeve. Fifteen, maybe twenty minutes — and a fragrant, colorful heap of *Moo Shu* appears, ready to be wrapped in the thinnest pancakes glossed with hoisin.

We'll take a gentler path: the same flavors, the same comforting warmth — but tucked into cool, crisp lettuce cups so the vegetables can really shine.

The technique behind *Moo Shu* is simple enough; what requires care is choosing and preparing the ingredients. Chinese cooks traditionally rely on dried wood ear mushrooms, soaked back to life in water. But if you can find fresh ones, use them — they taste like a walk through a damp forest after rain.

Rinse the fresh wood ears in a bowl of water to shake loose any grit. Trim off the tough roots with scissors and slice the soft “ears” into thin quarter-centimeter ribbons. Sauté them in a bit of oil in a nonstick pan — eight to ten minutes on medium heat will do. Add a handful of carrot cut into delicate matchsticks, pour in half a cup of dry white wine, and let everything simmer together for five minutes on high. The mushrooms will drink in the wine and soften just enough. Set the pan aside.

Now decide who your main character will be: pork or shrimp. *Moo Shu* welcomes both.

For pork, take two pieces of pork loin, each about 3 cm thick. Slice them first into thin sheets, then into slender strips. Toss the strips with half a tablespoon of cornstarch and a full tablespoon of oyster sauce, and let them rest for half an hour. The flavor will thank you.

If you choose shrimp, remove the dark vein from each thawed tail and chop the meat into small, neat cubes. Mix with half a tablespoon of cornstarch, a splash of oyster sauce, and the white of one egg. Give it the same gentle half-hour rest.

Either way, the next step is identical: stir-fry your pork or shrimp with a spoonful of pine nuts in a hot wok or skillet for 4–5 minutes, just until golden and fragrant. Transfer to a bowl.

Whisk two eggs with half a teaspoon of cornstarch and fry them into a thin omelet — nothing fancy, just a soft sheet of egg kissed by oil on both sides. Let it cool slightly and slice it into ribbons no thicker than pencil shavings.

Now — the cabbage, the quiet heart of the dish. Choose a fresh, tight head, one that feels heavy for its size. Early spring and summer cabbages in California tend to be pale and sleepy, so Chinese cooks often switch to Taiwanese cabbage for crunch. Take half a medium head, discard the loose outer leaves, remove the core, and shred the rest into fine chiffonade. A couple stalks of celery, also sliced into thin matchsticks, bring brightness and snap.

Heat a wok or large nonstick skillet with a generous splash of oil. Add finely chopped ginger and garlic, and stir until the fragrance escapes the pan and fills your kitchen. Add the cabbage and celery and cook over high heat until softened but still lively — five to eight minutes. Don't cover the pan; the cabbage needs room for its juices to evaporate.

Now fold in the mushrooms and carrots — ideally squeezed a bit to remove the leftover wine. Too much liquid will weigh the dish down. Return the pork or shrimp with the pine nuts, raise the heat to its highest setting, and let everything sizzle until nearly dry.

Finish with a spoonful of Marsala or Sherry, a splash of soy sauce, a spoonful of oyster sauce, and a pinch of brown sugar. Stir thoroughly so the flavors settle into one another.

Scatter the sliced egg omelet over the top and gently fold everything together.

For serving, you'll want crisp lettuce cups — Bibb, Boston, Butter, even Romaine if that's what your market offers. Pat the leaves dry (a wet leaf is the enemy of a tidy wrap), brush the insides lightly with hoisin if you like, and spoon 1–2 tablespoons of *Moo Shu* into each cup. What arrives on the table will be fresh, aromatic, and deeply comforting — a dish that tastes both familiar and entirely new.

For about four generous servings of *Moo Shu*, you'll need:

- Wood ear mushrooms (fresh black wood ear, about 300 g)
- Pork loin, two pieces about 3 cm thick each (roughly 300 g total)
- or 6–8 large shrimp tails, peeled (about 250–300 g)
- Pine nuts (2 tbsp)
- Neutral vegetable oil (8–9 tbsp)
- Dry white wine (100 ml)
- Eggs (2)
- Marsala or dry Sherry (2 tbsp)
- Fresh ginger (about a 2 cm piece, very finely chopped)
- Garlic (2–3 cloves, very finely chopped)
- Half a medium head of cabbage (300–500 g, finely shredded)
- Celery (2 stalks, cut into thin matchsticks)
- Carrot (about 8 cm, cut into fine julienne)
- Brown sugar (½ tbsp)
- Cornstarch (1 tbsp)
- Soy sauce (3 tbsp)
- Oyster sauce (3 tbsp)
- Hoisin sauce (1 tbsp)
- One small head of tender lettuce (Bibb, Boston, Butter, or Romaine) for the cups

Cauliflower Fritters with a Persian Yogurt Sauce

Begin with the sauce — a light, herb-bright Persian yogurt sauce you may remember from the cucumber version we made earlier. In a small bowl, stir together 300 ml of plain yogurt or sour cream with a generous handful of cilantro leaves, torn by hand so they keep their perfume. Grate in the zest of a lime, a lemon, or even an orange — whatever citrus is lounging in your fruit bowl — the point is simply to let a ribbon of brightness run through the sauce. Add a spoonful of lemon juice, a splash of olive oil, and half a teaspoon of salt. Give it all a gentle stir and tuck the bowl into the refrigerator. An hour of rest will turn it silky and composed.

Now for the cauliflower. Trim away the leaves, carve out the tough central stalk, and break the head into florets. Slip them into a pot of salted boiling water and cook until tender, 10–15 minutes. Drain them well, let the steam dry them a bit, and, if some florets are too large, cut them into bite-sized pieces — fritter-sized, really, no more than a centimeter across.

While the cauliflower softens, whisk together the batter: flour, chopped cilantro, eggs, spices, and a full tablespoon of salt. When the mixture becomes glossy and smooth, fold in the warm cauliflower, turning the bowl until every little floret is coated in gold.

Heat 1.5–2 centimeters of neutral oil in a wide skillet over medium-high heat. You want it shimmering, not furious. Lower the battered florets into the oil — gently, carefully — either with a small ladle or whatever tool helps you keep your fingers safe. Make sure the fritters have room to float; if they crowd, coax them apart with a wooden spatula. Reduce the heat to medium and fry until each side is the color of late-afternoon sunshine, about 3–4 minutes per side.

Move the finished fritters to a plate lined with paper towels so the excess oil can wander off. Serve them hot, crisp, and fragrant, with the chilled Persian yogurt sauce alongside. The contrast — warm spice against cool citrus — is exactly the kind of thing that makes a home kitchen feel, suddenly, like a little holiday.

Fritters

- Cauliflower (1 small head, about 350 g)
- Flour (120 g)
- Cilantro (3 tbsp, finely chopped)
- Eggs (4)
- Ground cumin (1 tsp)
- Ground turmeric or curry powder (1 tsp)
- Salt (1 tbsp)
- Neutral vegetable oil for frying (500 ml)

Sauce

- Plain yogurt or sour cream (300 ml)
- Cilantro (a handful of leaves)
- Lime, lemon, or orange zest
- Lemon juice (1 tbsp)
- Olive oil (1 tbsp)
- Salt (½ tsp)

Korean-Style Carrot Salad

No one, absolutely no one, treats carrots with more respect — or more flair — than Korean cooks. There's no need to reinvent anything here; we simply follow their lead, step by gentle step. Start with **two kilos of firm, bright carrots**. Peel them and cut them into thin matchsticks with a sharp knife (a food processor will do in a pinch, but the knife rewards you with better texture). Gather the orange tangle into a wide steel pot or onto a large tray, sprinkle with **two tablespoons of salt**, and massage the shreds lightly with your hands until they begin to give off juice. Leave them for an hour at room temperature.

When the time is up, tip the carrots into a metal colander and **drain off every drop of the salty liquid**. Transfer the softened carrots to a glass container with a tight-fitting lid — a Pyrex dish is perfect.

While the carrots rest, you have just enough time to make the fragrant oil that brings the whole dish to life:

- 1 medium onion, sliced into very thin crescents
- 1 whole head of garlic, cloves smashed under the flat of a heavy knife
- A thumb of ginger (3–4 cm), peeled and cut into thin strips — if you have it
- 5–6 cloves
- 2 stars of star anise — optional
- 1 tablespoon coriander seeds — optional

Pour about a cup (150 ml) of vegetable oil into a nonstick skillet and warm it gently with the onion, garlic, and ginger over low heat for about 10 minutes. Add the spices and let everything steep together over the same soft heat for another 3–5 minutes. The kitchen will smell like a spice shop opening for the morning.

Now turn back to the carrots. Sprinkle in two tablespoons of brown sugar and pour over **four tablespoons of good apple cider vinegar (5%)**. And then — the best moment — strain the hot, aromatic oil directly over the carrots through a metal sieve. Everything caught in the sieve (the garlic, the onion, the spices) has already given its best; discard it with thanks.

Press the warm carrots down firmly, close the lid, and let the salad rest for 24 hours. Time will do the rest, rounding the edges of sweetness and heat until the carrots taste like a small celebration in a glass jar.

A note on balance: Any salt will work here, but the proportions matter. For every kilo of carrots, use:

- 1 tablespoon (20–25 g) salt
- 1 tablespoon (20 g) sugar
- 2 tablespoons apple cider vinegar

Keep that ratio, and your carrot salad will never let you down.

Lightly Salted Summer Cucumbers

Pickling is a kind of quiet alchemy — a conversation between time and the invisible forces that reshape what we eat. Vegetables that only yesterday rested obediently on the vine now meet salt, spices, and the cool shelter of a pot or refrigerator, and something in them shifts. Inside, a soft, bubbling life begins; flavors move, deepen, settle into new shapes of themselves. A day or two later, you lift the lid and find not the vegetable you started with, but a new one entirely — a taste forged slowly, patiently, by waiting.

If you grow cucumbers in your garden, you know how summer can suddenly drown you in them. And you can only make so many salads. Lightly salted cucumbers, though — crisp, cold, just on the edge of fermentation — are a joy you can always bring to the table. You'll need a big 15-liter pot with a lid—or something close to it—and a bit of room in the refrigerator. This is a small three-act play.

Act I: The Soak

Even cucumbers picked moments ago benefit from a long, cold bath. It coaxes out their crunch, making them firmer and more resilient. Give them four to six hours in plenty of cold water. For a pot this size, I typically use about eight kilos of small varieties like *Sweet Success*, a type bred for Utah and California gardens.

Act II: The Brine

These cucumbers prefer coarse rock salt—Ukrainian, if you can find it. Two level tablespoons per liter is about right, or roughly 30–40 grams. That's what keeps them “lightly salted,” not fully sour.

First, figure out how much water you'll need: enough to cover the cucumbers *and* the plate you'll use to weigh them down. For eight kilos, I usually need around eight liters. Measure out 35 grams of salt per liter (about 280 grams total) and dissolve it in a liter of soft water. Bring it to a boil, and once it rolls, drop in the aromatics:

- Two whole heads of garlic, cut in half but unpeeled
- Two large roots of galangal, finely sliced (if you're lucky enough to have them)
- Two star anise pods
- Ten to fifteen cloves

Let everything simmer for about ten minutes, drawing out the garlic's sweetness and the spices' warmth. Add the remaining seven liters of water and bring it all to a boil again. Turn off the heat, lift the lid, and let the brine cool just slightly — five to ten minutes is enough.

Act III: The Cucumbers

Meanwhile, scrub the soaked cucumbers dry, trim off their stem ends, and slide them gently into the hot brine. Leave the pot uncovered on the stove.

If the brine were at a furious boil — or if you covered it tightly — you'd lose that lively, cheerful green color cucumbers wear so well. Now is the moment to tuck in a handful of roughly chopped basil (thick stems and blossoms welcome), or a few cherry or blackcurrant leaves if you grow them. A spoonful of grated horseradish with beets wouldn't be out of place either.

After about twelve hours on the stove, move the pot to the refrigerator. The cold slows fermentation, and you want to catch the cucumbers before the brine clouds. They'll be ready to eat in about a day — shimmering, gently tangy, wonderfully crisp.

Important note: Always use rock salt, not sea salt and not iodized salt. And keep the golden proportion: **30–40 grams of salt per 1 liter of brine.**

Marinated Tomatoes

Begin by washing your tomatoes and giving each one a quick prick with a toothpick near the stem — a small kindness that keeps their skins from bursting later in the brine. Set them gently into a large 15-liter stainless-steel pot, layering handfuls of herbs between them as you go. Basil, dill, whatever smells like summer to you — all of it will settle into the fruit as they rest.

Tomatoes come in every possible size and temperament, so the brine is always calculated by volume, not weight. The usual reference point is the old Soviet classic: a three-liter jar packed with tomatoes. For that much fruit you'd use 80 grams of sugar, 50 grams of salt, and 100 milliliters of good 5% apple cider vinegar.

A big pot, though — especially a roomy **15-liter** one — makes the work easier. Just multiply everything by five. You'll need **400 grams of sugar, 250 grams of salt, and 500 milliliters of vinegar.**

Pour **5–6 liters of water** into the pot and dissolve the salt and sugar over high heat. Once the brine reaches a rolling boil, add **three unpeeled heads of garlic** sliced crosswise, **10–20 white peppercorns**, and **10–15 whole cloves**. Let everything simmer for about 10 minutes so the spices and garlic can surrender their fragrance. Then turn off the heat and pour the boiling brine straight over the neatly layered tomatoes. Top off with plain boiling water, just enough to fully submerge them, and only then stir in the apple cider vinegar.

Let the pot cool on the stove with its lid on, then move it to the refrigerator, where the tomatoes will quietly absorb the flavors over the coming days.

Note: Here you can use regular table salt — nothing fancy required. The standard proportion remains: **80 g sugar, 50 g salt, and 100 ml of 5% apple cider vinegar for every 3-liter jar of tomatoes.**

Zucchini and Summer Squash

The simplest, most forgiving way to treat young zucchini, summer squash, or pattypan is almost embarrassingly direct: slice them into coins about two centimeters thick, salt them lightly, dust them in flour, and let hot oil do the rest.

Set a wide nonstick skillet over medium-high heat and warm half a cup of neutral oil to about 360°F (180°C). Lay the squash slices in carefully, making sure they have room to breathe — no crowding, or they'll steam instead of crisp. Lower the heat to medium so they don't scorch, and fry until both sides turn a sunny golden brown, about 3–4 minutes per side. Move them to a paper towel to shed any excess oil, and take them straight to the table while they're still warm and tender at the core.

Zucchini Fritters

A touch more effort here, but still a gentle kind of cooking — the sort that rewards a calm kitchen and a cooks' patience.

Start by grating **1 to 1.5 kilograms** of young zucchini on the large holes of a box grater. **Salt** them generously — a full, heaping tablespoon, **about 30 grams** — then toss and let them sit for ten minutes. Line a metal colander with cheesecloth, turn the zucchini into it, gather the cloth into a pouch, and squeeze out as much salted juice as your hands can manage. Think of it as waking up the vegetable, tightening its flavor.

Transfer the lightly dried zucchini to a large bowl. Add **4 to 5 heaping tablespoons of flour** (about 100 g) and **3 eggs**, and mix until everything is evenly combined. A spoonful of chopped cilantro or a teaspoon of mild curry powder wouldn't go amiss if they're already in your pantry.

Meanwhile, heat about a cup of neutral oil in a wide nonstick skillet until it reaches 360°F (180°C). Here's where attention matters: overheated oil will spit and sputter. To keep things

civilized, drop the batter into the pan with a small ladle held at a distance; the fritters should have enough room to float freely. If they drift too close, nudge them apart with a wooden spatula.

Lower the heat to medium and fry until the underside turns beautifully golden — golden, not brown, which would mean you’ve gone too far — about four minutes. Flip with a bamboo spatula, fry another four minutes, and move the fritters to a paper towel so they can lose their excess oil. Serve right away, while the edges are crispy and the centers still soft.

A small trick: to judge whether your oil is at the right temperature, dip the wide edge of a bamboo spatula into the pan. If a delicate necklace of tiny bubbles forms around it, the oil is ready.

Eggplants

The eggplant (*Solanum melongena*) traces its lineage back to India and South Asia, where its wild ancestors — still roaming the hillsides — remain small, seedy, and unmistakably bitter. Ancient Sanskrit texts suggest that people began taming these austere little fruits several thousand years ago, coaxing them slowly toward sweetness. Over centuries they traveled westward with traders and monks, crossed deserts and empires, and eventually reached the Mediterranean, where cooks coaxed out their tenderness with salt, oil, and fire.

Today we inherit the best of those centuries: eggplants that are plump, glossy, and yielding, ready to soften at the slightest touch of heat. They love a hot oven, adore a smoky grill, and collapse into sweetness when given enough time and a little patience. In California’s bright light they grow beautifully — especially the slender Japanese cultivars with poetic names like *Money Maker* and *Millionaire Purple*, bred for this very climate (If you’re planning to dig a new bed, order seeds from KitazawaSeed.com).

Working with eggplants always feels a bit like working with velvet. You have to be gentle, and you have to trust the process. Give them space, give them heat, and they will reward you with a flavor that is earthy and soothing, almost contemplative. Whether you roast them whole, turn them into a silken dip, braise them Sichuan-style, or fold them into a comforting bake with yesterday’s roast chicken, eggplants quietly anchor a meal and make it feel complete.

Here are a few ways to let them shine.

Roasted Eggplants

Preheat your oven to 475°F (246°C). With a large knife, slice **2-4 big purple eggplants** lengthwise, right through the green cap. Take a small, sharp knife and score the white flesh: first 3–4 long parallel cuts, then 3–4 more at a right angle, creating a lattice of diamonds.

Try not to pierce the skin — it will act as a natural baking dish, holding the softening flesh in place as it cooks.

If you love garlic, slip **3–5 thinly sliced cloves** between the diamonds. If you don't, simply skip this step but be generous with olive oil — rub it into every groove. Arrange the halves cut-side up on a foil-lined baking sheet and roast for 50–60 minutes, until the diamonds slump into tenderness and their edges turn golden.

When they're ready, remove the tray and let the eggplants cool just enough that you can handle them without a curse. Using a large spoon, scrape the roasted flesh from the skins and spoon it into a small glass baking dish.

Why a baking dish? Two reasons. First, you can stir in anything else you like and slide it back into the oven for a quick gratin under a snowy handful of grated hard cheese. Second, the glass dish slips neatly into the fridge — tightly covered — and reheats beautifully two days later, ready to serve with any sauce you love.

Roasted Eggplants with Pesto

The French and Italians have already done us the favor of inventing all the good sauces; there's rarely a need to go searching. Pesto, especially, asks for almost nothing: **fresh green basil, a handful of pine nuts, a squeeze of lemon juice, a hard cheese**, and a blender.

Pour that fragrant emerald sauce over the hot roasted eggplants, scatter **a fistful of pomegranate seeds** across the top, and take it straight to the table.

That's your side dish — bright, generous, equally at home beside fish or meat.

Eggplants Baked with Yesterday's Duck or Meat You Have Around

Remember how we once seared duck breast over fierce heat, slicing it into ribbons the Cantonese way? You can certainly use **leftover roast duck** for this, but scraps of chicken, pork, or even a bit of **good ham** from the fridge work just as well. Chop everything finely and fold it into a ceramic or glass baking dish together with **roasted eggplant** — half and half is the sweet spot.

Shower the top with grated cheese (*Gruyère* is wonderful here, though *Parmigiano* or *Grana Padano* are just as happy), and slide the dish into a 425°F (218°C) oven for about twenty minutes. What comes out is a bubbling, savory tumble of vegetables and meat that you can serve entirely on its own — preferably with a warm loaf of bread and something green and simple on the side.

*A bottle of **Petite Sirah** from Field Stone Winery in Alexander Valley is perfect here. They make beautiful red wines in that corner of Sonoma — the valley is small, quiet, and impossibly pretty, tucked just north of bustling Napa. If you ever find yourself there with a free afternoon, stop by the vineyard for a little picnic. A chilled glass*

dish of roasted eggplants and a heel of fresh bread will feel perfectly at home under those old oak trees.

Eggplant Croquettes

Scoop **600 g of roasted eggplant** into a large bowl. Add **300 g of boiled potatoes** mashed with a fork, **2 beaten eggs**, **150 g of grated hard cheese**, a teaspoon of mild curry, and half a teaspoon of salt. Work everything together with a fork until the mixture becomes cohesive and pleasantly sticky — something that remembers its shape when you touch it.

Divide the mixture into four portions and roll each one into a small log about an inch thick. Dust the logs with breadcrumbs (or flour, if that's what's on hand), set them in a shallow dish, and let them rest in the refrigerator for about an hour, just long enough to firm up. Then slice each log into short pieces — five centimeters or so — the little croquettes you'll be frying.

Pour a good **1.5 centimeters of vegetable oil** into a wide skillet and warm it over medium heat. Fry the croquettes in small batches, giving them space so they don't bump into each other and steam. Turn them now and then until every side takes on a deep golden color — about 4–5 minutes per batch. Lay them out on paper towels to drain, and serve immediately with meat or fish, when their insides are still warm and soft.

Make an aioli sauce to go with them:

Heat the oven to 340°F (170°C). Place **7–8 cloves of garlic** on a sheet of foil, drizzle with olive oil, sprinkle with salt, and wrap tightly — no leaks. Bake for 30–35 minutes until the garlic collapses into a fragrant, golden paste.

Mash the warm garlic with a fork. In a bowl or blender, combine **1 warm egg yolk**, the roasted garlic, **a scant tablespoon of apple cider vinegar**, and **½ teaspoon Dijon mustard**. Begin whisking, and slowly stream in **80 ml of olive oil** mixed with **50 ml of clarified sunflower oil** (or any neutral oil). Keep whisking until the aioli thickens into a silky, spoonable sauce.

Serve it beside the croquettes — they're made for each other.

Eggplant Spread (*Baklazhannaya Ikra*)

Take **5 kilograms of eggplants** — five or six large ones, or a dozen small — prick each with a fork or thin knife, and roast them on a foil-lined sheet for 45–50 minutes at 500°F (260°C). Let them cool, then slit each one lengthwise and scoop out the soft flesh, leaving behind any charred skin.

In your largest skillet or a steel wok, sauté **3–4 chopped onions** and **5–10 cloves of garlic** in vegetable oil until they soften and turn golden. A handful of finely diced carrot is perfectly

welcome here. Add **1–2 tablespoons of mild curry** and stir until the spices perfume the kitchen.

Now fold in the roasted eggplant. Pour in **half a cup of Marsala**, then — if you like a deeper, richer spread — add **one or two cans of tomato paste** (Italian or Californian) and a **cup of dry white wine**. Let everything simmer gently for about 30 minutes, stirring so nothing sticks; add a splash of wine if the mixture begins to catch.

At the very end, stir in a **cup of pitted black olives** and a **cup of cilantro leaves**, washed of every grain of sand and finely chopped. Salt, a little sugar if needed — and that's it. Serve warm or at room temperature, with bread, lamb, roasted fish, or all by itself on a quiet afternoon.

Babaganoush

Take **four large eggplants** and prick their skins with a fork or the tip of a small knife. Roast them on a foil-lined sheet for 40–50 minutes at 500°F (260°C), until they slump softly under their own weight. Let them cool, then split each one lengthwise and scoop out the silky flesh, leaving behind any charred skin.

Warm a little vegetable oil in a skillet and sauté **two finely chopped white onions** with **half a dozen peeled garlic cloves** until they turn golden and fragrant. Stir this into the eggplant. Add a **couple of tablespoons of tahini** and **about half a cup of lemon juice**.

And if you open the pantry and discover there's no tahini at all — don't worry. A tablespoon of toasted sesame oil and a cup of frozen walnuts blitzed in the food processor will take you to a perfectly delicious place.

Give the mixture a few pulses with an immersion blender, salt it to taste, and chill it well. Serve your *babaganoush* cold, showered with pomegranate seeds and accompanied by fresh bread. It will be very, very good.

Sichuan Yuxiang Eggplants

Take **five slender Chinese eggplants**, trim off the stems, and slice each one into finger-length pieces, then into long wedges. Scatter them over a wide plate.

Prepare a steamer: pour a little water into a wok, place a metal rack at the bottom, set the plate of eggplants on top, and cover. Steam over high heat for about 15 minutes, until a fork slips into them without resistance.

In another wok, warm **5–6 tablespoons of vegetable oil** and sauté chopped garlic and ginger just until they release their aroma. Add **shredded shiitake mushrooms** and cook for 5–7 minutes, then add **sliced leek** and give it another few minutes until everything softens and sweetens.

When the vegetables are ready, pour in the sauce (recipe below), bring it to a simmer, and slide in the steamed eggplants. Increase the heat, toss everything together, and let the eggplants braise in the sauce for 3–5 minutes, until they drink it in and turn glossy. Finish with a **generous drizzle of sesame oil**.

These Sichuan eggplants are wonderful alongside chicken fried in a crisp batter — or simply with a bowl of rice.

You'll need:

- Chinese eggplants (5 pcs, about 1 kg)
- Fresh shiitake mushrooms (6–8)
- Leek (2 stalks, washed well; use only the white part)
- Ginger (2–3 cm, minced)
- Garlic (2–3 cloves, minced)
- Vegetable oil (5–6 tbsp)
- Sesame oil (2 tbsp)

Sauce:

- Oyster sauce (4 tbsp)
- Soy sauce (6 tbsp)
- Apple cider vinegar (5%, 4 tbsp)
- Brown cane sugar (6 tbsp)
- Cornstarch (1 tbsp)
- Marsala or sherry (4 tbsp)

Potatoes

Potatoes are the quiet workhorses of the kitchen — unassuming, earth-covered, never in a hurry to impress. They sit patiently in a basket or a paper bag, waiting for the moment when you'll remember how miraculous they really are. No other vegetable transforms quite the way a potato does: from something dense and chalky into clouds, into crisp golden shards, into creamy layers that melt into one another like pages of an old book.

For centuries, these knobby roots carried entire families through winters. They fed farmers and travelers, children and soldiers; they fed the tired and the hopeful. In many parts of the world, a pan of good potatoes still feels like the closest thing to home — warm, fragrant, steadying.

This chapter is devoted to those small miracles: the potatoes that roast in duck fat until they crackle, the gratins that perfume the whole kitchen, the humble slices that turn, under a hot oven, into something elegant and comforting at once. Simple food, honest food — the kind that asks only a little care and gives back much more than you expect.

Remember how, back at the very beginning, we talked about frying potatoes quickly and well? If you happen to have roasted a duck recently — and have a little of that precious fat left with roasting juices — you can make a tray of truly magnificent roast potatoes.

Roast Potatoes in Duck Fat & Juices

Peel **2–3 kilos of good, starchy potatoes** and cut them into even pieces — halves or quarters, so they cook at the same pace. Spread them out in a wide, nonstick baking tray (or in a greased ceramic or glass roasting dish) and pour over the rendered duck fat and roasting juices. Salt generously — about a tablespoon over the whole tray — and slide everything into a 450°F (232°C) oven. Let the heat do its work for 45–60 minutes.

Near the end, if you want a deeper, crackling crust, switch the oven to broil for the last 10 minutes. What you'll pull out of the oven will be potatoes that are cloud-light inside and shatteringly crisp on the edges — the kind you can eat straight off the tray while pretending to “check seasoning.”

Gratin Dauphinois

Here's another potato dish — slower, more patient, but utterly reliable. It comes from *Elena Chekalova*, who once wrote a wonderful book on food with her husband, *Leonid Parfyonov*.

While your oven warms to 400°F (204°C), make the sauce: stir together heavy cream, the leaves of fresh thyme, a little rosemary, a whisper of sage, and finely chopped garlic. Add **⅔ cup of grated Gruyère**, then season with salt and pepper.

Now for the potatoes. Choose them big and long, if you can. Wash them, peel them quickly, and slice them into thin rounds — ideally on a mandoline, though a very sharp knife will do in a pinch. Work fast. You want to avoid plunging the slices into water; they must keep their starch, which is what gives the gratin its tenderness and cohesion.

Pour half of the cream-and-cheese mixture over the slices and toss gently. Then, working with small handfuls at a time, stand the slices upright in a glass baking dish as if you were stacking a deck of cards. They should be packed tightly, shoulder to shoulder. When the dish is full, pour in the remaining cream mixture so it rises just above the midpoint of the potato “columns.”

Seal the dish snugly with foil and bake for 45 minutes. Remove the foil and bake for another 40 minutes. Finally, scatter the remaining cheese on top, raise the oven temperature to 465°F (240°C), and let a golden-brown crust form — another 15 minutes or so.

When you set this gratin on the table, the whole room will smell like winter comfort: warm cream, melting cheese, soft garlic, and the herbal breath of thyme and rosemary. It's the kind of dish that anchors a meal — or quietly steals the show.

For the gratin dauphinois:

- Heavy cream (500 ml)
- Thyme, sage, rosemary
- Garlic (6–7 cloves)
- A melting cheese such as Gruyère (200 g)
- Large potatoes (2 kg)
- Olive oil
- Salt and pepper

Segovia Salad with Roasted Beet

I know, I know — you're probably not the kind of person who eats roasted beets on purpose. Still, let me leave you with this little treasure of a recipe: a cold Jewish salad that has rescued many a reluctant beet-eater.

Heat the oven to 340°F (170°C). Set **3–4 cloves of garlic** on a square of aluminum foil, drizzle them with a touch of oil, and scatter a pinch of salt over the top. Wrap the foil tightly so the garlic steams in its own perfume without losing a drop, and slide the packet into the oven for 30–35 minutes, until the cloves collapse into softness.

Now take **4–5 firm medium beets**, leave the skins on, wrap each one in a double layer of foil, and tuck them into the same oven for about an hour — maybe a little longer. When a knife slips in without hesitation, they're ready. Let them cool, peel off their jackets, and grate them on the large holes of a box grater.

Mash the roasted garlic with a fork and stir it into the beets. Chop a **cup of prunes** into small, dark jewels and fold them in as well. In a blender, pulse **a cup of frozen walnuts** until they resemble coarse crumbs, and add them to the bowl. Follow with **half a cup of finely chopped cilantro or parsley leaves**, bright and sharp.

Finish the salad with **2–3 tablespoons of good mayonnaise**, just enough to bind everything into a deep, earthy, sweet-savory tangle.

It's humble, nostalgic, and unexpectedly elegant — the kind of dish that tastes like someone cared.

Homemade Pizza

Let's get one thing out of the way first: a regular home oven will never give you a truly well-charred, well-blistered pizza — not the kind you remember from Naples or Brooklyn. It simply can't reach the ferocious heat needed to crisp the bottom in minutes. So, what are we supposed to do?

There *is* a way. What you need is a trick that lets you store a great deal of heat in a very small space — the same principle that makes a battery hold electricity or a capacitor release a spark in an instant. That stored heat must then be delivered, fast and clean, straight into a thin sheet of dough. In other words, you want the bottom of your pizza to go from raw to golden in about five to seven minutes.

The tool that solves this is a thick slab of steel — a baking stone masquerading as metal. Set it in the oven an hour before you plan to bake. Once heated, the steel behaves like a reservoir of energy (iron, as you know, has an astonishing heat capacity): it hoards every degree you give it and hands it back to your delicate pizza crust in an eager rush.

Where do you get such a slab? From Amazon, of course. Look for the **NerdChef Steel Stone — High Performance Pizza Baking**, size **15" × 16"**, and choose a thickness between **0.375" and 0.5"**. A couple of large stainless-steel pots (10–15 liters) and this steel “baking stone” are, honestly, the two best investments you can make for a home kitchen. They pay for themselves every weekend.

Pizza Dough

In the morning, stir **20–30 g** (2–3 tablespoons) of **fresh or dry yeast** into **300 ml** of warm water 100°F (38°C). Add **50 g** of sugar and let the mixture sit somewhere warm for 10–20 minutes, until it wakes up and begins to foam. This is your insurance policy — proof the yeast survived storage. If your kitchen is chilly, you can warm the oven slightly to 100°F (38°C) and let the bowl sit inside. Just be careful: at 125°F (52°C) the yeast dies, and then nothing will rise.

Into an 8–10-liter stainless-steel pot, pour **2.5 kilograms** of flour — ideally a high-protein, finely milled Italian flour like **Caputo “00”**. But don't worry: if you're baking on a preheated steel plate, even ordinary flour will behave beautifully. Add **1.5 liters** of warm water along with the yeast mixture and begin to knead. The dough will seem too wet, sticky, unruly — ignore this feeling and keep going. After 15–20 minutes it will become smooth enough to handle. Cover the pot and leave it in a warm place for a couple of hours. During this time, the yeast will nibble on simple sugars, breathe out carbon dioxide, and begin building the gluten that gives pizza its structure. Don't add salt or oil yet — they slow the yeast down.

When the dough triples or doubles in volume (that's the CO₂ at work), add **50 g** of olive oil and **40 g** of salt. Knead again to distribute everything evenly. Cover and let the dough rest

for another 30 minutes. What you now have is a very loose *poolish-style* dough — lively, glossy, and full of bubbles.

Dust your work surface generously with flour, tip out the dough, and divide it into three or four pieces. Stretch each piece gently, fold the edges toward the center, and shape it into a tight ball. This second rise will deepen the flavor as the yeast continues breaking down starches and sugars.

Transfer each ball into an oiled plastic container with a lid. A dough ball should fill only a third of the container — it needs room to grow.

- One ball — the one you'll bake tonight — can stay on the counter.
- Another should rest at room temperature for four hours before spending the night in the refrigerator; it'll make a wonderful pizza tomorrow.
- The remaining balls can go straight into the freezer, ready for some future evening when you need something easy and triumphant.

Assembling the Pizza

Start by rolling that soft dough into a thin sheet — it won't need much coaxing. Tear off a piece about the size of your fist, gently flatten it with your palms, then ease it outward with a wooden rolling pin until it becomes a pale, elastic disk. Lift the dough onto the rolling pin like a ribbon and unroll it onto a wide pizza peel lined with a sheet of foil cut to fit your steel baking plate.

Brush the surface with a tablespoon or so of olive oil. Spread on half a cup of tomato passata — or marinara with anchovies, if you're in that kind of mood — and scatter thin slices of salami over the top. Or shave gorgonzola directly onto the dough with a handful of black olives; or go full *quattro formaggi* with four cheeses melting into each other. *Prosciutto crudo* belongs on top only after the pizza comes out of the oven — it wilts gorgeously on its own heat. As for the rest of the toppings, I trust you'll improvise just fine.

While you're rolling and dressing the dough, crank the oven — with the steel slab in place — **to its absolute maximum**, 500°F (260°C), and let it run that way for at least an hour. The steel needs time to hoard every last watt of heat.

Let the shaped pizza rest — truly rest — for 10 to 15 minutes before it goes anywhere near the oven. This pause is not idle time; it's the quiet moment when the yeast wakes up again, stretching its limbs, taking a few delighted breaths, and filling the raw pizza crust with tiny bubbles of carbon dioxide. That brief second rise is what makes the baked crust airy, blistered, and alive rather than dense and sulking.

When the dough has visibly relaxed and looks just a little puffier, you're ready. Use a proper pizza peel — or even a stiff sheet of thick cardboard — to slide the pizza, still sitting on its square of heavy-duty foil, straight onto the blazing-hot slab of steel. Let it bake for six or

seven minutes, just until the rim freckles, the underside crisps, and the whole thing takes on that irresistible bronzed edge.

Lift the pizza back out with the peel, set it on a wooden board, and cut it into generous wedges while it's still singing with heat.

Below, in the *Addendum*, I've included a classic recipe from chef *Ken Forkish* himself — if only to keep his precise, elegant instructions on baking dough from getting lost in translation as these pages travel from one language to another.

Important: Always begin preheating the oven with the steel baking plate **about an hour** before you plan to bake.

Big Pies

Rich, comforting pies are what you bake when the whole family gathers — or when children and grandchildren come tumbling through the door. Don't ask why. That's simply how it's always been — the way my grandmother Sima and my great-grandmother Polya did it before her.

On those crowded days, when winter pressed against the windows and food was scarce (in the victorious socialist motherland it was mysteriously, perpetually hungry), the warm, yeasty smell of pies filled every corner of our enormous apartment — a swallow's nest tucked into the cliff-face of a Stalin-era house built by German prisoners of war along the Yauza River in Moscow.

That aroma — buttery dough, baked crust, a whisper of sweetness — was sometimes the only thing that held the whole family afloat through difficult times. And now, with a heavy slab of baking steel living permanently in your oven, this is the perfect moment to try a couple of Georgian recipes or bake a grand, cloud-light cabbage pie.

You'll do beautifully. I promise!

The Simplest *Mingrelian Khachapuri*

If your home is chilly, start by warming the oven for five minutes on the lowest heat. In a wide plastic bowl — something roomy enough for kneading — pour in warm water and stir in the sugar and yeast. Mix well and slide the bowl into the warm oven, then turn the heat off. Within half an hour the surface should be bubbling gently: the yeast has awakened and begun to eat.

Leave them undisturbed — yeast hates salt and oil at this stage — let them feast in peace. Once the mixture begins to whisper and froth, add the flour, the salt, and the oil. Now you can make dough. Knead for about five minutes: it should be soft, a little sticky, pliant rather than stiff. If it feels too loose, add just a touch more flour.

Oil the inside of the bowl, place the dough inside, cover it with plastic wrap, and set it somewhere warm. After a couple of hours, it will rise generously, the yeast busily transforming starch into tiny pockets of carbon dioxide. Turn the dough out onto a floured surface and knead it for another two or three minutes until it becomes smooth, elastic, and slightly glossy. Roll it out into a one-centimeter-thick round.

Now, the filling. Grate the cheese and pile it right in the center of the dough. Fold the edges toward the middle to form a soft, compact pouch with the cheese sealed inside. Gently roll this bundle out again with a rolling pin, and use your finger to open a small vent in the center — about the width of a fingertip. Steam must escape freely; otherwise the khachapuri will steam from within instead of baking.

Next, beat the eggs and brush the entire surface with a pastry brush. And please — give it a 15–20 minute rest before baking! The yeast needs this time to wake up again after being rolled and stretched, to rebuild those airy gas pockets that make the crust puff and lift in the oven.

Heat the oven with the baking steel inside to 500°F (260°C). It will take about an hour to reach full strength. Place the khachapuri on a wide peel lined with foil, and slide the foil directly onto the blazing steel. Immediately lower the temperature to 425°F (218°C).

After about twenty minutes, when the surface turns a deep golden brown, lift it from the oven, cover it with a paper towel, let it rest for ten minutes, and cut it into wedges.

For the dough and filling you'll need:

- 400 g all-purpose flour
- 2 teaspoons sugar
- 2 teaspoons active dry yeast
- 1 teaspoon fine salt
- 1 tablespoon neutral vegetable oil
- 300 ml warm water

For the cheese and glaze:

- 400 g *Sulguni* or young *Imeretian* cheese (in California, a good *Gouda* or mild sheep's feta will do just fine)
- 3 eggs (2 for the dough and filling if you like, 1 for brushing the top)

Small Svanetian Khachapuri, No Yeast Required — a Family Recipe from Editor Olga Grinkrug

This recipe traveled all the way from Tbilisi tucked into a family notebook, the way heirlooms often do — quietly, stubbornly, with the scent of warm kitchens clinging to its pages. It begins, as many Georgian recipes do, with brined cheese softened in a bath of boiling water. You let it sit for half an hour until its saltiness relaxes, then drain it off like a sigh. Here in California, you don't need to fuss quite so much. Brined cheeses can be hard to find, so simply mix 300 grams of a soft cheese — *Bulgarian sheep's feta* or *ricotta* work beautifully — with another 300 grams of a firm or semi-firm cheese, grated on the large holes of a box grater (*Pecorino Romano* or *Gouda* are ideal). If the cheeses aren't particularly salty, skip the soaking altogether and move right along.

Now to the dough. Rub the flour together with softened butter until the two turn into soft, sandy crumbs. Add the sugar, pour in a cup of sour cream or *Georgian matsoni*, and nestle half a teaspoon of baking soda right on top. Drizzle vinegar over the soda and watch it

bloom into cheerful bubbles. One more good mix, and you'll have a tender, supple dough. Divide it into six pieces and roll each into a small, plump patty.

The filling is as simple as it is generous: grate your soft and firm cheeses into a bowl, crack in a raw egg, and mix until everything binds. Add finely chopped herbs and a tablespoon of a mild curry blend — in the original recipe, of course, it would be the classic *Georgian khmeli-suneli*. Once everything is evenly combined, divide the filling into six portions (even if only in your mind).

Warm the oven to a comfortable 400°F (204°C) and dust both your counter and baking sheet with flour. Take one piece of dough and roll it into a thick, friendly-looking disc. Spoon a portion of filling into the center and fold the dough up around it, sealing it like an envelope. What you'll have is a slightly lopsided, utterly charming parcel. Turn it seam-side down onto the floured baking sheet. Repeat five more times, enjoying the small rhythm of assembly.

After 25–30 minutes in the oven, when the tops glow a deep golden brown, pull the tray out, drape the pastries with a paper towel, and give them a moment to settle. Slice each one open and let the steam escape. They are wonderful with a simple Iranian cucumber salad — though truthfully, these khachapuri are just as delightful cold and will keep at room temperature for up to three days.

For the dough:

- 200 g unsalted butter, softened
- 200 ml sour cream or *matsoni*
- ½ teaspoon baking soda
- ½ tablespoon apple cider vinegar (5%)
- 2–3 tablespoons sugar
- 2½ cups flour (380–400 g)

For the filling:

- 250–300 g brined cheese (or feta/ricotta mix)
- 250–300 g firm cheese (*Sulguni*, *Gouda*, *Pecorino*, etc.)
- 1 bunch green onions (green parts only)
- 1 large bunch cilantro, thoroughly washed
- 1 tablespoon mild curry blend
- 1 egg

Elena Chekalova's Khachapuri

Begin, as all good doughs begin, with waking the yeast. Stir a couple of teaspoons of dry yeast into a large glass of warm water (about 220 ml) with a tablespoon of sugar, and leave

it in a warm place for 10–15 minutes. When the surface froths and the mixture billows with tiny bubbles, you'll know the yeast has stretched its limbs and come back to life.

Now for the filling. Mash half a kilo of soft cheese — *Bulgarian sheep's feta*, *ricotta*, even *burrata* if you're feeling indulgent — together with an equal amount of firm cheese grated on the large holes of a box grater (*Pecorino Romano* or *Gruyère* are perfect here). Fold in two lightly beaten eggs. If thyme is growing on your windowsill, snip in a few leaves; if you have a pinch of Iranian saffron, by all means let it tint the mixture with its warmth.

While the cheeses quietly settle into one another, pour about four cups of flour into a wide plastic mixing bowl and rub it together with a softened chunk of butter until you have a fine, sandy crumble. Into this, pour the risen yeast mixture. A couple spoonfuls of sour cream won't hurt — if you have it, add it. Knead everything into a supple dough. It should pull cleanly from your hands yet still feel soft and gentle under your palms. If it clings, simply dust in a little more flour. Don't add salt: the cheeses will bring all the seasoning you need.

Cover the bowl with plastic wrap and leave the dough in a warm corner to rise. After an hour, it should be ready to work with. Turn it out onto a lightly floured surface and divide it into two uneven parts. Roll out the larger piece into a sheet about 3 mm thick — just big enough to drape over a medium baking tray. The second, smaller sheet will become the lid for your cheese pie.

Line your baking tray with foil, grease it generously, and lay the large sheet of dough inside, smoothing out any wrinkles. Spread the cheese filling in an even layer, cover it with the second sheet, and pinch the edges together. Using a knife, cut several long slits across the top — the steam must escape, or the interior will steam to softness instead of baking to tenderness. Brush the entire surface with lightly beaten egg. And now: let it rest for 15–20 minutes. This pause is essential — the yeast needs time to rebuild the tiny pockets of carbon dioxide that will lift the dough and give the baked crust its delicate, airy crumb.

Heat your oven, steel slab and all, to a roaring 500°F (260°C). It will take about an hour for the steel to store up enough heat. Set the tray directly onto the hot slab — it will crisp the bottom beautifully — then immediately lower the temperature to 425°F (218°C). After 25–30 minutes, when the top has bronzed and the kitchen smells unmistakably of butter and warm cheese, remove the tray. Drape the pie with a paper towel, let it rest for twenty minutes, and only then cut into it.

You will need:

- Flour (450 g)
- Warm water (220 ml)
- Sugar (1 tbsp)
- Dry yeast (2 tsp)
- Sour cream (2 tbsp)
- Unsalted butter (200 g, softened)

- Soft cheese (450–500 g — *Bulgarian sheep's feta, ricotta, burrata*)
- Firm cheese (450–500 g — *Pecorino Romano* or *Gruyère*)
- Eggs (4)

Tatyana Tolstaya's Cabbage Pie

Stir 800 g of flour with a tablespoon of salt. Take about 300 g of butter out of the fridge ahead of time; once it softens, slice it into the flour and work everything together with your hands until it turns into a fine, even crumble. In a large bowl, mix ½ liter of warm milk with sugar and dry yeast. Leave it in a warm place and check back in 20 minutes: the surface should be foamy and alive with bubbles. That's your sign — the yeast has woken up. Pour the warm yeast mixture into the flour and knead until the dough comes together; then leave it to rise for an hour or two in a warm corner.

Now, the cabbage. Shred a whole large head finely into a stainless-steel pot, sprinkle with a tablespoon of salt, and cover with boiling water. Let it sit for about ten minutes, then drain and squeeze out every bit of water hiding deep in the cabbage. Move it to a wide steel pan, add 50 ml of olive oil and 50 g of butter, and sauté over high heat for 10 minutes. Then pour in half a cup of milk and lower the heat. Cook another 20 minutes, adding more milk if needed, stirring often and salting lightly to taste. This is the heart of the pie, and what you're after is a creamy aroma and a kind of light, airy tenderness. When the cabbage is ready, take it off the heat and let it cool. Meanwhile, boil six eggs until firm, chill them quickly under cold water, peel, and chop — no need for precision here.

Once the dough has risen — it should be soft, loose, airy — turn it out onto a floured board and roll it into thin sheets. You can dust with more flour if you need to. Line a large baking sheet with foil, grease it well, and lay down the first sheet of dough. Spread the stewed cabbage and chopped eggs evenly over the surface. Cover with the second sheet and seal the edges tightly. Cut a dozen slits across the top: the filling needs to breathe, and the steam must escape so the dough bakes rather than steams from within. Brush the entire surface with two lightly beaten eggs, and let the pie rest for 20–30 minutes before it goes into the oven — the yeast needs time to rebuild its network of tiny gas-filled pockets after rolling. The longer the rest, the loftier the pie.

Heat your oven, with its heavy steel slab inside, to 500°F (260°C); it'll take about an hour to get there. Set the baking sheet directly onto the hot steel — it will brown the bottom beautifully — and immediately lower the oven temperature to 400°F (205°C). After 30 minutes, when the top is richly golden, pull out the tray, cover the pie with a paper towel, and let it sit for 20 minutes. Then slice away.

You will need:

- Flour (800–900 g)
- Sugar (3 tbsp)

- Dry yeast (3 tsp)
- Salt (1½ tbsp)
- Olive oil (50 ml)
- Butter (350 g total)
- Milk (500–600 ml)
- Eggs (6–8)
- A large head of firm white cabbage

Three-Onion Pie — with Chinese Chives, White Onions, and Leeks

Start by setting the dough. Stir the flour together with a half-tablespoon of salt, a spoonful of sugar, and a measure of dry yeast. Work 250 grams of soft, room-temperature butter into this dry mix with your hands until it resembles coarse crumbs or beach sand. Pour in 250 milliliters of milk, bring everything together into a dough, and leave it in a warm corner for an hour to rise into something light and pillowy.

Now for the filling. Finely chop the white onions and slowly sauté them over low heat in a nonstick pan with 50 milliliters of olive oil and 50 grams of butter, stirring all the while. When they turn gold, add the sliced leeks — the pale, tender lower half of the stalk — and let them soften for another five minutes. Only then is it time for the Chinese chives (garlic chives): the green tops only, sliced thinly. They need just five minutes of gentle heat. Take the pan off the stove, salt to taste, transfer the mixture to a ceramic bowl, and let it cool. Squeeze out every bit of liquid hiding in the onions; the filling must be dry, not weeping.

Meanwhile, boil six eggs until firm, cool them quickly under cold water, peel, and chop them roughly — they don't need to be dainty.

When the dough has risen into a loose, airy mass, tip it onto a floured table, divide it in half, and roll each half into a thin sheet; dust with more flour if it helps. Line a large baking sheet with foil, brush the foil with oil, and lay down the first sheet of dough. Spread the onion mixture and the chopped eggs evenly over it. Cover with the second sheet and seal the edges well. Cut a dozen slits across the top so the filling can breathe—steam must escape freely, or the dough will steam instead of bake. Finally, brush the entire surface with a couple of lightly beaten eggs. And let the pie rest 15–20 minutes before it goes into the oven: the yeast needs time, after all the rolling and pressing, to rebuild its network of bubbles inside the dough. That rest is what makes the crust light and alive.

Heat the oven with a heavy steel slab inside to 500°F (260°C) — it will take about an hour to saturate the steel with heat. Slide the sheet pan onto the steel and immediately drop the oven temperature to 400°F (205°C). The slab's enormous heat capacity will bake the bottom evenly and beautifully. After 30 minutes, when the top is deeply golden, pull out the pie, cover it loosely with a paper towel, give it twenty minutes to settle — then cut and serve.

You'll need:

- Flour (500 g)
- Sugar (2 tbsp)
- Dry yeast (2 tsp)
- Salt (1 tbsp)
- Olive oil (50 ml)
- Butter (300 g)
- Milk (400 ml)
- Eggs (9)
- White onions (2–3)
- Leeks (2–3 cleaned stalks)
- Garlic chives (about 500 g — easy to find at Koreana Plaza or Ranch 99)

Russian Blini with Caviar and Salmon

What are *Russian blini* for, when you think about it? They exist for that single perfect moment when you drape them with red caviar or lay a silken slice of salmon across their warm, butter-blushed surface. That alone justifies all the whisking, ladling, sizzling, and flipping. Of course, you *could* adorn them with black caviar, but I come from a humble family — and in any case, red caviar has always struck me as the more cheerful pleasure.

Most people remember blini only once a year, when Maslenitsa arrives — that ancient Slavic holiday which somehow, against all odds, preserved shards of pagan myth inside an Orthodox calendar. It appears in the final week before Lent, just as winter begins to loosen its grip and the year tilts toward light again. In the West, blini traditionally refers to small savory pancakes made with leavened batter. I've gathered for you three venerable recipes, each inherited from kind cooks who shared them generously. Personally, I find blini a little weighty — but tastes differ, and perhaps they'll win your heart. And right here, beside them, I've added two dependable ways to prepare salmon to serve alongside. The overnight cure is a small miracle you'll return to often. As for caviar — you're on your own. Try *Koreana Plaza*; talk to the clerks, look in the Japanese freezer or on the Russian shelves. Alaskan red caviar is excellent, too.

And if you're wondering what Maslenitsa (*Butter Week*) *really* is — and how blini ended up as its edible emblem — I can't claim full mastery of every historical bend and loop. But the clearest, most enchanting explanation I know is the feast scene in *Nikita Mikhalkov's* fairytale film *The Barber of Siberia*. Watch it, and you'll feel the whole story unfold without a single footnote.

Two Overnight Cures for Salmon

Take a whole salmon and break it down into two fillets. First, remove the head; lay the body on its side and, with a thin sharp knife, slide the fillet off the backbone. Use tweezers to pull any remaining pin bones, and trim off the belly flap. Leave the skin on. Discard the gills. The head, backbone, tail, and trimmings can go straight into a freezer bag — they'll wait patiently for your next fish broth.

Of course, you can simply buy a beautifully trimmed, properly thawed, skin-on fillet at Costco. Either way, weigh the fish — this matters for the curing ratios — and cut it into pieces about the size of your palm.

Salt-Cured Salmon

For every kilogram of salmon, you'll need one tablespoon of salt (about 25 g) and one tablespoon of sugar (about 20 g). Stir the salt and sugar together in a small bowl, then pour in a shot of vodka or cognac. The mixture will resemble a drift of thawing spring snow. If you like, shave in a little lemon zest or chopped dill — or even add a splash of pomegranate juice — though none of that is essential.

Lay the salmon pieces skin-side down in a wide glass container with a tight lid, and cover the fish evenly with the curing mixture. Seal the container and refrigerate for 12 hours. In the morning, blot off any moisture and excess salt with paper towels, remove the skin, slice neatly, and arrange everything on a festive Japanese plate.

Soy-Cured Salmon

For every kilogram of salmon, you'll need 100 ml *Kikkoman* soy sauce, 100 g peeled fresh ginger, and one tablespoon of sugar (20 g). Blitz the soy sauce, ginger, and sugar briefly in a blender, pour the mixture into a bowl, and add a couple of tablespoons of vodka or cognac.

Lay the salmon pieces skin-side down in your curing container and coat them evenly with the mixture. Cover tightly and refrigerate for 12 hours. In the morning, blot dry, remove the skin, and slice the salmon thinly — just like sashimi.

Yeasted *Blini* by Elena Chekalova

Begin by gently warming a liter of milk — just enough to take off the chill — and dissolving the yeast in half of it. Add the salt and give it a slow stir. Melt the butter, separate the egg, and set the white aside for later. Now whisk half the flour into the warm yeasted milk, then add the melted butter and the yolk. Beat the mixture with a hand mixer until it's perfectly smooth, cover the bowl with a kitchen towel, and leave it in a warm corner for about an hour and a half. By then the batter should rise and loosen, doubling in size as if taking a long, contented breath.

Pour in the remaining warm milk, fold in the rest of the flour along with the sugar, and beat again — an immersion blender works beautifully here. In another bowl, whip the reserved egg white to soft peaks and gently fold it into the batter. Cover the bowl once more and give the yeast another hour and a half to wake up, stretch, and fill the batter with tiny bubbles of air. This patient double rise is what gives blini their tenderness and lift.

Heat a heavy nonstick skillet over high heat. Ladle in a small amount of batter and swirl it into the thinnest possible layer. Blini cook in a flash — just a few seconds on each side — so stay close. Stack them on a plate as they finish, brushing each warm blin with melted butter. The aroma alone will feel like a holiday.

You will need:

- All-purpose flour (3 cups)
- Milk (1 liter)
- Egg (1)
- Fresh yeast (20 g, or 2 tsp active dry yeast)
- Salt ($\frac{1}{2}$ tsp)
- Butter, melted (30 g)
- Sugar (2 tbsp)

- More melted butter for brushing the finished blini

Important: The batter needs roughly **3 hours of rising time** in total. Don't rush it — the yeast is doing the quiet, invisible work that makes blini so light.

Scalded Yeasted *Blini* by *Lidiya Raevskaya*

Warm about three cups of milk to a gentle 86–104°F (30–40°C) — just warm enough that your finger feels comfortable, not hot. In this milk, dissolve the fresh yeast and whisk in the flour. Add the *semolina* (a fine wheat groat that lends blini their delicate tenderness), along with the salt and sugar. Cover the bowl and set it somewhere warm for half an hour. The batter should swell to twice its size, maybe even more — rising in soft, buoyant waves.

Now add the eggs one at a time, beating thoroughly after each addition. Truly thoroughly: the more air the batter receives at this stage, the lighter and more lacy your blini will be. Pour in the oil — half a cup — and whisk again until the batter is smooth and lively.

Bring the remaining cup of milk to a boil (or, better yet, use light cream). Pour the *boiling* milk straight into the batter — no hesitation — and mix quickly and confidently. The heat will “scald” the mixture, waking up the semolina and giving the blini their signature elasticity. Let the batter rest for 15 minutes.

That's it. You'll be looking at a full pot of warm, bubbling foam — a living, breathing batter. This is what you'll ladle onto the pan. Use a heavy nonstick skillet if you can, and let it heat properly before you begin.

You will need:

- All-purpose flour (3 cups)
- Fine semolina (½ cup)
- Milk (1 liter total)
- Eggs (4)
- Fresh yeast (20 g, or 2 tsp active dry yeast)
- Salt (½ tsp)
- Sugar (2 tbsp)
- Vegetable oil (½ cup)
- Melted butter — for brushing the finished blini

Scalded *Blini à la Tatyana Tolstaya*

Crack two eggs into a bowl and whisk them into a light foam with a teaspoon of salt. Without stopping — truly, don't pause even for a heartbeat — pour in a full cup of boiling water. The foam will surge upward, tripling or quadrupling in volume; this magical transformation is exactly what “scalded eggs” means. Keep whisking, keep the mixture alive and aerated.

Now, while the mixer is still running, stream in a cup of cold milk. Follow it with a heaping cup of flour, letting the batter thicken and smooth out beneath the beaters. Once the flour has disappeared into the foam, pour in the vegetable oil. The batter will relax into a silky, pourable consistency — ready to turn into blini almost immediately.

You'll fry these pancakes right away, on a well-heated skillet brushed lightly with olive oil or melted butter. (The easiest way to grease the pan is still the old Russian trick: rub it with half a potato. But if you have a heavy nonstick pan, you may not need any extra fat at all — the batter carries its own.)

Ladle out each portion — not quite a full scoop — and you'll get twelve to fourteen thin, tender pancakes. They don't need sugar. Their charm lies in their simplicity.

You will need:

- Eggs (2)
- Boiling water (1 cup)
- Cold milk (1 cup)
- Flour (1 heaping cup)
- Salt (1 tsp)
- Vegetable oil (2 tbsp)
- Melted butter — for brushing the finished blini

French Mother Sauces, Pesto, *Coulis*, and Salsa

French sauces are, in a way, the grammar of Western cooking — the quiet set of rules that makes everything else legible. Once you learn how butter behaves in a warm pan, how flour transforms when it toasts, how an egg yolk thickens at the edge of a simmer, the whole kitchen begins to speak more clearly. A simple roast chicken becomes grand with a ladle of *velouté*; a heap of vegetables turns luxurious when cloaked in *Hollandaise*. And the beauty of it is that these “mother sauces” are less about rigid technique and more about noticing small transformations — the change of scent when *roux* darkens, the moment milk and butter surrender into silk, the way a sauce suddenly glosses when it comes together. Learn to recognize these signs, and you’ll never feel lost at the stove again.

All the great French sauces rest on a single idea: balance — of flavor, of texture, of richness and brightness.

- **Butter** brings the gentleness of milk fat together with a quiet note of umami.
- **Dijon mustard** lends controlled heat, along with a graceful balance of acid and sweetness.
- **Lemon juice and apple cider vinegar** are two faces of fruit-born acidity.
- **Raw egg yolk, stock, and roux** — that humble mixture of flour and butter toasted together — give a sauce its body, its depth, its warmth.

To combine these building blocks properly, you’ll need a small stainless-steel saucepan; a pot of gently simmering water, which we’ll respectfully call the *bain-marie* (it keeps your sauce from overheating); and a whisk. A hand blender helps too — it transforms a warm mixture into a silky, cloudlike emulsion.

Béchamel

You’ve already met *Béchamel* in our gratin pasta, in the baked cauliflower, and in *Veau Orloff*. It is one of the classic *mother sauces* of France, the starting point from which generations of cooks have devised clever and elaborate combinations. Its creator was the Marquis *Louis de Béchamel*, *maître d’hôtel* to King Louis XIV — a man who, apparently, had time to play with butter and milk between royal banquets.

In its purest form, *Béchamel* is defined by three things: a quiet, creamy flavor; the faint perfume of nutmeg; and a soft off-white color, somewhere between ivory and warm cream — the shade designers politely call *off-white*.

All white sauces are thickened with a mixture of raw egg yolk and *roux*. Making *roux* is mildly tedious, but not difficult at all once you get into the rhythm.

Set a clean, dry stainless-steel skillet or saucepan with a heavy bottom over medium heat and warm 2–3 tablespoons of all-purpose flour (about 30 g) until it smells faintly nutty. Add a generous piece of butter (50–70 g), press it into the bottom with a fork, and let the melting butter sweep the flour into an even, sandy paste — your *white roux*.

Once the flour dissolves into the butter, slowly pour in a couple of cups of cold milk or cream (300–400 ml), stirring constantly with a spatula. Bring the mixture to a gentle boil over medium heat. Add a pinch of salt and the smallest whisper of freshly grated nutmeg.

Keep stirring — do not stop now. After 5–10 minutes, the sauce will thicken into something between custard and thin sour cream. Remove it from the heat and cover so it doesn't form a skin. Even better, pour it into a wide glass bowl (*Pyrex* works beautifully); it will cool more evenly there. If you want to be especially careful, lay a few small curls of butter across the surface to keep it velvety and untouched by that dreaded film.

Mornay Sauce

Mornay is a close cousin of *Béchamel* — enriched with cheese and egg yolks, and beloved for the quick, golden finish it gives to cooked meats or delicate fish in the oven.

Let your freshly made *Béchamel* cool just slightly. Separate 3 eggs, and whisk the yolks into the warm sauce, taking care that they don't curdle.

The cheese comes later. First, arrange your cooked meat or gently poached fish in a glass baking dish and pour the sauce over the top. Slide the dish into an oven preheated to 400°F (205°C). Fifteen minutes will do.

Now shower everything generously with grated hard cheese (*Gruyère* or *Parmigiano* are ideal). Take the remaining egg whites and whisk them into a soft foam with a teaspoon of sugar. Spoon this airy mixture over the cheese and lightly fold together with a fork.

Turn on the broiler and, in just a few minutes, your meat or fish will emerge under a beautifully browned, cheese-and-meringue crust. It never fails.

White Velouté Sauce

Another of the French “mother sauces,” *velouté* is essentially *Béchamel's* maritime sibling — the same gentle thickening technique, but built on fish stock instead of milk.

Set a clean, dry steel skillet or heavy-bottomed saucepan over medium heat and warm 2–3 tablespoons of flour (about 30 g) just until it releases a faint nutty aroma. Add a lump of butter (50–70 g), press it into the flour with a fork, and stir briskly as it melts to form a smooth, pale *roux*.

As soon as the flour dissolves into the butter, begin adding cold fish stock (300–400 ml) in a slow stream, stirring constantly. Keep the motion steady and uninterrupted — it's the secret to a velvety sauce. Bring it to a gentle boil, season with salt, and let it thicken for 10–20 minutes until it reaches the consistency of pastry cream or loose sour cream.

Remove from heat, cover to prevent a skin from forming, and you'll have the perfect companion for almost any fish.

Saffron *Suprême* Sauce for *Pojarski* Cutlets and Fried Shrimp

In a saucepan, warm **300 ml of your mother-sauce velouté**, whisking steadily as it heats. Add **half a teaspoon of Dijon mustard** and **200 ml of Half & Half**. Crush a **pinch of saffron** between your fingers and rub it directly into the sauce, letting it bloom. Bring everything to a gentle simmer over low heat and let it cook for 3–5 minutes, stirring with a spatula.

Finish by whisking in about **30 g of butter**, and spoon the glossy saffron sauce over *Pojarski* cutlets, fried shrimp, or steamed asparagus just before serving.

Emulsion Sauces: Mayonnaise

Mayonnaise is born from warm egg yolks, lemon juice, and vegetable oil. The oil itself doesn't need to be fancy, but the yolks should be fresh — and gently warmed. Its elder sibling, *Hollandaise*, is made from hot yolks and melted butter; it belongs to the aristocracy of salad dressings and fish sauces. Their humble father, Spanish *aioli*, is built on the same principle of emulsified egg and oil, but somehow has fallen out of favor — perhaps because of its unapologetic garlic punch.

The foundation of all three is the same: a well-beaten *sabayon*, an emulsion of fat and the phospholipids that yolks contain in generous supply.

Start by whisking **two warm egg yolks** in a heated glass bowl with a **tablespoon of Dijon mustard** and a **quarter teaspoon of salt**. If you're out of mustard, half a tablespoon of 5% vinegar will do. Now begin adding **oil** — literally drop by drop — whisking each addition firmly into the yolks. Then another drop, and another...

Something remarkable happens in that bowl: the mixture thickens, expands, becomes almost buoyant. This is the *sabayon* (not to be confused with its sweet dessert namesake).

At this point, you can switch to an immersion blender and start adding more **oil (another 200–300 ml)** in a thin, steady stream until a stable, glossy emulsion forms. To finish, whisk in **2 tablespoons of lemon juice** (or vinegar, or even a splash of dry white wine). This touch of acidity keeps the sauce from separating in the refrigerator.

Hollandaise and the Art of Eggs Benedict

In a small saucepan, melt **200 g of butter** over the gentlest heat you can manage, letting it come just to a quiet boil. Skim off the foam. Pour the clarified butter into a bowl, leaving the milky sediment behind, and let it cool slightly — the pan itself should remain just warm to the touch.

Now set that pan over a very soft bain-marie: simply nestle it into a pot of hot water held around 140°F (60°C). Into this warm bath whisk **4 egg yolks** with a **tablespoon of water** and a **tablespoon of 5% apple cider vinegar**. Keep whisking — eight to ten minutes is

normal — until the yolks grow pale, thick, and billowy, swelling to two or even three times their original volume. The single iron rule: do not let the mixture climb above 149°F (65°C), or the yolks will harden and the spell will break. The temperature test is simple: the pan must never feel uncomfortably hot in your hand. If it does, lift it off the heat and keep whisking. Or use a thermometer with a metal probe for peace of mind.

Now for the magic. Begin adding the warm clarified butter, first drop by drop, then in tiny spoonfuls, whisking each addition deeply into the yolks before adding the next. Take your time — haste curdles *Hollandaise*. When all goes well, you'll feel the sauce transform into a glossy, custardy emulsion with the consistency of a loose mayonnaise. Season it with a **quarter teaspoon of salt** and a **tablespoon of lemon juice**, and the sauce is ready.

Hollandaise is glorious on white fish — sturgeon, halibut — and incomparable on poached eggs, which are far less intimidating to make than their reputation suggests. Those very eggs became the foundation of one of America's most beloved breakfasts: *Eggs Benedict*.

PS: A Poached Egg Benedict

Crack a fresh egg into a small cup, then gently slip it from the cup into a saucepan of lightly salted, barely simmering water. Some cooks add vinegar to encourage the white to set — perhaps it helps, perhaps not. What *is* certain is the timing: three minutes. No more, no less.

Lift the egg out with a slotted spoon, let the water drain onto a paper towel, and place it on a piece of toasted bread. Spoon warm *Hollandaise* over the top. If you like, slip in a couple of thin slices of your home-cured salmon beneath the egg — a small luxury that never fails.

Mediterranean Sauces

Mediterranean sauces are little sunlit miracles — born from herbs, oil, garlic, and patience. Pesto, aioli, salsa: each captures a fragment of coastline, a breath of warm wind, a memory of ripening fields. They aren't cooked so much as coaxed into being. Crush, whisk, taste — and suddenly you have a sauce that feels both ancient and alive. Spoon it over anything warm, and it brings a flash of summer to the table.

Spanish Aioli

This Spanish sauce is a close cousin of mayonnaise, but its character is entirely its own — bold, fragrant, and unabashedly garlicky.

Preheat the oven to 340°F (170°C). Lay **7–8 cloves of garlic** on a sheet of foil, drizzle them with **olive oil**, and dust with a **pinch of salt**. Wrap the foil tightly so that the garlic and oil are completely sealed inside — no leaks — and roast for 30–35 minutes, until the cloves turn soft as butter. When they're ready, scoop them out and mash them with a fork.

In a bowl or blender cup, combine **one warm egg yolk**, all the roasted garlic, a scant **tablespoon of apple cider vinegar**, and **half a teaspoon of Dijon mustard**. Whisk or blend this mixture until smooth, then begin adding **80 ml of olive oil** mixed with **50 ml of clarified sunflower (or any mild vegetable) oil** — first drop by drop, then in a thin, steady stream. Keep whisking without pause until the aioli thickens into a creamy, spoonable sauce. Stored in the refrigerator, it will keep happily for about a week.

Pesto Genovese

For a true pesto, blitz in a blender: **one cup of pine nuts**, **two cups of freshly washed green basil leaves**, and a **tablespoon of lemon juice** — the lemon helps the basil keep its bright green color and its perfume. Add a **cup of olive oil** and about **half a cup of Parmigiano**, cut into small chunks. Blend until the mixture becomes a velvety emerald paste. You can, of course, buy a perfectly decent jar of pesto at Costco. But if basil is nowhere to be found — or you simply want a different shade of green — you can assemble another excellent sauce using walnuts. In the blender, combine **two cups of washed cilantro leaves**, a **tablespoon of lemon juice**, a **cup of fresh walnuts**, a **cup of olive oil**, and a **chunk of hard cheese** (*Gruyère* or *Grana Padano* both work beautifully). Blitz until smooth. It's not Italian, exactly — but it is delicious, bright, and astonishingly versatile.

A Small Prelude to Coulis

A coulis is the quietest of sauces — a whisper rather than a proclamation. Born in the French kitchens of another century, it turns vegetables, herbs, and broths into something soft as breath and smooth as dusk. Nothing in a coulis shouts; everything flows. It is flavor in its most fluid form, meant not to dominate the dish but to surround it gently, the way light pools around a figure in a painting.

Pour it along the rim of a plate, let it drift toward the center, and watch how even a simple piece of fish or a slice of roasted lamb begins to look like it belongs to a finer world.

Leek Coulis for Fish

The French, who gifted the world most of classical European cooking, invented the coulis in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. The word comes from *couler* — “to flow” — and that is exactly what a true coulis does: it turns humble ingredients into a silken, slow-moving ribbon of flavor that flatters any firm fish or meat.

Take a **couple of thick white leek stalks** (about half a kilo), slice them lengthwise, rinse away every grain of sand, and cut them into fine half-moons. Melt **50 grams of butter** in a saucepan and let the leeks collapse gently over low heat for 10–15 minutes. Pour in **two cups of fish stock** and a **cup of heavy cream** (at least 33%), add a **few threads of saffron**, and let everything simmer softly for another 15–20 minutes, stirring from time to time. In

the end, blend it into a completely smooth, velvety sauce, adjust the salt, and ladle the hot coulis around the edges of the plates just before you nestle the fish into them.

Creamy *Coulis* of Celeriac or Fresh Green Peas

Lamb loves a creamy celeriac coulis at its side. Peel a **large celeriac (about half a kilo)**, cut it into cubes, and simmer it in a saucepan of boiling water until it surrenders and turns tender. Transfer it to a blender with a **cup of heavy cream** and purée into a satin-smooth mash. If the coulis seems too thick, a **knob of butter** or a splash more cream will coax it into the right silkiness. Season with **salt and pepper** and spoon it alongside the lamb.

If you crave a fresher, greener counterpoint to the richness of the meat, swap the celeriac for **half a kilo of young peas**. Drop them into boiling water for five minutes — just until they soften — then blend them with cream exactly as you would the celeriac. The result is a bright, springlike *coulis* that wakes the whole plate up.

Pineapple *Salsa* for Roast Beef

Start by peeling a **medium pineapple** and cutting out its tough central core. Dice the flesh into neat one-centimeter cubes. Rinse a generous **bunch of cilantro** in cold water, pluck only the leaves (the stems sit this one out), and chop them finely.

Set a nonstick skillet over medium heat and scatter in a **couple of tablespoons of brown sugar**. The moment it melts and begins to caramelize, tumble in the pineapple cubes and stir with a bamboo spatula until they're glossed and glistening, each piece lacquered in molten sugar.

Now add a **tablespoon of oyster sauce**, a **tablespoon of dark soy sauce**, the **chopped cilantro**, the **juice of half a lime**, and — if you like a bit of fire — a **whisper of chopped chili**. Let the salsa warm through for another minute. Spoon it over sliced roast beef and watch the whole plate brighten.

Sashimi Sauce

Pour about **half a centimeter of neutral oil** into a small skillet and warm it over medium heat. Add **5–6 centimeters of fresh ginger** (finely sliced), a **couple of chopped scallions**, one **bruised stalk of lemongrass** (give it a few taps with your kitchen mallet), **3–4 centimeters of galangal** if you happen to have it, and **one or two chili peppers** — slit them first if you prefer your food a little wild.

Let the spices quietly simmer in the oil for 10–15 minutes, just to the edge of a bare bubble. Remove from the heat, let it cool, and strain the fragrant oil into a small bowl, discarding the spent aromatics.

Now whisk in **20 ml of dark soy sauce (optional)**, **50 ml of regular soy sauce**, a **tablespoon of brown sugar**, and **two tablespoons of Marsala**. Cover the bowl and chill until serving time. Before pouring the sauce into tiny dipping dishes, give it a quick whisk to wake it up again.

Desserts

The ending of any meal should be tender and sweet, like a half-remembered dream — not loud enough to drown out the memory of the main story, but soft enough to nudge the table talk into a gentler key. I've never been a devotee of massive chocolate cakes with buttercream frosting or sugar-heavy pastries. With all due respect, they're as heavy as an aircraft carrier group leaving San Diego Bay to "*avenge the unreasonable Khazars.*"

What one longs for instead is something light — something that lifts rather than lands. So let's take a closer look at how to make a velvety English custard, that quiet miracle of yolks, milk, and heat. It pairs just as beautifully with almond pastries as it does with California peaches, giving you an easy summer dessert for tea or coffee — with hardly any sugar or fat, believe me.

And while we're lingering in this sweet corner of the kitchen, you'll also find a recipe for an exquisite sabayon of raw yolks, a golden cloud that flatters everything it touches: strawberries, raspberries, woodland berries. For good measure, order a *Panettone Galup*. This airy marvel has been baked in Turin (*Torino*) for generations — a festive companion to any dessert.

Crème Anglaise (Custard Cream)

In a metal or glass bowl (*Pyrex* works perfectly), whisk together the yolks, starch, sugar, and vanilla — by hand or with a mixer, whichever suits your mood. The mixture should thicken slightly, turning glossy and cohesive.

In a small saucepan, gently heat the milk and cream. The trick is to catch *exactly* the moment before it reaches a full boil: the surface will tremble with tiny ripples, like wind brushing a pond, but no bubbles yet. Got it? Quickly take the saucepan off the heat and pour it in a thin stream into the yolk mixture, whisking without pause. Soon you'll have a smooth, silky liquid with no lumps in sight.

Return the mixture to the saucepan and place it over the lowest heat possible. This is the delicate stage — custard is temperamental and prone to clumping if provoked. Stir constantly with a wooden spatula until it thickens, and never let it boil. Once the custard coats the spatula in a soft, velvety film, remove it from the heat immediately. Now it's ready.

You can serve the custard warm, or strain it through a fine-mesh sieve and let it rest in the refrigerator for a day or two. When the moment comes, pour it over washed strawberries or peeled, finely diced peaches. A few mint leaves on top, maybe a cinnamon stick or even a vanilla pod, and you have a dessert that tastes like summer learning to speak.

You'll need:

- Half & Half (200 ml)
- Milk (700 ml)

- Egg yolks, cleanly separated (4–5)
- Cornstarch or potato starch (3 tbsp)
- Sugar (100 g)
- Vanilla extract (1 tsp)

Sabayon with Wild Berries

Rinse the berries gently and lay them out to dry on paper towels before sending them into a glass bowl — they look their most spectacular in glass. Grate in a bit of citrus zest (on the finest side of the grater), being careful not to catch the bitter white pith. Add a couple of tablespoons of lemon or lime juice, toss everything lightly, and let the fruit rest and perfume itself.

Meanwhile, set up your bain-marie. Fill a saucepan with enough water to support a metal or Pyrex bowl securely on top — the bowl should perch there the way a tricorn hat sits on a general: resting on the rim, never touching the water. Warm the water to about 113°F (45°C).

Crack the eggs into a shallow dish and, using your hands, separate the yolks with care. Transfer the yolks to the bowl, sprinkle them with sugar, set the bowl over the warm steam, and begin whisking — with a mixer or a good steel whisk — until the mixture triples in volume, filled with tiny bubbles of air. Keep whisking as the bain-marie slowly heats; the water should never rise above 194°F (90°C). Over time the foam will tighten, the mixture will thicken, and the sabayon will begin to take shape.

Now pour in the white vermouth (*Martini & Rossi* is perfect) along with half a cup of citrus juice, and continue whisking. After about 8–10 minutes, you'll have a smooth, pudding-like cream. The sabayon is ready when it reaches 131°F (55°C). Turn off the heat and let it rest under a lid before folding it into the berries. A few mint leaves on top make the whole thing look like summer in a bowl.

You'll need:

- Raspberries (250 g)
- Blueberries (250 g)
- Orange and lime or lemon (1–2, for juice)
- Citrus zest (1 tsp)
- Eggs (6, scrub the shells with soapy water)
- Sugar (150–200 g)
- *Martini & Rossi* white vermouth (100–150 ml)
- Mint leaves, for garnish

Poached Pears in Red Wine

Begin with a shallow steel pot and a **liter of sweet Californian red** — the boxed kind that tastes like a half-forgotten summer and is far too cloying to drink on its own, unless you're nineteen and the night is young. Pour it in and let it darken the bottom of the pan like spilled velvet. With the tip of a knife, coax the seeds from a **vanilla bean** and let them fall into the wine like flecks of midnight. **Add two cinnamon sticks, a pair of star anise** — they look like tiny frozen fireworks — and a **good handful of sugar (100 g)**.

When the wine begins to murmur and roll toward a boil, slip in **6–8 firm pears**, peeled to their pale, moonlit flesh but still wearing their stems like little handles. Retrieve the spices for a moment (you will summon them again later) and lower the heat until the wine barely quivers. Let the pears drift and soften there for an hour and a half, maybe two — time bends a little in this ruby-colored fog. They should yield to the touch, but not surrender; poached fruit, like a good story, needs structure.

Lift the pears out with a slotted spoon and let them cool in a glass dish, gleaming like lanterns after rain. Return the spices to the pot and coax the remaining wine down to a glossy syrup. Strain it, let it breathe and cool.

To serve, stand each pear in the center of a cold plate, surround it with a few scoops of your favorite ice cream — snow at the foot of a crimson tower — and pour the dark, aromatic syrup over the top. The dessert arrives at the table looking like something from a winter tale: simple, luminous, and quietly unforgettable.

Peach Salad

Slip the skins off a few July or August peaches — the slightly bitter, late-summer kind, the ones that smell of hot grass and warm evenings. A brief dip in boiling water, and their jackets slide right off. Yellow varieties like Californian *Silk Road* work especially well here. Slice them into soft crescents.

Do the same with a couple of firm green apples — *Granny Smith*, crisp as early morning wind. Cut a small handful of prunes into tiny squares, slice a banana, rinse a cup of blueberries and let them dry on paper towels until they shine. Tumble everything into a glass bowl.

Now the dressing: pour in freshly squeezed grapefruit juice with its pulp (orange juice will do in a pinch), a spoonful or two of brown sugar, and a good glug of *plum infusion* — or simply a clean, honest vodka. Add two or three cinnamon sticks and a star of anise, that little perfumed compass rose. Give the bowl a gentle stir, cover with plastic wrap, and let the fruit rest in the refrigerator for a couple of hours, soaking quietly in its own fragrant summer.

Just before serving, scatter a few leaves of chocolate mint across the top. They'll perfume the air before the spoon even touches the fruit.

You'll need:

- Bitterish, yellow California peaches (800 g)
- Firm green apples (like Granny Smith, 200 g)
- Prunes (50 g)
- Banana (1)
- Blueberries (200 g)
- Freshly squeezed grapefruit juice (1 cup, you can swap in orange juice)
- Brown sugar (2 tbsp)
- Strong plum liqueur, or just good vodka (½ cup, 100 ml)
- Cinnamon sticks (2)
- Star anise (1 whole star)
- Chocolate mint leaves (5–6, for garnish)

Almond Cakes (*Macarons de Saint-Émilion*)

Begin by setting up a gentle *bain-marie*: fill a saucepan with water — wide enough for a metal or *Pyrex* bowl to perch on top without touching the water — and warm it to about 113°F (45°C). While the water heats, set your oven to 360°F (182°C).

Crack 3 eggs into a small bowl and carefully separate the whites from the yolks with your hands. Tip the whites into the warm bowl, scatter in the sugar, set the bowl over the *bain-marie*, and whisk — patiently, steadily — until the mixture thickens and doubles in volume, turning glossy as it fills with air. Fold in the almond flour, mix well, and let the batter rest over the warm water for about half an hour.

A purist French recipe would stop right here, but I'd still nudge you to add 2 tablespoons of all-purpose flour and half a teaspoon of baking powder. It's a small heresy, but it makes the cakes lighter and more buoyant.

Spoon the soft batter onto a sheet of oiled parchment (*culinary parchment*) or onto silicone baking mats, forming small rounds. Slide the tray into the oven for 15–20 minutes — your oven has been waiting, thoroughly preheated.

You'll need:

- Almond flour (1½ cups, 150 g)
- Sugar (1 cup, 175 g)
- Egg whites (from 3 eggs)
- Flour (2 tbsp, 30 g)
- Baking powder (½ tsp)

Homemade Infusions

In summer, when the heat wavers over the Central Valley like a mirage and the branches in our orchard bow under the weight of plums, apricots, and cherries, a quiet instinct awakens — the old, human desire to trap sunlight in a bottle. To stitch a little warmth into the fabric of the coming winter, when low clouds graze the Contra Costa hills and the rain drums its soft, persistent rhythm on the roof.

So you begin simply: take a clean stainless-steel pot — ten, maybe fifteen liters, one of those that looks as if it could outlive the house — and tumble in a third of its volume in ripe, washed plums. Then pour over them a generous tide of good French vodka from Costco. Let the fruit disappear under the clear surface like swimmers beneath a cold lake. Close the lid. Hide the whole thing for a couple of days. And do not, under any circumstances, throw out those bulky vodka bottles — their second life is yet ahead of them.

But what is *good* vodka, anyway? And why is one bottle merely liquor and another a kind of transparency, a clean windowpane of a drink? The answer lies in the purity of the spirit itself — in the slow, meticulous choreography of distillation. Alcohol begins humbly: grains of corn, oats, or wheat are crushed, drowned in water, simmered in enormous steel vats until starches surrender and sugars emerge. Then the yeasts — those tireless creatures, *Saccharomyces cerevisiae* — begin their ancient work, turning sweetness into ethyl alcohol and a sigh of carbon dioxide.

Fermentation, however poetic, is messy. It leaves behind a confetti of molecular rubbish that must be lifted away. And so begins the ascent through heat: rectification, distillation — the heated mash boiling, the alcohol-water mixture (an azeotrope, if you wish to impress someone) rising upward, leaving the heavy, lumbering molecules below. Again and again the spirit climbs the steps inside the huge column made of steel, something essential distilled from something ordinary.

The finest alcohol, they say, begins life as a failed French wine — redeemed, like a character in a nineteenth-century novel, through fire and transformation into the base of cognac. Whiskey, on the other hand, is content to remain rustic: those pretty advertisements with the copper stills and short little spouts do not show you the fusel oils drifting contentedly in the mix, “responsible,” as marketing insists, for whiskey’s unforgettable aroma (Unforgettable indeed).

And lurking at the bottom of this ladder of spirits is technical alcohol — synthetic, eager, and dangerous. It appears in premixed cocktails and cheap liquors sold in countries politely labeled “developing,” though what’s developing there is often limited to corruption and leaders with a hobbyist interest in immortality. Technical alcohol may contain methanol or benzene — small, eager molecules that no amount of wishful distillation can cleanly remove.

Meanwhile, in the more fortunate parts of the world, modern rectification columns stretch thirty meters into the air, layered inside with steel platforms where distillation repeats until

the spirit emerges pure, crystalline, nearly innocent. That alcohol goes on to become *Campari*, *Aperol*, *Cointreau*, *Absolut* — each dressed up in herbs or oak or citrus, but all sharing the same secret backbone: a perfectly washed, perfectly made spirit from grain or grapes. Everything else is costume.

But let us return to your plums, steeping patiently in their stainless-steel waiting room.

After three days, the vodka has stolen their color — a tender, rosé blush — and inhaled their fragrance. Now strain this newborn infusion into another steel pot: first through a colander lined with several layers of cheesecloth, then through an optional glass filter directly into the bottles awaiting their destiny. The fruit, now pale and ghostly, can be discarded or turned into rustic plum paste.

And here is the trick: no sugar. The plums have offered their sweetness freely. The only rule — and it deserves to be carved somewhere in your kitchen — is never let fruit or herbs linger in the vodka for longer than a few days. Beyond that threshold lies compote. And your infusion should whisper of summer, not shout of syrup.

Could you cut the plums open to intensify the ruby depth? Of course. But then you must accept the penance: cloudiness, sediment, the need for a vacuum pump (water or oil), an Erlenmeyer flask, and proper glass filters. A laboratory for a drink — charming, if you love that sort of thing.

Magnificent infusions can also be coaxed from sea buckthorn and chocolate mint; from cherries paired with bitter herbs like thyme or St. John's wort; from young walnuts and marjoram. Whatever marriage of flavor you attempt, I promise your homemade infusion will outshine most fortified spirits on the shelves — cleaner, truer, made from real fruit and real alcohol rather than from industrial shortcuts.

Only a few commercial creations deserve to be mentioned in the same breath: the immortal *Campari* of *Gaspare Campari*; the vermouths of *Martini & Rossi*; *Aperol* of the *Barbieri* brothers; and the French *Cointreau*, born from several varieties of orange in Saint-Barthélemy-d'Anjou.

Let us bow to their makers — and then return to our own quiet alchemy.

Dry Meats and Fruits

This chapter is about insurance — culinary insurance of the most ancient kind. Long before banks printed guarantees or lawyers notarized promises, people trusted in salt, sun, wind, and time to secure their future. A well-made stash of dried meat or fruit was a quiet pact with the universe: *whatever storms arrive, we will have something delicious to carry us through.*

Here, then, are three deceptively simple techniques—small miracles, really—that give you not only handsome table snacks but also provisions worthy of a long journey. Food for the road, food for the mountains, food for the days when the world feels a little too sharp and you want something made by your own hands, infused with your own patience.

Another delight: both *pastarma* and *fruit leather* are scandalously overpriced in stores. They cost ten times more than their humble ingredients, and yet somehow taste like they were made on autopilot. Make them yourself and they become something else entirely—clean, fragrant, tactile in a way industrial food never is. They carry the clarity of your spices, the honesty of your fruit, and that unmistakable signature of purity that only home can give.

True, you'll need a bit of equipment. A stock pot large enough to look slightly absurd in a domestic kitchen. Some hooks, some twine, a bag of salt the size of a small child. But isn't that the first step toward mastery in any craft? One day you buy a single tool; the next you realize you've quietly apprenticed yourself to an ancient tradition that people once trusted with their very survival.

And all of a sudden, you're not just preserving meat or fruit — you're preserving a sliver of summer, a breath of orchard air, a small edible promise that something good awaits in the quieter months ahead.

Pork *Pastarma* (aka *Pastirma* or *Basturma*)

Can you make at home something that resembles a tender *prosciutto crudo* or a slice of beautifully cured pork belly? Yes. Yes, you can. And it's far less intimidating than it appears at first glance.

The process does take a couple of weeks — ideally in autumn, when the air cools and slows all the wrong kinds of bacteria — but the actual work is delightfully minimal. What you get in the end is fresh, supple meat, nothing like the tired, oversalted hams languishing behind the glass at most supermarket counters. And unlike commercial charcuterie, your *pastarma* won't contain unnecessary fat, sodium nitrite (the very thing that gives industrial meats their suspiciously cheerful pink glow), or monosodium glutamate. Instead, we'll coax inexpensive pork into becoming one of the most elegant wine snacks imaginable — meant to sit proudly alongside olives, cheeses, and a loaf of warm bread.

You'll want the softest, most tender pork you can find — those two long muscles running along each side of the spinal column, sold in Costco under the name *pork center loin*. This is

not a moment for half measures: buy eight to ten kilos at once. You're committing to a project of character. While you're there, pick up a large bag of salt. Ordinary, medium-coarse, non-iodized salt. Plenty of it. You'll also need a large stainless-steel pot — 15 to 20 liters — with a tight lid, a sharp knife, and oceans of paper towels.

1. Salting

With your sharpest knife, trim away every trace of membrane and fat — left on the meat, these bits lend off-flavors no amount of spice can disguise. Halve each section to create clean pieces about 30–40 cm long and roughly 8 cm thick. Make 10–15 shallow cross-cuts in each piece; think of them as little doorways through which salt and spices will later wander inward.

Cover the bottom of your pot with a 2–3 cm layer of salt. Lay the pork pieces on this snowy bed and bury them completely — about 5 kilograms of salt will disappear into this stage, but don't bother weighing anything. Salt is the great equalizer: it will extract excess moisture, silence any surface bacteria, and firm the meat without invading its soul. Whatever remains will be washed away later. Seal the pot with its lid and place it in the refrigerator for three days. The temperature is non-negotiable: 4°C (39–40°F). The vessel: stainless steel only.

2. Washing

After three days, the meat will look almost unchanged — but firmer, as though it has gained resolve. Rinse it under cold running water several times to remove excess salt, then soak it in a pot of clean cold water for 4–5 hours, changing the water once or twice. If you skip this step, your final *pastarma* will taste like the Dead Sea.

Pat the meat absolutely dry with paper towels, then wrap each piece in fresh towels again and press them lightly. An easy trick: arrange the wrapped pieces in a stainless-steel sink in two layers, set a half-filled pot of water on top, and let gravity do the rest for 3–5 hours. Every last droplet will escape through the cuts you made earlier.

3. Spice Mix and the Final Rite of Hanging

Pierce each piece with a thin knife about 4 cm from one end and thread a loop of cotton kitchen twine — or better, butcher's twine — through the hole. Tie the loop securely; this is the lifeline from which your meat will hang.

The hooks themselves can be suspended from a wooden beam in the garage or basement. Spread old newspapers beneath them — the meat will drip a fragrant, spice-tinted liquid as it dries, and newspapers are wonderfully unpretentious custodians of such things.

Now for the spice paste.

Put on rubber gloves unless you want your hands perfumed for several days. In a wide pot or bowl, mix your chosen spices with crushed garlic, a bit of salt and sugar, and enough water or beet juice to form a thick, heavy paste — the texture of an obstinate wall compound. It must cling, not slide. Add half a cup or so of vodka or cognac for sterilization. Belt-and-suspenders, as the saying goes.

Which spices? Whichever call to you. Ideally those that hail from lands where spice is a birthright: India, Vietnam, Spain, Indonesia. I often order from a brand called *Rani* on Amazon — fresh, bright, and unapologetically aromatic.

You'll need, unavoidably:

- Paprika (Rani Paprika, *Deggi Mirch*, low heat, 300 g) — Kashmiri paprika is what gives *pastarma* its color, its fragrance, its unmistakable dusk-red glow.
- Turmeric (Rani Turmeric, *Haldi*, root powder, 100 g) — among other virtues, it's a fierce natural antiseptic.
- Ground fenugreek (Rani Fenugreek, *Methi*, 300 g) — the ancient backbone of sausages, cured meats, and anything meant to hang proudly in cool air.
- Cumin (Rani Cumin powder, 100 g).
- Garlic (2 whole heads, peeled and mashed into a paste) — its sugars tenderize the meat and coax the spices deep inside. If you don't have the time or patience, dried garlic will do; the spice gods will forgive you.
- Rice or all-purpose flour (about 100 g) — not for taste, but as a glue, the quiet architect of structure.
- Salt (1–2 tbsp).
- Sugar (1–2 tbsp).
- Vodka or cognac (half a cup) — to keep mold at arm's length. Not today, mold. Not today.

Optional but deeply satisfying:

- Rani Curry Powder Mild Natural 10-Spice Blend (100 g).
- Beet juice — made by simmering two large beets cut into matchsticks with a cup of water and a spoonful of vinegar; it gives the meat a dark ruby aura worthy of an Armenian grandmother's approval.
- Prepared horseradish (a 200 g jar), which wakes the spice blend with a quiet winter bite.

Now hang your pork on hooks and coat each piece in the spice paste — thickly, deliberately — until every surface is sealed in a fragrant armor, a cocoon three to five millimeters deep. Wet your gloved hands and smooth the paste downward, as if tucking in a child for winter. The texture should be even, almost sculptural.

And then: the vigil. The meat must hang for 12 to 14 days. A garage in late autumn or winter is ideal — chilly, still, and blessedly free of insects. **Cover the pieces loosely with cheesecloth; consider it a respectful veil against wandering flies.**

If a blush of mold appears on the outside, don't panic. *Pastarma* has seen worse. You'll shave the spice crust off later anyway.

When the cocoons finally dry and the pieces feel firm to the touch, cut them down and wrap them in layers of paper towels. In the refrigerator, they'll keep for a couple of months; even at room temperature, two good weeks — long enough for a road trip, a mountain trek, or a slow, contemplative drive along the coast.

And when you serve it, slice it thin — *paper thin*. *Pastarma* rewards delicacy. It is, after all, meat transformed into memory: a small miracle coaxed out of salt, patience, and time.

Turkey Jerky

If you've ever wondered whether it's possible to make truly delicious turkey jerky at home — the kind that tastes like a road trip through Utah but without the mystery additives — the answer is yes, emphatically yes. You will, however, need two things: a rather opinionated marinade and a dehydrator that looks suspiciously like a small industrial appliance.

Start with **two medium turkey breasts** — about **four kilos** altogether. Slice them into half-centimeter strips; think of them as ribbons destined for a better life.

Now build them a marinade worthy of devotion.

You'll need:

- Soy sauce (2 cups, 400 ml)
- Worcestershire sauce (1 cup, 200 ml)
- Brown sugar (1 cup, 200 g)

Optional, but transformative:

- One orange, halved and squeezed — because even jerky deserves a little sunlight.
- Paprika (Rani Paprika, *Deggi Mirch*, low heat (1 tbsp)
- Ground fenugreek (Rani Fenugreek, *Methi*, 1 tbsp)
- Garlic (5–10 cloves), smashed with the side of your knife like a debt collector with a gentle heart.

Once the sugar melts into the dark, fragrant pool of sauces, pour the marinade into a stainless pot and slide in the turkey. Give everything a slow, meditative stir, as though tucking the meat in for an overnight rest. Refrigerate for 24 hours. (Twelve will do in an emergency — but really, where are we rushing?)

Turn the meat every so often; marinades appreciate company.

After its long night, lift the pot and overturn it into a colander. The marinade has now fulfilled its purpose; you can let it go. Pat the turkey strips dry with paper towels — the way you'd blot tears off the face of someone setting off on a long journey.

Now comes the grown-up equipment: a **10-tray food dehydrator**, preferably the stainless-steel **Septree** model from Amazon — an appliance so sturdy it looks like it should have a serial number and a union rep. Lay the turkey strips across the trays in a single airy layer; give each piece its own space, like guests at a party who haven't been introduced yet.

Set the machine to full blast — **145–155°F (63–68°C)** — and let it run for at least four hours, possibly six. The test for doneness is humble but foolproof: take the thickest piece and bend it in half. If it snaps and reveals pale fibers inside, your jerky has transcended.

Eat it warm, ideally standing over the counter. Whatever survives the first wave of grazing can be stored in the refrigerator, though experience suggests it won't stay there long.

Turkey jerky is a disappearing act — a delicious one.

Fruit Leather, or the Art of Saving Summer

Long before refrigerators, freezer bags, and well-lit supermarket aisles, people had only one reliable way to bargain with time: they dried things. Sunshine, wind, patience — that was the ancient machinery of preservation. And among all the inventions born of necessity, few are as quietly miraculous as **fruit leather**: ripe fruit, cooked down to its essence, pressed thin, and left to dry until it becomes a supple, tart, beautifully concentrated memory of summer.

Even today, fruit can be spread out in its simplest form — just puréed, no sugar, no fat — and dried into soft, deep-colored sheets that still hold more than 50% of their moisture. A kind of edible parchment. A traveler's talisman. A child's treasure. A cook's secret weapon.

But the true masterwork of this craft is **lavashak** — the ancient Persian snack whose lineage stretches back thousands of years. Lavashak (Persian: لواشک) is a sour-sweet fruit leather made from plums, apricots, pomegranates, or whatever the orchard happened to offer that season. The fruit is simmered down into a heavy, fragrant mass; salted just enough to wake it up; pressed through a sieve; smoothed into a glossy film two or three millimeters thick; and dried until it cools, firms, and finally transforms into something that feels half like candy and half like history.

Lavashak of Plums or Apricots

I wouldn't recommend buying a fruit leather at open-air markets. You can never know which plums went into the cauldron, where the fruit was dried (on a dusty rooftop, perhaps, in the company of flies?), nor what mysterious extras were tossed in for color or weight.

And why rely on someone else's fruit leather when you have, on our own California acres, an orchard studded with extraordinary plums and apricots — the living legacy of the late *Floyd Zaiger*?

Raise your hat for a moment; the man deserves it. *Zaiger* was a visionary plant geneticist, the father of elegant stone-fruit hybrids — the *pluot* and *aprium* (plum-apricot), and the wonderfully whimsical *pluerry* (plum-cherry). He worked not far from here, in the Central Valley, where apricots ripen in May and June, and where July arrives in slow tides of burgundy and gold plums, their skins glowing with honeyed, translucent light.

So — take **20 kilograms** of good burgundy plums (*Santa Rosa* or *Hollywood* are perfect). You can mix in apricots, too; lavashak welcomes personal taste. Sort the fruit, pile it into a large **15–20 liter stainless-steel stockpot**, and wash it twice. Pour in **two cups of white wine**, bring everything to a boil, and let the fruit simmer gently for about 30 minutes. Then turn off the heat, cover the pot, and leave it overnight.

This is where the stockpot becomes a kind of benevolent sorcerer: by morning it will have quietly transformed the fruit into a soft, yielding purée — one of the many advantages of large pots over dainty saucepans. (Remember our stock-making lessons? Same principle.)

When the mixture cools, press it through a stainless-steel sieve or colander set over a second pot. Discard the skins and stones. You should end up with **12–13 kilograms** of plum purée — and this is the number we'll base all further proportions on.

Now add **2–4 kilograms** of sugar (brown cane sugar is best, but any will do). Sugar softens the acidity of plums, gives the purée a syrupy body, and makes the final lavashak silky. It also kills bacteria — all sugars are potent antimicrobial agents, remember?

Next comes **300–500 grams of apple pectin** (*Hoosier Hill Farm* is great; Amazon is full of options). Nothing mysterious about pectin: it's just a natural gelling polysaccharide made from apples or citrus. Add a cup of **lemon juice**, too — pectin dissolves beautifully in an acidic environment, since it's essentially chains of galacturonic acid.

Warm the fruit-sugar-pectin mixture almost to a simmer over low heat, stirring with a wide wooden spatula. The pale pectin clumps will slowly melt, and the mass will become glossy and uniform. As soon as the first bubbles appear, turn off the heat. Leave the pot uncovered for a couple of hours so some moisture can escape, then cover it and let it rest until morning.

Now for the drying chamber — the **10-Tray Food Dehydrator Machine**. Don't agonize over brands: simply order the stainless-steel **Septree** model on Amazon. It is an admirable contraption, essentially a well-built steel cabinet endowed with a heater and a fan.

Unlike jerky, plum purée cannot be spread directly on the metal racks, so you'll need **silicone dehydrator mats with raised edges** (Bright Kitchen Dehydrator Sheets — add

about ten to your cart). Using a small ladle or spatula, spread the purée over each mat in a **5-millimeter-thick layer**.

Slide the trays into the dehydrator and select the fruit-drying mode: **135°F (57°C) for 15 hours**. If after 15 hours the lavashak still feels tacky, give it another **4–5 hours**. Once dry, the sheets will peel effortlessly from the silicone mats. Dust them lightly with powdered sugar and roll them up.

Store your lavashak in a cool place or in the refrigerator. It travels magnificently — by plane, by car, by ship — and at home it's the perfect companion to tea. Believe me: it is far superior to jam or marmalade. It is summer, captured and saved, unrolling itself slice by slice.

Green Tea, Oolongs, and the Many Shades of “Red” Tea

The tea tree, *Camellia sinensis*, springs from East Asia and almost certainly once clung to the misty, forested slopes of northern Burma and southwestern China. Tea and wine sit atop the twin peaks of two great civilizations — Chinese and European — the latter carrying forward the inheritance of ancient Greece and Rome. Each culture spent centuries perfecting its chosen elixir, selecting superior cultivars and inventing ever more refined methods to coax depth and nuance from simple leaves or grapes.

Wine we’ve already examined at leisure; now it’s time to turn to the other summit — the long, fragrant story of tea.

Every kind of tea, from green to oolong to the so-called “red tea” the West calls black, was invented in China over the span of the last two millennia. The Chinese also bred nearly all the cultivars of the tea plant now grown worldwide. During the Han dynasty (2nd century BCE – 2nd century CE), tea seems to have been used mostly as medicine — a bitter decoction of leaves boiled with a pinch of salt. By the golden age of the Tang (7th–9th centuries), tea had transformed into a beverage — first sipped at the imperial court and in monasteries, then at roadside inns and in private homes. In the 8th century, *Lu Yu* wrote his celebrated *Classic of Tea* (*Cha Jing*). At the time, tea was usually stored as compact bricks, which were pounded into powder before brewing.

Under the Song dynasty (10th–13th centuries), loose-leaf tea came into fashion, as did powdered tea whisked with hot water into a pale, frothy drink — and tea drinking blossomed into an elegant ritual that the Japanese later adopted and refined.

China’s tea culture dimmed in the 13th century with the Mongol conquest, when many artistic and scholarly traditions were disrupted. Only in the Ming era (14th–17th centuries) did tea return to prominence, but in a different form: the Chinese switched entirely to loose-leaf tea, brewed simply in hot water — predominantly green tea. This was the tea that Portuguese and English merchants encountered when they finally reached the Middle Kingdom in the 16th century. And as all people of taste do, they very quickly wanted some for themselves.

So, what distinguishes green tea, oolong, and black (or rather, “red”) tea? **Fermentation — or more precisely, oxidation.**

Freshly picked tea leaves can be dried rapidly at high temperature and packed as is — that is *green tea*.

Or they can be spread out on bamboo trays, allowed to wilt slightly until the cell membranes soften, and left for a time so *polyphenol oxidase* — an enzyme abundant on the leaf surface — can begin its quiet internal work. The leaves will remain green, but their chemistry deepens. They are then dried gently and rolled into large olive-green pearls. These are *oolongs* (烏龍, *wǔlóng*), a broad and marvelously varied family.

Or — one can let polyphenol oxidase run the full course. The leaves darken as oxidation and ambient air work their alchemy; afterward they are thoroughly roasted and only at the very end fully dried. This is *Chinese red tea*, though in the West we insist on calling it black.

The adventurous tale of how tea leapt from China to Europe is inseparable from the British East India Company, founded in 1600. Until the mid-19th century, China held a strict monopoly: tea could be bought **only** there. In 1711 the Company established a trading factory — a “hong” — in Canton (modern Guangzhou, which we’ve already visited in our chapter on Cantonese cuisine). Initially tea was purchased with silver; but as silver famously ran out in Britain, it was exchanged instead for opium grown on Company plantations in India.

The Chinese, understandably, resisted — but the Company ignored imperial bans and continued smuggling opium in astonishing quantities, about 900 tons a year, using the profits to purchase more tea.

By 1838 illegal imports had climbed to 1400 tons, and the Qing government imposed the death penalty for contraband. Cantonese officials even raided the British factory and destroyed a massive cache of opium — prompting Britain to go to war with China. Thus began the Opium Wars (1839–1842, 1856–1860), after which the British Empire secured, among other things, its own island at the mouth of the Pearl River: Hong Kong.

Meanwhile Britain needed a new tea supply. The Royal Horticultural Society dispatched a botanist — *Robert Fortune* — on a clandestine mission to steal tea seeds and seedlings from China. (Sharing valuable cultivars was out of the question.) By 1851, the first plantation in the hills of Darjeeling was established; soon tea spread throughout mountainous regions of British India — in Assam to the northeast, Nilgiri in the south, and on the island of Ceylon (now Sri Lanka). The island had originally planned to focus on coffee, but a fungal blight wiped out all the trees, forcing an urgent pivot to tea.

By 1887, production in Britain’s own colonies surpassed Chinese imports. Fast clipper ships carried tea to London at astonishing speed: the journey from Canton took just three to four months, even less from India. After the opening of the Suez Canal in 1869, shipping time — and cost — plummeted; tea grew cheaper, sales doubled within fifteen years, and by 1870 Twinings began blending Indian and Ceylon teas into the classic English mixtures *English Breakfast*, *Irish Breakfast*, and *Prince of Wales*.

In 1889, Sir *Thomas Lipton*, a self-made Scotsman who had once sought his fortune in America, launched an ambitious campaign to popularize his tea on the British market — largely by selling the dust and sweepings of his Ceylon plantations in convenient little bags. And so, in a matter of decades, tea became not just a luxury but one of the everyday emblems of the British Empire.

How to Brew Green Tea and Chinese Oolongs

Brewing tea properly means obeying a few simple rules and giving the process the small measure of care it deserves. First things first: pick up a couple of large jugs of **distilled water** at the supermarket. In fact, I'd urge you to use distilled water for everything delicate and refined — tea, your homemade infusions, broths, even consommés. There's nothing more discouraging than splurging on a beautiful green tea or a pristine fillet of sturgeon only to drown their flavor with hard tap water. And tap water often carries traces of organic compounds — phenol, benzene — that sail straight through household filters as if they were on holiday.

For boiling, you'll want a simple electric kettle with a stainless-steel interior, and for brewing, a lightweight one-liter teapot made of lab-grade borosilicate glass. (Tea can be brewed in just about anything — even a saucepan in a pinch — but good water and good leaves are non-negotiable.)

For a one-liter pot, measure out a heaping tablespoon of oolong — about 12 to 15 grams — and pour boiling water directly over the leaves. But whatever you do, **don't cover the pot with a lid**.

Modern cultivars such as *Jin Xuan* (pronounced *jin syüan* — the beloved “milk oolong”) or *Jade Tieguanyin* green tea are wonderfully resilient: they welcome a full, rolling boil. What they will not forgive is being suffocated under a lid, which traps steam and flattens all the delicate aromatics that make them special in the first place.

Let the tea steep for five to ten minutes, unhurried and uncovered — and that's it. You can drink it straight away.

Green tea rewards patience, not ceremony.

The Best Green Teas and Chinese Oolongs

Today, some of the finest green teas in the world grow on the mist-wrapped slopes of *Taiwan*, and just across the strait in *Anxi*, a tea county in China's Fujian province. If you're just beginning to explore this small universe of leaves, start with two contrasting oolong cultivars — one island-born, one firmly rooted in the mainland:

- *Alishan Jin Xuan* (金萱, also known as TTES #12 or #27), Supreme Grade (\$100–120/kg). A Taiwanese cultivar from the high mountains of Alishan, Jin Xuan is a winter-picked, barely fermented, low-temperature-dried oolong with the soft, unmistakable aroma that earned it the nickname *milk oolong*. Taiwanese cultivars are typically labeled with TTES numbers, but the name itself, *jin xuan*, translates to “golden lily,” which captures its character far better than any code number. Whenever possible, seek out Alishan teas from their source — local vendors in Taiwan or their online storefronts.

- *Anxi Tieguanyin (安溪铁观音), Supreme Grade (\$80–100/kg)*. Anxi teas sit closer to the green-tea end of the spectrum: fermentation is minimal, the style crisp and lively. The finest grade is *Jade Tieguanyin* — “铁观音,” the *Iron Goddess of Mercy* — called “jade” because it is dried gently at low heat and keeps its brilliant emerald color. Tieguanyin is grown both in Taiwan and on the mainland, but when you have a choice, choose mainland Anxi. If you are ever lucky enough to visit the tea markets there, buy it directly from the growers.

These two teas are the perfect introduction — order small amounts for tasting from sellers like *CA_Factoryshop on eBay*, and you’ll immediately sense how wildly different “oolong” can be. Below are a few more worthy varieties. I leave their names in English; it will make your online searches much easier.

Chinese tea, of course, is its own vast scholarship. Harvests come in winter, spring, summer, and autumn — and among them, *spring teas*, picked in May (the *li xia* season), are the most delicate, while winter harvests are the rarest. And processing! The methods alone read like a fusion of alchemy and engineering: drying in shade or under sun, freeze-drying, vacuum dehydration, chemical reagents, infrared treatments, drying cabinets, microwaves, heat pumps — a whole toolbox of ways to coax complexity from a leaf.

One can talk endlessly about terroir, humidity, tradition, innovation — it’s all as intricate as wine, though the vocabulary is far more exotic. Yet with tea, the joy isn’t only in the science. Tea plantations themselves are breathtaking places: high ridgelines wrapped in fog, terraces climbing toward the sky, rows of glossy shrubs rippling like green silk under the wind.

And all of it — the craft, the climate, the centuries — somehow ends up in your cup.

Taiwan

Qingxin 青心 (#17) — the name translates, beautifully and almost literally, as “green heart.” This high-mountain cultivar is one of Taiwan’s quiet triumphs: a leaf whose ancestry traces back to Fujian plants brought over in the 18th and 19th centuries, and whose character depends on restraint. Qingxin needs only the gentlest fermentation and the most delicate drying. Treat it well, and it rewards you with a cup that tastes like the island’s own high-elevation winds — cool, floral, and astonishingly pure.

Anxi, Mainland China

Tieguanyin 铁观音 (tiěguānyīn) — a tea wrapped in legend, as all worthy Chinese teas seem to be. The story goes that a poor farmer named Wei Qin tended a weathered stone statue of the bodhisattva Guanyin, bringing her offerings of tea each day. One night, she appeared to him in a dream and revealed a miraculous tea tree growing out of a cliffside. The next morning, Wei Qin found the very plant she had shown him, and — depending on which

storyteller you trust — either an imperial envoy or an enlightened monk helped him carry its fame across the empire.

Classic Tieguanyin is light, floral, and golden. When processed into *Jade Tieguanyin*, the color shifts toward green and the flavor sharpens into something bright and almost crystalline — a modern invention, surprisingly, born in the 1990s, which by Chinese standards was essentially *yesterday*.

But if you come across *Muzha Tieguanyin* (木柵鐵觀音), you are holding the opposite: a traditional style shaped not only by drying but also by a careful roast. The result is deeper, more expressive, touched with a toasted nut character, and shading in color toward the red-tea family. A cup of *Muzha Tieguanyin* feels like the warm echo of an older China — bold, fragrant, and unmistakably its own.

How to Brew Indian Black Tea

To begin, it helps to acknowledge a mildly impolite truth: what we call *Indian* tea is, historically speaking, Chinese tea grown on British plantations. Don't believe the romantic fables. The British, with their usual mixture of tenacity and bureaucracy, simply turned India into a vast experimental garden for *Camellia sinensis* — and to their credit, they did it thoroughly. The result was Darjeeling: a black tea so ethereal that even purists in Fujian grudgingly nod in approval.

I'm fond of *Earl Grey*, perfumed with the essential oil of bergamot (*Citrus bergamia*), that citrus note so bright it almost hums. I'm equally taken with *Imperial Blend*, a stately mixture of Darjeeling and Sri Lankan leaves (the latter still proudly labeled *Ceylon*), rounded out with the tender, downy **flowery tips** from the mountain shrubs of Assam — tips kissed, again, with a touch of bergamot.

Indian single-origin teas don't use the Taiwanese numbering system; instead, they rely on an alphabet soup of abbreviations. Really, you only need to remember a few things:

- Packages marked *D* (*Dust*) or *B* (*Broken*): reject immediately. This is sweepings, not tea.
- Look for *FOP* (*Flowery Orange Pekoe*) — whole, twisted upper leaves with some unopened buds mixed in.
- And the rule of thumb: the more letters you see stacked in front of FOP, the better the tea.

The “Orange” here has nothing to do with citrus; it refers to the *House of Orange*, whose Dutch traders supplied tea to the princely courts long before the British muscled in. The aristocratic *SFTGFOP*, often shortened — with a straight face — to *silver tips*, is nothing but buds. That's what you want.

Brewing red tea (what Westerners call black tea) is not so different from brewing oolong.

First, buy **distilled water** in large jugs. Please don't sabotage a fine tea — or a fine sturgeon, for that matter — with hard tap water laced with trace amounts of phenol or benzene that slip through household filters undisturbed.

You'll need:

- a basic electric kettle lined with stainless steel;
- a one-liter teapot of thin laboratory glass.

Measure **4–5 teaspoons of black tea** into the pot, pour over boiling water, and — unlike with green teas and delicate oolongs — **do put the lid on**. Let it steep for about **five minutes**. That's all. A clean, forthright cup, brisk as a British morning and aromatic as a Darjeeling hillside.

Addenda

1 Saturday Pizza Dough by *Ken Forkish*

- Bulk fermentation: 2 hours
- Divide, shape and cover dough: 10 minutes
- Second fermentation: 6 hours

Dough schedule:

Mix the dough at 9 AM, knead it at 9:20 AM, shape it into dough balls at 11 AM, make pizza between 5 PM and 9 PM. For next-day pizza, refrigerate the dough balls 4 hours after they are made up, then leave them out at room temperature for 1 hour before making pizza.

Measure and combine the ingredients:

Using your digital scale, measure 350 grams of 95-degree water into your 6-quart dough tub. Measure 13 grams of fine sea salt, add it to the water, and stir or swish it around in the tub until it is dissolved. Measure 1.5 grams of instant dried yeast. Add the yeast to the water, let it rest there for a minute to hydrate, then swish it around until it's dissolved. Add 500 grams of flour to the water-salt-yeast mixture.

Mix the dough:

Mix by hand, first by stirring your hand around inside the dough tub to integrate the flour, water, salt, and yeast into a single mass of dough. Then using a pincerlike grip with your thumb and forefinger, squeeze big chunks of dough, tightening your grip to cut through the dough. Do this repeatedly, working through the entire mass of dough. With your other hand, turn the tub while you're mixing to give your active hand a good angle of attack. Then fold the dough back into a unified mass. Continue for just 30 seconds to 1 minute. The target dough temperature at the end of the mix is 80 degrees; use your probe thermometer to check it.

Knead and rise:

Let the dough rest for 20 minutes, then knead it on a work surface with a very light dusting of flour for about 30 seconds to 1 minute. The skin of the dough should be very smooth. Place the dough ball seam side down in the lightly oiled dough tub. Cover with a tight-fitting lid. Hold the dough for 2 hours at room temperature (assuming 70 to 74 degrees Fahrenheit) for the first rise. This timeline is flexible, so if you need to do this after 1 hour or 1–2 hours, don't stress, just make up your dough balls a little early and add the difference in time to the next stage.

Shape the dough:

Moderately flour a work surface about 2 feet wide. With floured hands, gently ease the dough out of the tub. With your hands still floured, pick up the dough and ease it back down onto the work surface in a somewhat even shape. Dust the entire top of the dough with flour, then cut it into 3 or 5 equal-sized pieces, depending on the style of pizza. Use your scale to get evenly sized dough balls. Shape each piece of dough into a medium-tight round, working gently and being careful not to tear the dough.

Second fermentation:

Place the dough balls on lightly floured dinner plates or a baking sheet, leaving space between them to allow for expansion. Lightly flour the tops and cover airtight with plastic wrap, and let rest at room temperature for 6 hours for the second fermentation. Alternatively, you can rest the dough balls for 4 hours at room temperature, and then refrigerate to hold for up to the next evening.

Make pizza:

Without refrigeration, the dough balls can be used anytime in the 4 hours following the second fermentation. If you refrigerated the dough balls, let them come to room temperature for an hour while you preheat the oven and prepare your toppings.

Use a heavy metal sheet pre-heated at 500°F for best results.

Ingredients:

- Makes 3 regular or 5 thin-crust dough balls
- 1-1/2 cups water (350 grams at about 32–35°C)
- 2-1/2 teaspoons fine sea salt (13 grams)
- 3/4 of 1/2 teaspoon instant dried yeast (1–1.5 grams)
- Scant 4 cups white flour, preferably Caputo “00” red label (500 grams)

2 Blueprints for Feasts: Calm Instructions for Chaotic Kitchens

There is a quiet, almost meditative genre of writing — the kind meant not to be read in an armchair but to lie flat on a counter, waiting for your hands. Printable work instructions, humble but indispensable, the sort that keep a large dinner from unraveling into delightful but unmanageable bedlam.

In my laboratories — the ones I ran, organized, and steered through countless experiments — the day often began with such sheets. They were the still point in a swirl of glassware, equations, and hurried inspiration. Order distilled onto paper.

And in the kitchen, their purpose is much the same. When you're cooking for many people and the clock seems to misbehave, running faster than reason, these step-by-step guides quietly hold the center. They keep you from chasing paragraphs, let your attention rest on the simmering pot, the waiting board, the rhythm of the work.

A feast comes together not in prose but in gestures — measured, repeated, patient. These pages won't hurry you or contradict you. They will simply stand beside you, the way a good lab protocol always does, steadying your hand as you build something beautiful.

2.1 Lamb Leg with Persian Pilaf

Serves 8–10. Medium difficulty. Total time: about 5 hours.

Begin the night before:

Nestle two modest lamb legs (frozen works just fine) into a large stainless-steel stockpot and give them an overnight brine. You remember the formula: **1 liter of water, 1 cup of salt (200 g), 150 g of brown sugar, and a couple of garlic heads sliced in half**. Bring the mixture to a boil, top it up with 4–5 liters of cold water, and let the lamb steep in this gentle mineral bath until morning.

In the morning, locate the joint:

Find the spot where the shank meets the thigh and make a circular incision with a small, sharp knife. Slip the blade into the joint and — with quiet determination — separate shank from leg. (Or skip the surgery altogether and buy pre-cut Australian lamb at Costco.)

Divide and season:

Cut the lamb into three pieces, roughly a kilo each (two thighs separately and the two shanks together). Coat each piece generously with thick **Chinese oyster sauce** (*Lee Kum Kee Panda Brand Oyster Flavored Sauce*), add **5–10 crushed garlic cloves**, and tuck in a **couple sprigs of thyme** — or, even better, **3–4 stalks of lemongrass** bruised with a kitchen mallet.

The double wrapping — non-negotiable:

Tear off a generous sheet of baking parchment and wrap each lamb parcel tightly. This step is essential: parchment keeps lamb from drying out in the oven. But we're not done yet. Now you need six enormous sheets of heavy-duty foil (*Reynolds Heavy Duty, 18 × 50 inch*). Place each parchment-wrapped piece onto a foil sheet and wrap as tightly as if preparing it for interplanetary travel — no steam, no juice may escape. Repeat with a second layer of foil. Arrange the three metallic cocoons on a baking sheet lined with foil and slide them into a 340°F (170°C) oven for 1.5 hours. Then reduce to 270°F (130°C) and continue roasting another 3-4 hours. Turn off the oven, let the bundles cool slightly so you don't scorch your fingers, and slice the lamb into portions when you're ready.

While the lamb transforms, begin your rice ritual:

Pour about **1 kg of basmati** into a large pot filled with 6–7 liters of fiercely boiling salted water (4–5 tablespoons salt). Stir often with a wooden spatula to keep the grains floating free instead of sinking and sticking. Cook 10–11 minutes.

Drain the rice in a wide colander.

Now take a broad, heavy-bottomed pot with a snug lid. Film the bottom with a little **vegetable oil**. Transfer the drained rice — do not pack it down. Set the pot over medium heat, then low, for 30–40 minutes. Steam will escape steadily. To prevent condensation dripping back onto the rice, cover the pot with a clean cotton towel and place the lid on top, with the towel's corners flipped upward for safety.

Meanwhile, build the jeweled topping:

Melt **100–200 g of butter** and let it gently warm **half a cup of raisins**, a **cup of apricots** cut into quarters, and — if you have some — **half a cup of shelled pistachios**. Finish with a **pinch of precious Iranian saffron**.

Pour this fragrant mixture over the rice, then add the sliced lamb — but without any accumulated juices or fat; they would cloud the perfume of the basmati.

Fold gently with a wooden spatula. Serve immediately, while the saffron still glows and the steam still whispers upward.

Wine Pairing: Cabernet Sauvignon, Geyser Peak, Sonoma — or Petite Sirah, Stone Field Winery, Alexander Valley.

2.2 Lamb Leg with Roasted Potatoes

Serves 8–10. Medium difficulty. Total time: 5–6 hours.

Begin the night before:

Set two small lamb legs (frozen is fine, as long as the lamb is young and mild) into a large stainless-steel stockpot for an overnight brine. You know the drill: **1 liter of water, 1 cup of salt (200 g), 150 g of brown sugar, and a couple of garlic heads** sliced in half. Bring it all to a boil, top up with 4–5 liters of cold water, and let the lamb rest in this mineral bath until morning.

In the morning, locate the joint:

Find where the shank meets the thigh and make a clean circular incision with a small, sharp knife. Slip the blade into the joint and — patiently, gently — separate shank from thigh. (Or skip the whole anatomical exercise and buy pre-cut Australian lamb from Costco.)

Divide and season:

Cut the lamb into three pieces, roughly a kilo each (two thighs separately and the two shanks together). Coat each one generously with thick **Chinese oyster sauce** (*Lee Kum Kee Panda Brand Oyster Flavored Sauce*), add **5–10 crushed garlic cloves** and a **couple sprigs of thyme** — or, even better, **3–4 stalks of lemongrass** lightly bruised with a kitchen mallet.

Wrap everything — twice:

Tear off large sheets of baking parchment and wrap each lamb portion tightly. This matters: parchment prevents the lamb from drying out in the oven. Now the armor: six wide pieces of heavy-duty foil (*Reynolds Heavy Duty, 18 × 50 inch*). Place each parchment-wrapped parcel onto a sheet of foil and wrap it as tightly as human hands can manage — no steam or juice should escape. Wrap each piece again in a second layer. Arrange the three dense cocoons on a foil-lined baking sheet and slide them into a 340°F (170°C) oven for 1.5 hours. Then drop the temperature to 270°F (130°C) and continue roasting another 2.5 hours. Remove the tray from the oven, let the lamb cool a little so you don't scorch your hands, and slice into smaller portions. Keep the oven on.

Prepare the potatoes:

Peel **2–3 kilograms of white or pink potatoes**. Or use a couple bags of tiny new potatoes — they don't need peeling or cutting. Just wash them, trim any rough spots, and remove the eyes. Larger potatoes can be halved.

Combine lamb and potatoes for the final bake:

Remove the lamb from its foil and parchment and transfer it — along with its rendered juices (probably a couple of cups) — into a deep roasting pan or a stainless-steel tray with high sides. Add the potatoes and sprinkle a little salt over them. Seal the tray tightly with foil and return it to the oven for another 1.5 hours at 340°F (170°C).

Finish under high heat:

By now the lamb will be meltingly tender but not dry, and the potatoes will have absorbed its savory juices. In the last minutes, remove the foil and let everything brown: 10 minutes at full blast 500°F (260°C) or simply under the broiler.

For a crisp, shiny crust on the lamb:

Mix **2 tablespoons honey** with **2 tablespoons balsamic** or **5% apple cider vinegar**, then whisk in a **couple tablespoons of vegetable oil**. Brush this mixture over the lamb about 10 minutes before finishing under high heat.

Optional Side Dish:

In a serving bowl, mix **½ liter of sour cream** with **1 kg finely chopped small cucumbers**, the **juice of half a lemon**, and a **handful of chopped dill**. Sprinkle with a **pinch of saffron**. A perfect counterpoint to the lamb.

Wine Pairing: Cabernet Sauvignon, Geyser Peak, Sonoma — or Petite Sirah, Stone Field Winery, Alexander Valley.

2.3 Duck (or Turkey) Legs in Plum Sauce with Basmati Rice

Serves 8. Simple and reliable. Total time — 4 hours.

Choose your bird:

You can use **8–10 duck legs with skin**, or **4 turkey legs** cut at the knee joint into two pieces each, or even **4–5 turkey necks**. First thaw them, then coat every piece in a thick layer of **Chinese oyster sauce** (*Lee Kum Kee Panda Brand Oyster Flavored Sauce*). You'll need about 1 cup. Arrange everything in a stainless-steel pot with a lid and let the bird marinate overnight in the refrigerator.

Brown the legs:

The next day, transfer the legs and whatever marinade clings to them into a glass or ceramic roasting dish with high sides. Add a couple tablespoons of vegetable oil to the bottom. Preheat the oven to 475°F (246°C) and roast the bird for 40–50 minutes, until the fat renders and the skin turns crisp and golden.

Make the onion base:

Meanwhile, finely chop **4–5 large onions** and sauté them in vegetable oil until lightly caramelized.

Build the sauce:

Remove the roasting dish from the oven and let it cool slightly. Pour in **2–3 cups of white wine**, add the sautéed onions, and throw in a **dozen halved, pitted plums**. Return the dish to the oven at 325°F (160°C) — low enough to avoid scorching, hot enough to coax everything into a mellow, fragrant sauce. Let it go for 2 hours, during which you may safely forget about it.

Prepare the rice:

Pour **1 kilogram of basmati** into a large pot of vigorously boiling salted water (5–6 liters of water with 4–5 tablespoons of salt). Stir often with a wooden spatula so grains don't settle and stick.

After 10–11 minutes, drain the rice through a wide colander set in the sink.

Now take a broad stainless-steel pot with a thick bottom and a well-fitting lid. Add a little **vegetable oil** to the bottom — just enough to prevent sticking. Transfer the hot, drained rice into the pot, but do not pack it down.

Warm it first over medium heat, then over very low heat for 30–40 minutes. Steam will steadily escape from under the lid. To keep condensation from dripping back onto the rice, tuck a small cotton towel under the lid and fold the edges upward to keep them away from the flame.

Assemble and serve:

When the rice is ready, fluff it gently and move it onto a wide serving platter or a deep ceramic tray. Arrange the braised bird on top and spoon over all the onion-plum sauce. Serve immediately.

Set out a little soy sauce on the side — some guests may want an extra hint of salt with their basmati.

What to serve alongside: sliced peaches, a tomato salad, or whatever the season currently smiles upon.

Wine pairing: a dense, golden *Chardonnay* from *Carneros* or *Russian River Valley* — but please, don't chill it into numbness.

